

BEING A FIELD MANUAL FOR THE LIVING

BLOOD & GRIT

A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF THE HAUNTED
FRONTIER

THE PLAYER'S BOOK

Revised & Expanded · Compiled in the Territories · Edition of 1885 · Version 2.17

Most rules herein are adapted from Pathfinder Second Edition, with some unique rules & systems of its own





"We came west to be made new, and found instead that the country was older than newness, older than God, and had been waiting a long while in the quiet for company."

— FROM THE BURNED JOURNAL OF ELIZA HART, SURVEYOR



*"Keep your powder dry, your salt close, and your accounts with the dark paid up.
The country settles every debt in the end."*

— A SAYING COMMON TO THE TRAIL, AUTHOR UNKNOWN



Blood & Grit · The Player's Book · Version 2.17 · First Complete Edition

Contents

What you will find in this book, and the order of it.

This is the Player's Book. It holds everything a soul needs to make a character and keep them breathing — the dice, the callings, the guns, and the rules of fear. Secrets meant for the one who runs the game are kept elsewhere, in the Keeper's Book, and are no business of yours.

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I. The Country

What manner of world this is, and what waits beneath it.

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Come west. The handbills say it plain: land for the breaking, silver for the digging, cattle for the driving, and room — room past counting, under a sky so wide it makes a man feel newly made. This is a game of that country and the people who dare it: drovers and widows, deserters and physicians, gun-hands and gamblers, ordinary souls out of money, out of luck, or out of options, riding into the biggest country there is to win something back from it.

Blood and Grit is a game of the American West — the mud and the marrow of it true to life, the weather honest, the work brutal, the coffee worse. You will keep your powder dry and your horse fed. You will learn what a winter costs, and what a bank costs, and which of the two is the more honest robbery. And now and again, at the far edge of the firelight, you may notice — as the people of that country have noticed for a very long time — that the silence out on the long grass is not quite the silence of empty land.

The Look of the World

Day is for labor and for travel — long, hot, dangerous, and mostly mundane. Men die of infected scratches and bad water far more often than of anything stranger. The work is cattle and rail and rock, the pay is thin, and the law is wherever the nearest honest man happens to be standing.

But the Territories are a patchwork of failing things. Cattle towns swollen on credit and gone to rot when the railroad chose another valley. Mining camps that dug too deep and woke too much. Missions where the bells still ring at dusk though no hand pulls the rope. Homesteads sunk to their windowsills in dust, the families inside listening to something walk the roof at

night and telling the children it is only the wind. The sun goes down early behind the ranges, and the nights are very long, and it is in the night that the country remembers itself.

When This Is — the Year of 1885

The default frame is the mid-1880s, a closing door of a decade. The great buffalo herds are all but slaughtered off; the open range is being strung with wire; the railroads have stitched the continent and unstitched a hundred ways of living. The Indian Wars are mostly behind, their ending bitter — the nations of the Plains and the desert forced onto reservations whose borders shrink each treaty. Geronimo is still at large in the Sierra Madre; he will surrender the next year. The country is being made *modern*, and modernity here means barbed wire, the company store, the boarding school, and the surveyor's chain. Set your stories against this, and the horror beneath will have something true to grow from.

The Three Truths

And here, before you go a page further, the truth the handbills leave out. They will tell you the frontier is empty. They are wrong, and the wrongness of it is the whole of this game. The land between the last church and the first ocean is not empty — it is *occupied*. The horror of this game is not that monsters exist. The horror is that the world was never arranged for your comfort, and has only now begun to show you so. Everything in this book grows from three plain ideas. Hold them in mind and the rest will follow.

- **Knowing costs.** The more you understand of what moves beneath the dust, the more it understands of you. Wisdom in this country is a wound that does not close.
- **Survival is the victory.** There is no saving the world here, no chosen one, no last battle that sets things right. There is only the next winter, the next town, the next morning you wake up still yourself.

— **The land is old and indifferent.** What hunts you does not hate you. You are weather to it, or weeds. This is worse than malice. Malice can be bargained with.



"The map-makers leave the bad country white and call it unsurveyed. The people who lived here before us have a name for it. They do not say it after dark, and neither, after a season out here, will you."

— MARGINALIA, THE ALMANAC OF THE BITTERROOT SURVEY



On Tone — for Everyone at the Table

This is a game about fear, hardship, mortality, and the dark places of history and the mind. It is meant to disturb. It is **not** meant to harm the real people playing it.

Before your first session, talk plainly together about what you want from the game and what you would rather leave out. Agree on lines you will not cross and veils you will draw across. Anyone may, at any time and without explaining, ask to pause, skip, or rewind a scene. A frightening game is only worth playing among people who feel safe playing it.

The history of the West was, for a great many real people, already a horror without any need of monsters. *Blood and Grit* does not pretend otherwise. Treat that history, and the peoples who lived and suffered it, with more care than you treat the things with teeth. See the guidance on the First Peoples in Chapter IV before you bring them to your table.

II. How the Game Is Played

The dice, the checks, and the long odds of staying alive.

One person at the table is the Keeper. They describe the world, play every soul who is not a player's own, and decide what the rules cannot. Everyone else plays a single character — a living person trying to last another day. The Keeper sets the scene; you say what your character does; the dice settle what is uncertain. That is the whole loop, repeated until the story ends or you do.

A Word on the Rules

Every rule in this book — the core roll, the four degrees of success, abilities and saves, actions and conditions, and all the rest — is **mostly adapted from Pathfinder Second Edition**, reskinned for the haunted frontier — though this book adds some unique rules and systems of its own, the gun rules of Chapter XI chief among them. If a question is not answered in these pages, the Pathfinder 2E rule is the rule, and the Keeper has the final word besides. Players who know that system will find their footing at once; players who do not need carry nothing but this book.

The Core Roll

When an action's outcome is in doubt and failure is interesting, roll a twenty-sided die (the d20), add the relevant numbers, and compare the total to a target. Meet or beat the target and you succeed.

The **ability modifier** comes from whichever of your six attributes best fits the task.

Proficiency is the catch-all term for the training you bring. For a skill, it is your level plus a proficiency bonus — +2 if you are *trained*, +4 *expert*, +6 *master* — once you are trained in it. For attacks it is your level, adjusted by your Calling's rank; for saves, your Calling's own progression. Both stand on your Calling's table in Chapter V, and both are reckoned in Chapter XIV. The **Difficulty Class** (DC) is the number to beat, set by the Keeper or by the Defense of whatever you are trying to harm.

Difficulty at a Glance

The Task	DC	Example
Trivial	10	Kick in a rotten door
Easy	13	Calm a skittish horse
Average	15	Pick a strongbox lock; track a man over a day old
Hard	18	Climb a sheer canyon wall in rain
Very Hard	20	Out-draw a known shootist
Punishing	25	Read a dead tongue
Beyond	30	Set a bone by lantern in a storm without waking the patient

Degrees of Success

Most checks simply pass or fail. But many moments in this country reward — and punish — by *how far* you cleared the mark. When it matters, the Keeper reads your result against four degrees, after the manner of the gun rules in Chapter XI:

- **Critical Success.** You beat the DC by 10 or more, *or* you meet it and the die shows a natural 20. Fortune turns: extra grace, double benefit, or a clean grievous blow.
- **Success.** You meet or beat the DC. The thing is done.
- **Failure.** You fall short. The thing is not done, and the world moves on without you.
- **Critical Failure.** You miss the DC by 10 or more, *or* you fail and the die shows a natural 1. Something goes wrong beyond mere absence — a gun fouls, a lie is caught, a rope parts.

A natural 20 always shifts your result one step better; a natural 1 always shifts it one step worse. Thus a 20 can turn failure to success, and a 1 can turn success to disaster. The country humbles the sure.

Checks, Saves, and Opposed Rolls

A **check** measures whether you can *do* a thing: shoot, climb, lie, doctor a wound, recall a half-buried legend. A **saving throw** measures whether you can *withstand* one: poison, a blast, a terror that would unseat the mind. There are three saves — **Fortitude** (enduring the body's ruin), **Reflex** (dodging swift harm), and **Will** (holding the mind together). When two souls strain against each other — a grip, a stare-down, a chase — both roll and the higher total wins; this is an **opposed roll**, with ties going to the one already holding what is contested.

Taking Your Time

When there is no pressure and failure costs only minutes, the Keeper may let you **take 10** — treat the die as a flat ten — rather than tempt fate. When there is all the time in the world and failure carries no penalty worse than starting over, you may **take 20**, as though you had rolled until you succeeded; it consumes twenty times as long. You may never take 10 or 20 with a gun in your hand.

Grit

You are more than a column of numbers. You are stubborn. **Grit** is the measure of that stubbornness — a small pool of points, refreshed each session, that lets you bend a moment your way. Every character begins a session with **3 Grit**. You may spend one point, after seeing the result, to do any one of the following:

- Add 1d6 to a d20 roll you just made, perhaps turning a miss to a hit.
- Re-roll a single failed check, save, or attack, keeping the second result.
- Refuse to fall: when dropped to 0 Blood, stay conscious and on your feet for one more round.
- Steady your nerve: ignore the effect of a fright until the end of your next turn.
- Take a breath: convert a critical failure you just rolled into an ordinary failure, denying the worst of it.

Grit is the difference between people who die in the first reel and people whose names get remembered. Spend it. The Keeper may award a point mid-session for a deed of true courage, a moment of perfect character, or a line that makes the whole table go quiet.



*"The dice do not care for you. That is the only honest thing in the room.
Everything else at this table will lie to keep you breathing — including, in time,
yourself."*

— ATTRIBUTED TO A FARO DEALER IN LEADWATER, BEFORE THE FIRE



The Measures of Time

The rules in this book keep time at several scales, and it saves confusion to know which one a given rule means. From the smallest to the largest:

- **The Beat.** The smallest unit, used only in a fight. On your turn you have three Beats to spend — a Strike, a Stride, a reload, a shouted word. The full accounting lives in Chapter XI.
- **The Round.** In a fight, the few seconds in which every combatant takes one turn — six seconds, near enough. "Once per round" means once between your turns.
- **The Turn.** Your own slice of a round: your three Beats, and whatever reactions you are owed.
- **The Scene.** The basic unit of story — a single stretch of continuous action or talk in one place: a gunfight, a tense parley, a night's hard ride, the search of a haunted house. A scene runs from the moment a situation begins until it resolves and the table moves on. It might be two minutes of shooting or an hour of careful conversation; what matters is that it is one unbroken piece of business. Most abilities that recharge "once per scene" return when a new situation begins.
- **The Session.** One sitting at the table — an evening's play, however many scenes it holds. Abilities that reset "once per session" come back when you next gather. The session is the unit by which a table actually lives the story, and it usually ends at a natural stopping place.
- **Downtime.** The unhurried days or weeks between adventures — for healing, crafting, carousing, mending fences, and earning a living. The clock runs loose, and the Keeper narrates its passing.
- **The Arc.** A run of sessions telling one larger tale. A rare few effects ("for the rest of the arc") last this long; when one story closes and the next opens, the slate is wiped clean.

Scene vs. Session — the Short of It

A **scene** is one situation; a **session** is one evening of play. When an ability says "once per scene," ask only whether the situation has changed — a new fight, a new place, a new problem. If it has, the ability has recharged. "Once per session" is stingier: it returns only when you next sit down to play. As a rule of thumb: Beats and rounds are for the gunfight, the scene is for the situation, the session is for the evening, and downtime and the arc are for everything in between.

III. Making a Character

Eight steps from a blank page to a soul worth losing.



“A man out here is three things: what he was, what the country made him, and what he’ll do when the lamp goes out. Get all three on the page and you’ve got someone worth playing — and worth burying.”

— EB TUTTLE, TRAPPER



A character in this game is a person, not a hero. Build them to be wanted, haunted, indebted, or simply too poor to go home. The mechanics below give them flesh; the questions at the end give them a reason to ride out into the dark. Work down the list in order and you will have a finished character in the space of a single sitting.

Step	What You Do
1. Concept	Decide who this person was before the trouble found them.
2. Abilities	Generate the six numbers that define body and mind.
3. Origin	Choose where you come from; gain its gifts (Chapter IV).
4. Calling	Choose your trade and trade of trouble (Chapters V–VII).
5. Skills & Edges	Choose your trained skills; take your first Edge (Chapters VIII–IX).
6. Reckon Numbers	Work out Blood, Defense, saves, Nerve, and Grit.
7. Outfit	Spend starting coin on guns, gear, and a horse (Chapter X).

Step	What You Do
8. The Questions	Answer the four questions that make them real.

Step 2 — The Six Abilities

Every soul is measured along six lines. Three govern the body, three the spirit. From each score you derive a **modifier**, equal to the score minus ten, halved, and rounded down. A 10 or 11 gives +0; a 14 gives +2; a 7 gives -2. The modifier is what you actually add to rolls.

Ability	Governs	Used For
Strength (STR)	Muscle, brawn, brute labor	Melee blows, grappling, hauling, breaking
Dexterity (DEX)	Speed, aim, balance	Gunplay, dodging, riding, stealth, sleight
Constitution (CON)	Wind, gut, endurance	Blood total, Fortitude, disease, thirst
Wits (WIT)	Reason, learning, craft	Lore, medicine, repair, trained skills
Resolve (RES)	Composure, faith, instinct	Will, Nerve, noticing, survival, signs
Presence (PRE)	Bearing, voice, menace	Leading, lying, charming, intimidating

Generating the Scores

Choose one method with your Keeper's blessing. All three make a capable but mortal person — there are no demigods in the dust.

- **The Gamble (Rolled).** Roll four six-sided dice, drop the lowest, and total the rest. Do this six times and assign the results. Bold, and sometimes cruel — fitting for the country.
- **The Honest Array.** Assign these six numbers as you like: 15, 14, 13, 12, 10, 8. Fair and quick.

- **The Wager (Point-Buy).** Every score starts at 8. You have 27 points to raise them, costing more the higher you climb. Nothing may begin above 15 or below 8 by this method.

A Word on Modifiers

Score 8–9 gives –1. Score 10–11 gives +0. Score 12–13 gives +1. Score 14–15 gives +2. Score 16–17 gives +3. Score 18–19 gives +4. A starting human is unlikely to exceed 18 in any line, and should not. The exceptional belong to the things you hunt.

Step 6 — Reckoning Your Numbers

With Origin and Calling chosen, work out the figures you will lean on every session. Your Keeper will help; do it once and you will never forget.

Figure	How It Is Reckoned
Blood (Hit Points)	Your Calling's full Hit Die + CON modifier at 1st level; add a roll (or the average) of the Hit Die + CON each level after.
Defense (AC)	10 + DEX modifier + armor worn + any cover. See Conflict for how bullets treat armor.
Saves	Base from your Calling — a strong save is 2 plus half your level, a weak save a third of it, both rounding down — plus the keyed ability: Fortitude (CON), Reflex (DEX), Will (RES).
Attack	Your Calling's rank — Practiced (your level), Steady (level less 1), or Slight (level less 2, never below +0) — added to every attack roll along with the keyed ability. See Chapter XIV.
Nerve	RES score + your character level. The measure of how much horror your mind can bank before it breaks.

Figure	How It Is Reckoned
Grit	3, refreshed each session. Spend to bend fate (Chapter II).
Speed	30 feet on foot for most folk; a horse is faster and you will want one.

Step 8 — The Four Questions

Numbers do not bleed. Before you ride, answer these aloud at the table. Your Keeper will use your answers as hooks — and as bait.

- **What did you lose?** Everyone out here has lost something — land, kin, country, faith, a former self. Name it.
- **What have you seen?** You have already glimpsed something that does not belong. What was it, and have you told a living soul?
- **What is your vice?** Drink, the cards, laudanum, violence, the Word. It will comfort you and it will cost you.
- **What keeps you moving?** A debt, a grave to find, a person to reach, a sin to outrun. Survival needs a reason.

Step 9 — The Compass

A soul, out here, is read two ways — and both the dark and the divine are reading. The first measure is your **conscience**: how you treat others, from open-handed mercy to plain cruelty. The second is your **conduct**: how you hold to law, oath, and order, from the badge-keeper to the man who is a law unto himself. Set against each other, these two measures make your **Compass** — what older books call alignment — a rough fix on where a character stands. It is a description, not a leash; see the box below.

The Two Axes

Conscience runs Good – Neutral – Evil. The Good spend themselves for others; the Evil spend others for themselves; most folk fall between, decent enough until it costs them.

Conduct runs Lawful – Neutral – Chaotic. The Lawful keep to code, contract, and chain of command; the Chaotic keep to themselves and their own lights; the Neutral bend as the day demands. The nine points each wear a frontier face:

	Lawful	Neutral	Chaotic
Good	The Marshal's Heart	The Good Samaritan	The Free Rider
Neutral	The Letter of the Law	The Survivor	The Drifter's Whim
Evil	The Cattle Baron	The Self-Server	The Mad Dog

- **Lawful Good — the Marshal's Heart.** Honor and mercy together; the badge that means what it says, and would sooner take a bullet than break faith.
- **Neutral Good — the Good Samaritan.** Does right by folk, badge or no, law or no; kindness is the whole of the creed.
- **Chaotic Good — the Free Rider.** Unfenced and good-hearted; helps as conscience bids and damns the regulations doing it.
- **Lawful Neutral — the Letter of the Law.** Order above all — the judge, the company man, the soldier who follows orders he does not weigh.
- **True Neutral — the Survivor.** Takes the world as it comes; few causes and fewer crusades; sees to their own and lets the rest ride.
- **Chaotic Neutral — the Drifter's Whim.** Their own road and their own reasons; trusts no fence and no flag, and means no harm by it — usually.
- **Lawful Evil — the Cattle Baron.** Cruelty by contract and code; the tyrant who keeps his word to the letter and grinds you beneath it.

- **Neutral Evil — the Self-Server.** Whatever profits, by whatever means; loyal to no one living but himself.
- **Chaotic Evil — the Mad Dog.** Ruin for its own sake; the thing the frontier hangs first and asks after later.

Holy, Unholy, and the Unsanctified

The Compass is what a soul *is*; **sanctification** is what the unseen world has a *claim* on. Most living folk are **unsanctified** — neither blessed nor damned, whatever their sins. A soul given over to the divine — certain Callings of Faith at their height, a weapon truly consecrated, ground that has been hallowed — carries the **holy** quality. A soul given over to the Old Dark — by a Hexer's Bargain, a Cultist's Devotion, or a Mark grown deep (Chapter XII) — carries the **unholy** quality. The two cut across the line at one another: the Witch Hunter's *Sanctified Iron*, holy water, the Preacher's fire, a Patron's gifts — all strike hardest where they meet their opposite. A wicked man is not unholy until he has dealt with the dark; a kind one is not holy until something greater than him has laid a hand on his shoulder. The **Mark** is the road from the one to the other, and it runs downhill.

A Compass, Not a Cage

Your Compass describes how a character has lived, not how they must act. Play them as a person; the needle follows the deeds. A Keeper may move it after a true pattern of contrary acts — and the moving is rarely free, for the slide toward the Dark is measured in the **Mark** (Chapter XII), which has teeth. Most player-characters live in the Good-to-Neutral band; the three Evil corners are mostly the country's villains and its damned. Little in *Blood & Grit* hinges on the nine points directly — the dark and the divine care far more whether you are holy, unholy, or merely a frightened soul who has not yet decided which.

IV. Origins

Where you come from, and what it cost to leave.

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No one is born in the saddle. Before the trouble, before the trail, your character was someone — with a trade, a people, a place that has since burned or barred its door. Choose one Origin below. Each grants a lasting **Gift**: a bonus to a pair of abilities and a knack your past beat into you, and most a further **Boon** besides. None of it comes free — every Origin save the gentlest also lays a **Burden** on you, the price the past still charges. The number beside an ability is added to that score before you reckon its modifier.

The Drummer

A travelling seller of tonics, Bibles, futures, or lies, you have talked your way into a hundred parlors and out of nearly as many beatings. You believe in nothing you sell and everything you say. **Gift**: +2 PRE. You are trained in Persuade, and folk meeting you for the first time are inclined to hear you out before they decide to distrust you. **Boon**: you could sell sand in a drought — once per scene reroll a failed Persuade or Deceive, and in any town of size you can talk your way to a bed, a meal, or a line of credit on your word alone. **Burden**: a tongue that quick is seldom believed twice; once a lie or a tall tale of yours is found out, those who caught it take -2 to trust you for the rest of the affair, and word travels ahead of you.

The Fallen Gentry

Once there was a name, a house, an inheritance — and then a war, a debt, or a scandal took it all. You wear the manners still, threadbare as your coat, and they open doors your purse cannot. **Gift**: +1 WIT and +1 PRE. You are lettered, trained in Lore (Frontier or Occult, your choice), and move easily among people who believe themselves your betters. **Boon**: the old manners open doors a purse cannot — gain +2 on social checks among the wealthy, the

lettered, and the powerful, and you read rank, breeding, and the lie beneath a fine coat at a glance. **Burden:** the soft years left their mark; you take –1 on Fortitude saves against the plain hardships — hunger, exposure, hard labor — that those frontier-born endure without complaint.

The Freed

Born or sold into bondage, you took your own liberty or had it grudgingly granted, and you have walked west to be no man's property again. You carry a watchfulness that has saved your life more than once. **Gift:** +1 RES and +1 PRE. You gain a permanent +2 on checks to read a stranger's true intent, and on Will saves against being cowed. **Boon:** ropes, locks, and cages have never held you long — gain +2 to slip a bond or a confinement, and you are never quite cornered while any way out remains. **Burden:** badges and the men behind them have earned no trust from you; you take –1 on social checks to deal with lawmen, soldiers, and officials, who feel your wariness and return it.

The Gambler

You have made your living, and lost it, at the green-felt tables of a hundred towns, and learned to read a face for the truth it tries to hide. **Gift:** +1 PRE and +1 WIT. You are trained in Gamble and gain a permanent +2 on Sense Motive at any table. **Boon:** you keep a working peace with chance — once per session you may reroll a single d20 and keep the better result, the small luck a card-player learns to trust. **Burden:** the table keeps its hooks in you; when coin, cards, or a sure thing are laid before you, the Keeper may call for a Will save to walk away, and old gambling debts have a way of riding into town behind you. *A character of a Calling of Faith — most of all a **Preacher** or a **Padre** — may not take the Gambler background unless the Keeper rules the campaign allows it; a soul sworn to the pulpit has no business at the green table. This background grants only a knack; the Gambler Calling of Chapter V is the whole craft, and far more.*

The Homesteader

You broke sod that did not want breaking and buried more than one child under it. You know weather, livestock, and the particular patience of poverty. **Gift:** +1 CON and +1 RES. You begin trained in Survival and never go hungry where anything at all will grow. **Boon:** a full night's rest in a camp you have made restores you and each companion sheltering with you an extra 1d6 Blood, and your dogs and stock give warning before trouble arrives. **Burden:** the sod broke the wanderer in you — away from home or kin you take –1 on Initiative the first round of any fight, slow to credit that the worst has come again.

The Laborer

You laid rail, dug shafts, or drove spikes for wages that vanished at the company store. Perhaps your tongue is not the one spoken here. Your hands are ruined and reliable. **Gift:** +1 STR and +1 CON. You are trained in Repair, and treat any tool, however crude, as the right one for honest work. **Boon:** your ruined, reliable body shrugs off a hard day — gain +2 on Fortitude saves against fatigue, strain, and the wearing cold, and you can labor or march long past where softer men fold. **Burden:** these hands were made for the spike and the shovel, not the needle; you take –1 on checks of fine dexterity — sleight, lockwork, fuses, and the surgeon's delicate art.

The Outlaw

There is paper on you in at least one territory. Whether the charge was just is your own affair. You sleep light, draw fast, and trust the law to do you no favors. **Gift:** +1 DEX and +1 PRE. Once per session you may declare you have been somewhere before and know one useful, unsavory fact about it. **Boon:** the wrong sort know you and you them — gain +2 to deal with criminals, fences, and the hard cases of any town, and +2 to make a quick exit when the law takes a sudden interest. **Burden:** there is paper on you in at least one territory, and your face surfaces at the worst moments; lawmen and bounty men take note of you, and the Keeper may rule a warrant, a posse, or an old grudge has trailed you into town.

The Scout

You read the land like scripture, whether the country bore you or you simply spent your life learning its moods — a guide, a hunter, a wagon-pilot, an Army auxiliary. The newcomers need you and distrust you in turn, and you owe them little. **Gift:** +1 DEX and +1 RES. You are trained in Survival, ignore difficult ground afoot, and are never lost beneath an open sky. **Boon:** you read country at a glance — gain +2 on Notice to spot ambush, tracks, and lying-in-wait out of doors, and you are never surprised beneath the open sky. **Burden:** a life on the trail leaves you ill at ease behind walls; indoors and in close crowds you take –1 on Notice, the roof and the press of bodies sitting on you like a held breath. *If your Scout belongs to one of the First Peoples, read the guidance below before play.*

The Veteran

You served — blue or gray in the late war, or a hard hitch with the cavalry and infantry in the long campaigns that followed it across these plains. You know drill, the chain of command, the weight of a carbine, and exactly what a volley does to men. Some of it you are proud of. Some of it wakes you in the small hours. **Gift:** +1 CON and +1 STR. You are trained in **Athletics** or **Intimidate** at your choice, begin play with a service carbine or sidearm, and once per session may steady the line — you and each ally who can hear you shrug off fear for a round. **Boon:** drill is in your bones — once per scene reroll a failed Reflex save to take cover or hit the dirt, and you reload and clear a jam a half-beat faster than any green hand. **Burden:** some of it never left; the first time each session the sudden roar of gunfire or the touch of the uncanny finds you, make a Dread Check or be Shaken a round as the old war rises behind your eyes.

Came Back Wrong

You died — of fever, of lead, of cold, of something with no name — and then you did not stay dead. You remember the dark on the other side. It remembers you. (Begin play at Mark 1; see Chapter XII.) **Gift:** +1 CON and +1 RES. You no longer need to breathe to live and feel

cold and pain dimly — but you start one step along the Mark, and the uncanny notices its own. **Boon:** what came back with you does not die easy — once per session, when you would drop to 0 Blood you instead stay standing at 1 until the end of the round, and you need neither food nor sleep to go on, though you may rest if you wish. **Burden:** the dead do not forget you — the Old Dark notices you before any other, and the living sense without knowing why that something about you is wrong (–1 on first-impression checks with the breathing).



"My grandmother told me the land does not belong to us. We belong to it, and it has been lending us back to ourselves for a thousand winters. The newcomers think a paper changes that. The land has read no papers."

— RECORDED BY A MISSION TEACHER; THE SPEAKER ASKED THAT HER NAME BE KEPT



The First Peoples

West of the Mississippi, the country was never empty and never new. It was — and is — the home of nations older than any territory drawn on a map: among them the **Lakota, Dakota, and Nakota** of the northern plains; the **Cheyenne, Arapaho, Crow, Pawnee, and Osage**; the **Comanche, Kiowa, and Wichita** of the southern plains; the **Apache** peoples and the **Diné (Navajo)** of the desert southwest; the **Ute, Shoshone, Paiute, and Bannock** of the Great Basin; the **Nez Perce, Cayuse**, and the Plateau nations; the **Pueblo, Hopi, and Zuni** of the pueblos; and a hundred more, each with its own language, law, kinship, and faith. They are not one people, and never were.

By 1885 these nations have endured a generation of catastrophe not of their making: the slaughter of the buffalo, broken treaties, forced removal, military campaigns, epidemic disease, the reservation, and the boarding school that took the children to unmake their

tongue. This is the true horror against which the invented horror of this game is only a shadow. A character of the First Peoples is most likely a survivor of all of it — and a person, fully, before they are anything else.

Playing a Character of the First Peoples

If a player wishes to portray a character from one of these nations, the whole table owes the choice some care. A few plain rules of the road:

- **Avoid the worn lies.** No noble-savage, no bloodthirsty-savage, no vanishing-race elegy. These are propaganda, not character.
- **Be specific, not generic.** Choose a real nation and learn a little of its actual history, country, and circumstance in the 1880s. "Generic Indian" is a settler's invention; do not play it.
- **Honor lines and veils.** Real massacres, removals, and the boarding schools are matters a table may choose to handle gravely, glancingly, or not at all. Decide together, and never for shock.
- **Sacred is not a mechanic.** The Signs, the Mark, and the Old Rites of this book are the game's *invented* dark. Do not pin them to any real living religion, ceremony, or sacred object. If you want a faith-keeper, see the note in Chapter VI.
- **They are people first.** Give them families, humor, grudges, hopes, and an inner life — not mystic set-dressing for someone else's story.

When in doubt, the people whose history this is should be heard before the dice are. If no one at the table can speak to it with care, it is honorable to leave it to the Keeper's background and play someone else.

Mechanically, a First Peoples character chooses any Origin that fits their life — most often the **Scout** or **Homesteader**, but any may apply — and any Calling. Their nation, language, and history are written into the four

Questions, not bought with a stat. The country they know best is, after all, the one being taken.

The Mexican Frontier

The border did not cross these families; the border crossed them. Long before the territories were drawn, the land from Texas to California was **Mexico**, and before that New Spain — and the **Tejano**, **Californio**, and **Nuevomexicano** families who built the missions, ranchos, and towns of the Southwest did not vanish when the maps were redrawn in 1848. They remained: ranchers and *vaqueros* — the first cowboys, whose craft and very words (*lariat*, *lasso*, *rodeo*, *corral*, *chaps*, *buckaroo*) the Anglo cowhand later borrowed — alongside farmers, freighters, miners, priests, merchants, and laborers, on land their grandparents had worked for a hundred years.

By 1885 many find themselves strangers in their own country: old Spanish and Mexican land grants challenged or stolen outright in Anglo courts, the language of law turned against them, and a hard new color line drawn through towns their families founded. Some hold their ranchos still; some have lost everything to lawyers and lynch-law; some ride the border both ways, and a few have taken up the revolver to settle what the courts would not. They are Catholic, mostly, with a faith that keeps its own saints and its own dead close — no small thing on a haunted frontier.

Playing a Mexican Character

The same courtesy owed any real people applies here. A few plain rules of the road:

— **Avoid the worn lies.** No bandit-buffoon, no sleeping peon, no hot-blooded caricature. These are dime-novel propaganda, not character.

Playing a Mexican Character *(cont.)*

- **Be specific.** A Tejano ranching family near San Antonio, a Californio whose grant was swallowed after statehood, a Nuevomexicano from a village older than the United States — these are different lives. Choose one and learn a little of it.
- **Faith is a strength, not set-dressing.** Catholic devotion, the saints, the Day of the Dead, the village *curandera* — these can anchor a character against the dark without being reduced to mysticism.
- **Not a costume or an accent.** Give them family, faith, pride, and an inner life. Spanish belongs in their mouth naturally, never as comic seasoning.
- **The injustice is real history.** Stolen land grants, the lynchings, the slur "greaser," the color line — these happened. Use them with weight, by agreement, never for flavor.

As with the First Peoples, lines and veils are the table's to set together. When the history is someone's own, let them be heard before the dice are.

Mechanically, a Mexican character chooses any Origin and Calling that fits — the *vaquero* is a Drifter, Gunhand, or Marshal as readily as any Anglo, and the old ranching families field Homesteaders and Fallen Gentry alike. Their language, faith, and the grant the family is fighting to keep are written into the four Questions, not bought with a stat.

Black Westerners

The West was worked by Black hands from the first drive to the last spike, and the record is plainer than the dime novels ever admitted. Roughly **one trail hand in four** on the great cattle drives is Black or Mexican; the best bronc-riders and ropers in the business are known by name across three territories. Black men and women are freighters, blacksmiths, cooks, barbers, laundresses who own the building, homesteaders, mail carriers, and lawmen — a

deputy marshal riding out of Fort Smith into Indian Territory has brought in more wanted men than any other deputy in the Territory — thousands of them over his career — and every outlaw between the Arkansas and the Red knows his name. Four regiments of the regular Army — the **Ninth and Tenth Cavalry, the Twenty-Fourth and Twenty-Fifth Infantry** — are Black soldiers under mostly white officers, and the Plains nations who fought them named them the **Buffalo Soldiers**, which was meant as respect and was taken as such.

Most came under their own power and for their own reasons. When Reconstruction was abandoned in '77 and the old order came back wearing a sheet, tens of thousands left the South in the **Exodus of 1879** — walking, riding, and taking deck passage up the Mississippi for Kansas, which they had heard was free ground. They founded whole towns of their own: **Nicodemus** on the Kansas grass, and after it a string of Black towns across Kansas, Indian Territory, and Texas, each with its church and its school built before its saloon. What they found was freer, and it was not free: the color line came west on the same trains they did, sundown towns turned them out at dusk, and the law was a coin-flip. By 1885 the door is closing again — and they are still here, still building, and no longer asking anyone's leave.

Playing a Black Character

The same courtesy owed any real people applies here. A few plain rules of the road:

- **Avoid the worn lies.** No faithful retainer, no comic relief, no saintly sufferer, no character who exists to be endured against. These are minstrel-show inventions, not character.
- **Be specific.** An Exoduster homesteader proving up outside Nicodemus, a sergeant of the Tenth out of Fort Davis with fifteen years in, a trail hand on his sixth drive who is the best horseman in the outfit, a widow who owns the laundry and half the block — these are different lives. Choose one and learn a little of it.

Playing a Black Character *(cont.)*

- **Competence is the historical record.** Where a Black character is the best hand, the best shot, or the best doctor in the scene, that is not a favor being done — it is the ordinary case, and the table should play it as ordinary.
- **Community is the strength.** The church, the lodge, the school built first, the town that holds together — these anchor a character against the dark, and they are somewhere to come back to.
- **The injustice is real history.** Slavery, the Exodus, the color line, and the violence that enforced it all happened. Use them with weight, by agreement, and never for flavor or shock.

As with the First Peoples and the Mexican frontier, lines and veils are the table's to set together. When the history is someone's own, let them be heard before the dice are.

Mechanically, a Black character chooses any Origin and Calling. **The Freed** and **The Veteran** are the obvious roads and by no means the only ones — a great many were born free, and the frontier's Black Gunhands, Sawbones, Marshals, Preachers, and Prospectors are all a matter of record. Where they came from, who they left, and what they are proving up on go into the four Questions, not into a stat.

The Chinese on the Frontier

The hardest miles of the transcontinental railroad were built by Chinese labor, and the Central Pacific's own officers said so. At the peak of the work, **nine men in ten** on that grade were Chinese — better than ten thousand of them — cutting the Sierra tunnels by hand through granite at eight inches a day, hanging in baskets off the Cape Horn cliffs, setting nitroglycerin, and wintering under forty feet of snow in the sheds while avalanches took whole camps. When the rails met in '69 and the photograph was taken, not one of them

was asked to stand in it. Afterward they went where the work was: the quartz mines and the placer bars, the levees that made the delta farmland, the fisheries, the cigar benches, the laundries and restaurants and market gardens of every town on the coast and half the towns inland — and the cook tent of any cattle outfit shrewd enough to hire one, where the man feeding twelve hands is often the best-paid and least-replaceable soul in the crew. The herbalist with a shop full of drawers is a trained physician in a tradition two thousand years older than the one the Army surgeon studied, and the town generally works this out the first time somebody is dying.

The country's answer to all this was the law. The Page Act of '75 shut out the women; the **Exclusion Act of 1882** — three years back — shut the door outright, barred naturalization, and stranded a generation of men on the wrong side of an ocean from wives and children they send money to and may never see again. Where the law would not do it, mobs did: Los Angeles in '71, and this very year the coal camp at **Rock Springs**, where a wage dispute ended with the Chinese quarter burned and twenty-eight men dead. Against all of it they built their own civil order — the **district associations** that settle disputes, lend money, run the schools, bury the dead, and ship the bones home to be buried properly in the village. They are not guests here. They built the hardest miles of the road west, and they are owed for it.

Playing a Chinese Character

The same courtesy owed any real people applies here. A few plain rules of the road:

- **Avoid the worn lies.** No inscrutable mystic, no comic laundryman, no dispenser of ancient wisdom, no fortune-cookie speech, and no dialect played for laughs. These are stage inventions of the exclusion years, and they were built to justify it.

Playing a Chinese Character *(cont.)*

- **Be specific.** Nearly all came from a handful of districts in **Guangdong** — most from Toisan and the Sze Yup counties — and speak Cantonese, not "Chinese." They have a village, a family, a surname that means something, and a remittance going home every quarter. Choose the particulars.
- **Skill is a trade, not magic.** The herbalist's medicine is medicine; the railroad man's blasting is engineering; the merchant's ledger is capital. Do not turn any of it into mysticism, and do not hang the game's invented dark on Buddhist or Taoist practice — the same rule the First Peoples' section sets, for the same reason.
- **The associations are civil society.** The *huiguan* is a bank, a court, a hiring hall, and a burial society at once. A character with standing in one has resources; a character who has crossed one has a problem that a gun will not solve.
- **The injustice is real history.** The tax, the queue ordinances, the Exclusion Act, and the burnings all happened, and 1885 is the year of Rock Springs. Use them with weight, by agreement, never for flavor.

Lines and veils are the table's to set together. When the history is someone's own, let them be heard before the dice are.

Mechanically, a Chinese character chooses any Origin and Calling. **The Laborer** is the road most walked and is far from the only one — the **Sawbones** fits the herbalist tradition exactly, and the frontier's Chinese Prospectors, Gamblers, Drifters, and Bounty Hunters are all a matter of record. Their district, their family across the water, and what the remittance is for go into the four Questions, not into a stat.

V. Worldly Callings

The trades of the desperate, from first blood to last stand.

A Calling is what your character does when the talking stops — the trade by which they earn coin, enemies, and an early grave. Each advances over ten levels, the highest a mortal is likely to reach before the country collects its due. Your Calling sets your Hit Die (the dice you roll for Blood), your war-progression (Base Attack Bonus), your strong saves, and the features that make you dangerous.

This book groups the Callings by the well they draw from, across three chapters. The **worldly Callings** in this chapter — Gunhand, Drifter, Sawbones, Marshal, Prospector, Mountain Man, Bounty Hunter, and Gambler — live by iron, instinct, learning, law, luck, a hard eye for the unnatural, a quick hand on the wrong side of the law, and a cooler one at the card table. Those who draw on **faith** — Padre, Preacher, Shaman, Medicine Man, and the Witch Hunter — are gathered in Chapter VI. And those who walk with the **Old Dark** by pact, by craft, by deceit, or by devotion — Hexer, Witch, False Prophet, and Dark Cultist — are given Chapter VII, for such roads ask a toll the others do not.

*Read each table thus: **Attack** is your Calling's attack proficiency by level, read straight from its table, added to Strikes along with your keyed ability; **Fort/Ref/Will** are your save proficiencies by level, added to saves along with the keyed ability; **Features** are gained at the listed level. The number beside **Trained Skills** in the statline, plus your WIT modifier, is how many skills you begin trained in; you gain a skill increase at 3rd, 5th, 7th, and 9th level.*

Bounty Hunter

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Reflex, Will · Attack Practiced

Some come to the frontier to take what others carried; the Bounty Hunter comes for the men who took it. Manhunter, paper-collector, skip-chaser — call it what you like, the trade is the

same: find the soul the warrant names, be where he does not expect you, and bring him in before his friends or his nerve can turn the odds. Bounty men are not duelists and seldom heroes, but one who has lived past his third warrant has learned the only lessons that keep a man breathing — pick the moment, take your mark unready, and always, always know the way out with him in tow.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+1	+0	+2	+2	Bushwhack 1d6, Quick Hands
2	+2	+0	+3	+3	Road Sense
3	+3	+1	+3	+3	Edge, Trade
4	+4	+1	+4	+4	The Drop
5	+5	+1	+4	+4	Bushwhack 2d6, Getaway
6	+6	+2	+5	+5	—
7	+7	+2	+5	+5	Edge, Hard Ride
8	+8	+2	+6	+6	Bushwhack 3d6
9	+9	+3	+6	+6	Edge
10	+10	+3	+7	+7	Dead or Alive, Bushwhack 4d6, Trade Mastery

Bushwhack

Bringing a man in is not a fair fight, and you do not pretend otherwise. Once per turn, when you Strike a quarry who is unaware of you, who has not yet acted in the fight, or whom an ally threatens, deal the listed extra damage. The ambush is the whole of the art — a bounty man forced to trade blows in the open with a cornered killer has already made his mistake.

Quick Hands

Years of needing your iron — or your irons, the manacle kind — a half-second sooner than the other man. You draw, holster, reload, or snap on a cuff as part of another action rather than spending a Beat on it, and add +2 to the roll that decides who acts first. Lockpicks, knots, and a fugitive's hidden pockets answer to these hands as readily as a trigger does.

Road Sense

You have laid enough ambushes to know when you are walking into one. Gain +2 on Notice against traps, tails, and lying-in-wait, and you are never caught flat — you act in the first round of a fight even when surprise is called against you. The hunted set snares too.

The Drop

With a quarry dead to rights — your iron drawn, his not — you may Demoralize as a single Beat, and a man who yields comes along quiet, hands where you can see them. Against one who calls the bluff, your first Strike counts him as unaware. Dead or alive is his choosing; you are paid the same either way.

Getaway

The catch is only half done until you and your man are clear of his friends. Immediately after you Strike, take a prisoner, or break free, you may Step and then Stride for free; mounted, you may instead vault to the saddle and ride, prisoner and all.

Hard Ride

You and your horse have run down more men — and outrun more of their kin — than you can count. Your mounted Speed increases by 10 feet, you cross rough country a fleeing man must slow for, and once per scene you may close on a single quarry who thought he had lost you, or shake a pursuit of your own, given a moment's lead and a place to turn.

Dead or Alive

At 10th level your name is worth nearly as much as the paper you carry. Once per scene, a Bushwhack you land against an unready quarry is an automatic critical hit. And you are never truly cornered: declare a bolt-hole — a relay horse, a confederate, a lawman who owes you, a back trail only you know — and the Keeper will honor it, once, when all seems lost. A great many men have been promised to the rope, and you are the one who delivers them.



"Folks ask how I bring them in when faster men could not. I do not bring them in fast. I bring them in tired — a week of no fire, no sleep, no notion of where they are, until the open country has done my work for me and the iron is only the receipt."

— ATTRIBUTED TO THE BOUNTY MAN CALLED COLE RENNER, WHO ALWAYS COLLECTED

*Trades of the Bounty Hunter*

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

— **The Stalker.** You read a quarry's trail and habits and strike from where he never looks; your Bushwhack deals extra dice against a foe who has not yet acted. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, a perfect ambush against an unready quarry is an automatic critical that may end the chase before it starts.

Trades of the Bounty Hunter (cont.)

- **The Posse Boss.** You ride at the head of a hunting party, swear in hands to the chase, and may Demoralize a whole group at once. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, your name alone breaks lesser fugitives who know it — they scatter, surrender, or freeze.
- **The Trailsman.** You handle and run down mounts with ease, and ride harder than any man you hunt. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, you run a quarry to ground that no horse and no head start could have saved.

Drifter

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Save Reflex · Attack Steady

The Drifter belongs to no town and answers to no brand. Scout, tracker, horse-thief, bounty-man, or simply a soul who cannot stop moving — the Drifter survives by seeing first, striking once, and being elsewhere by dawn. They are the party's eyes on the trail and its knife in the dark.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+0	+2	+0	Sudden Strike +1d6, Pathfinder
2	+1	+0	+3	+0	Ghost
3	+2	+1	+3	+1	Edge, Evasion, Trail
4	+3	+1	+4	+1	—
5	+4	+1	+4	+1	Sudden Strike +2d6
6	+5	+2	+5	+2	—

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
7	+6	+2	+5	+2	Edge, Uncanny Step
8	+7	+2	+6	+2	—
9	+8	+3	+6	+3	Sudden Strike +3d6
10	+9	+3	+7	+3	Edge, Vanish, Trail Mastery

Sudden Strike

When you strike a foe who is unaware of you, or whom an ally is engaging (an Off-Guard target; see Conditions), you deal extra damage as shown — the patient violence of the ambush. The dice rise as you advance.

Pathfinder

You move at full speed through wilderness others must crawl through, leave a trail only the gifted can follow, and add your level to checks to track, forage, or find the way.

Ghost / Uncanny Step / Vanish

You learn to disappear. *Ghost* lets you hide even while briefly observed. *Uncanny Step* leaves no track on any surface. *Vanish* lets you drop from sight once per scene, as if the land itself closed over you — out here, perhaps it has.

Evasion

Your reflexes are inhuman. On a successful Reflex save against an effect that would harm an area — a blast, a cave-in, a sweep of fire — you take no harm at all rather than half. On a *critical* success, you also end your move in any open square adjacent to the danger.

Trails of the Drifter

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Ghost Trail.** Gain a bonus to Sneak and Hide, and you may Hide in cover even while observed. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, become wholly unseen for a round, striking from nowhere.
- **The Hard Trail.** Ignore the toll of harsh country, weather, and want; +2 Fortitude against the elements. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, shrug off the first wound or affliction that would lay you low.
- **The Hunter's Trail.** You never lose a trail and gain +2 against ambush and to read a quarry. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, study a foe a moment and learn the weakness that undoes it.

Gambler

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Reflex, Will · Attack Steady

Every town past the railhead has a green-felt table and a soul who lives by it. The Gambler reads people the way the Prospector reads rock — the tell, the bluff, the breaking nerve — and has made a working peace with chance that most folk only pray for. They are charming, watchful, and very hard to rattle, for anyone who has seen a year's wages turn on a single card has learned that the trick was never the card. The trick is knowing the odds — and knowing when to break them. Where the **Gambler background** of Chapter IV grants but a single knack of the green table, this Calling is the whole craft — a life given wholly over to chance, and to the bending of it.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+0	+2	+2	Fortune's Favor, Cardsharp
2	+1	+0	+3	+3	Hedge Your Bets
3	+2	+1	+3	+3	Edge, Game
4	+3	+1	+4	+4	Cold Deck
5	+4	+1	+4	+4	Ace in the Hole
6	+5	+2	+5	+5	—
7	+6	+2	+5	+5	Edge, Press Your Luck
8	+7	+2	+6	+6	Stack the Odds
9	+8	+3	+6	+6	Edge
10	+9	+3	+7	+7	The House Always Wins, Game Mastery

Fortune's Favor

Chance leans your way, and you have learned to lean back. Keep a pool of **Favor** equal to your PRE modifier + half your level (minimum 1), refreshed each dawn; you also recover 1 point whenever you stake something real on a genuine risk and let the dice fly. Spend a point to **reroll any one d20 you just rolled** and keep the better result, to add 1d6 to a check, or to force a foe to reroll a hit or a save made against you. Favor spent is gone whether the gamble pays or not — that is rather the point of it.

Cardsharp

You are trained in games of chance and the arts that bend them — palming, marking, dealing seconds, and reading a face for the truth it is trying to hide. Gain +2 on Deceive, sleight of hand, and Sense Motive at any table, and you know

at a glance whether a game is honest. In a crowd, your hands move quicker than a witness's eye.

Hedge Your Bets

You rarely lose it all at once. When you fail a check, you may spend a point of Favor to treat it as a success instead — but the Keeper names the price: a complication, a debt, a watching eye, a worse spot down the road. You win the hand. The game goes on.

Cold Deck

Once per scene, free of any cost, force a single reroll — your own, or that of a foe whose luck has run too good. And when you spend Favor to reroll, you may instead simply **take the dealt card**: treat the die as though it had come up an 11, no better and no worse, for the moments when steady is worth more than lucky.

Ace in the Hole

You are never quite as cornered as you look. Once per scene, produce something you "had ready all along" — a hideout derringer, a palmed knife, a marked card, a bribed dealer, a second key. And when you are reduced to 0 Blood, you may spend 3 Favor to come up at 1 instead and take an immediate action. The Gambler's oldest trick is not being dead when everyone else has folded.

Press Your Luck

Before you roll, you may **ante**: wager a point of Nerve or of Blood on the outcome. Succeed, and you win big — a critical success on a hit, an extra Beat on a skill, a boon the Keeper honors. Fail, and you lose the ante and the failure cuts deeper. The bolder the bet, the richer the pot the Keeper may allow.

Stack the Odds

Your luck spills onto those who stand with you. Once per round, free, grant an ally who can see you +1 to a roll; and you may spend your own Favor on their behalf, letting a companion reroll as though the luck were theirs.

The House Always Wins

At 10th level you have made chance a silent partner. Your Favor refreshes at the start of every scene rather than each dawn. And once per session you may **call the turn**: declare, before it is cast, that a single die — yours, or one thrown against you — comes up its best or its worst, a natural 20 or a natural 1, as though fate had dealt it from the bottom of the deck for you. The bill for such certainty always comes due. It simply does not come due tonight.



"I have lost more money than most men will ever see, and I will give you the secret of it free, since you won't believe me anyhow: the cards do not care. The cards never cared. You play the man, and the odds, and your own cold nerve — and you leave the praying to folks who like to lose."

— EULALIE "LUCKY" DEVEREAUX, WHO WAS NOT, IN THE END, LUCKY



Games of the Gambler

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

Games of the Gambler (cont.)

- **The Charmer.** Spend Favor on Deceive, Persuade, and reading a room, and gain a bonus at any table. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, bend a crowd or a single mark wholly to your play.
- **The Duelist.** Spend Favor to add luck to your Strikes and to turn a blow aside. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene in a duel, turn a foe's hit into a miss, or your miss into a killing crit.
- **The Mechanic.** Your Favor pool grows, and once per scene you may set a die to any face you please. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, stack fate entirely — take the better result on every roll for a round.

Gunhand

Hit Die d10 · Trained Skills 2 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Reflex · Attack Practiced

Some folk are simply faster than the rest, and have made their peace with what that means. The Gunhand is the gunfighter, the shootist, the hired iron — a person who has reduced the question of survival to who clears leather first. They are not brave so much as quick, and they know the difference even if no one else does. The Gunhand is built for the gun rules of Chapter XI; learn the Iron Code well.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+1	+2	+2	+0	Deadly Aim, Gunhand's Edge
2	+2	+3	+3	+0	Trick Shot
3	+3	+3	+3	+1	Edge, School
4	+4	+4	+4	+1	—

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
5	+5	+4	+4	+1	Lightning Hand
6	+6	+5	+5	+2	—
7	+7	+5	+5	+2	Edge
8	+8	+6	+6	+2	—
9	+9	+6	+6	+3	Edge
10	+10	+7	+7	+3	No Quarter, School Mastery

Deadly Aim

You may take a -2 penalty on a firearm attack to add $+4$ to its damage. The penalty and bonus both increase at 5th level ($-3 / +6$) and 9th ($-4 / +8$).

Gunhand's Edge

You gain a pool of **Edges** — sharp little tricks. Choose one combat Edge from Chapter IX at 1st level and at every odd level after. These are in addition to the Edges every character earns.

Trick Shot

Once per round, before rolling, you may declare a called shot — to disarm, to wound a limb, to shatter a lantern or a rope. Take -4 to the attack; on a hit, the Keeper grants the effect in place of, or alongside, reduced damage. Under the Iron Code (Chapter XI), a *critical* hit on a called shot grants the effect *and* full damage.

Lightning Hand

Your reflexes outrun thought. Drawing a holstered weapon costs no action (a free Interact), and you act before anyone you have not yet met in a fight unless they, too, have this knack. Once per fight you may take an extra Strike as a reaction the instant initiative is rolled.

No Quarter

When you drop a foe to 0 Blood or below with a firearm, you may immediately make one more attack against a different target within range, free of the Multiple Attack Penalty. There is no limit to how many times this may chain in a single round but your own luck.



"A pistol is an argument that ends the conversation. Most arguments out here were never worth starting, which is the one thing a fast man learns too late."

— MARSHAL T. COYLE, RETIRED IN BOTH SENSES OF THE WORD



Schools of the Gun

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Fanning Hand.** With a single-action revolver you may fan a second Strike each round at the Multiple Attack Penalty without spending an extra Beat. *Mastery (10th):* once each round, dropping a foe lets you immediately Strike another in range at no penalty.
- **The Fast Draw.** You always act first in a one-on-one draw, and your first Strike of a fight gains +1. *Mastery (10th):* the first shot you fire in a scene is a critical hit if it lands.
- **The Long Rifle.** Ignore the penalty at the first range increment, and Aim as a single Beat. *Mastery (10th):* a braced, aimed shot ignores cover and concealment and is an automatic critical against a foe who has not yet acted.

Marshal

Hit Die d10 · Trained Skills 4 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Practiced

Lawman, cavalry sergeant, wagon-boss, or self-appointed keeper of a town that never asked — the Marshal leads. Their gift is not the fast draw but the steady one, the voice that keeps frightened people pointed the right way when everything in them wants to run. A Marshal rarely dies alone.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+1	+2	+0	+2	Command, Reputation
2	+2	+3	+0	+3	Hold the Line
3	+3	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Oath
4	+4	+4	+1	+4	—
5	+5	+4	+1	+4	Unflinching
6	+6	+5	+2	+5	—
7	+7	+5	+2	+5	Edge
8	+8	+6	+2	+6	—
9	+9	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+10	+7	+3	+7	Last Stand, Oath Mastery

Command

As an action, bark an order. One ally within earshot may immediately take a single action — a shot, a move, a check — out of turn, gaining your PRE modifier as a bonus. Usable a number of times per scene equal to your PRE modifier (minimum 1).

Reputation

Your name carries. Add your level to checks to rally, deputize, requisition, or overawe, and choose at 1st level whether folk mostly fear you or trust you. Either opens doors; each closes others.

Hold the Line / Unflinching

Allies within sight of you gain +1 on saves against fear and the uncanny, rising to +2 at 5th level, when you yourself become immune to being Frightened. Courage, it turns out, is contagious — the only blessing in this book that is.

Last Stand

Once per session, when an ally within sight would drop to 0 Blood, you may shout them upright: they remain conscious and acting until the end of the fight or until struck again. Some Marshals have held a doorway with five dead men still standing at their word.



"I never asked to be followed. I only stood where the road forked and would not move, and after a while there were people standing behind me. That is the whole of leadership. That, and never letting them see you reckon the odds."

— FROM THE DEPOSITION OF A WAGON-BOSS, FORT RELIANCE



Oaths of Office

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

Oaths of Office (cont.)

- **The Lawman.** Your commands carry weight — a bonus to Demoralize and to rally — and you may deputize allies for a scene. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, your word stays a hand: a foe must lay down arms or stand frozen a round.
- **The Manhunter.** Name a quarry; gain bonuses to track, read, and strike them. *Mastery (10th):* your mark cannot shake you, and once per scene you land a decisive, fight-ending blow or capture against them.
- **The Shield.** You may intercept a blow meant for an ally at your side. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, become the only target the enemy may strike, or turn aside a killing blow aimed at another.

Mountain Man

Hit Die d10 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Practiced

Some men went up into the high country to trap beaver and never entirely came back down. The Mountain Man lives where the maps give out — the peaks, the deep timber, the snowbound passes — trapping, hunting, and reading a wilderness that kills the unready in an afternoon. He is hard as a hickory axe-handle, easy with a long rifle, and short on conversation, and he has seen things in the deep snow that he does not, as a rule, talk about. When something out of the dark comes down out of the hills, he is often the only soul who already knows its name.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+1	+2	+0	+2	Hawken Rifle, Dead Aim 1d6, Hard Country
2	+2	+3	+0	+3	Read Sign

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
3	+3	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Range
4	+4	+4	+1	+4	Skinner
5	+5	+4	+1	+4	Dead Aim 2d6
6	+6	+5	+2	+5	Iron Constitution
7	+7	+5	+2	+5	Edge, Mountain Sense
8	+8	+6	+2	+6	Unbroken
9	+9	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+10	+7	+3	+7	King of the High Country, Range Mastery

Hawken Rifle

The heavy plains rifle is your right arm. With a two-handed rifle you ignore the penalty at the first range increment, and the first reload each round costs no extra Beat. You keep your piece clean, charged, and to hand, and you do not miss the shots a lesser hand calls lucky.

Dead Aim

Spend a Beat to steady your rifle — this is the *Aim* action — and your next shot this turn deals the extra damage shown on a hit: **1d6** at 1st level, **2d6** at 5th, and **3d6** once you are King of the High Country. Patience, a good rest, and a held breath are worth more than any luck.

Hard Country

The wilderness is your parlor. You are never lost in wild country, you ignore natural difficult terrain — scree, deadfall, brush, snow — and a day's hunting or foraging feeds you and up to

four others. Cold, altitude, thirst, and hunger that would break other men, you simply endure.

Read Sign

Gain +2 to Survival and Notice to track and to read what passed — how many, how long ago, and whether it walked on two legs or something else. You leave little trail of your own: the DC to track *you* rises by 2, and you know when you are being followed.

Skinner

Spend a Beat to study a beast or an unnatural thing (Survival or Lore: Occult) and learn one weakness or trait the Keeper will honor. Against animals and the wild things of the dark you deal +1 **damage**, and you may harvest a kill — hide, fat, claw, tooth, gland — for coin, for trade, or for the makings of a remedy or a ward.

Iron Constitution

The mountains have been trying to kill you for years and have not managed it. Gain a bonus against cold, heat, thirst, hunger, poison, and disease, and once per scene you may reroll a failed Fortitude save. You heal a little faster than you have any right to.

Mountain Sense

You cannot be caught flat in the wild. You are never surprised out of doors, you act first in the opening round of any ambush you spring or spot, and predators give you a wide berth — they know a bigger one when they smell it.

Unbroken

You have seen what the high country hides in the deep snow, and naming it did not break you. Gain a bonus on Dread Checks in the wilderness, and you may spend a Beat to steady a companion who can

see you, lending them your nerve to face what is coming down out of the hills.

King of the High Country

At 10th level the wilderness is yours, and everything in it knows your step. Your Dead Aim rises to 3d6; while out of doors you gain a standing +1 to Defense and to all saves; and once per scene a single steadied rifle shot is an automatic critical against a living or unnatural quarry you have studied with Skinner. The mountain does not give up its king easily, and neither, in the end, do you.



"Folks down in the settlements think the wild is empty. I have wintered alone above the timberline with the wind screaming for three months, and I will tell you it is the most crowded place I know. Something up there counts every man who comes. I just learned to count back."

— ELI SIX-BEARS, TRAPPER, WHO CAME DOWN OUT OF THE BITTERROOTS ONE SPRING AND
WOULD NOT SAY WHY



Ranges of the Mountain Man

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

— **The Hermit.** You have gone native in the deep country and made a peace of sorts with what lives there: beasts will not harm you unbidden, you find shelter and forage anywhere, and you read the land's moods. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, call on the wild — a beast comes to your aid, a sudden storm covers your retreat, or the country itself turns a pursuer aside.

Ranges of the Mountain Man (cont.)

- **The Hunter.** Name a quarry as the Marshal marks a man, but for the beasts and monsters of the wild: gain bonuses to track, read, and damage it. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, a Dead Aim shot against your quarry strikes a killing blow that fells even a great beast.
- **The Trapper.** You set deadfalls, snares, and pit-traps swiftly and well; a trap on ground you have readied forces the unwary to save or be caught — Grabbed, Slowed, or wounded as the trap allows. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, a sprung trap is ruinous — the quarry, beast or man, is caught fast and badly hurt.

Prospector

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Reflex · Attack Steady

The Prospector came west for the one honest promise the country ever made: that what lies in the ground belongs to whoever is fool enough to dig it out. Part surveyor, part gambler, part blasting-man, they read rock and water and luck the way others read scripture — and they have learned, the hard way, that some seams were sealed for a reason, and that the deepest shafts open onto more than ore.



“We followed the vein down past where the air goes wrong, and there he sat in his rusted Spanish iron, four hundred years dead and still holding the box like he meant to keep it. We took the gold. I have wished, every night since, that we had not.”

— J. HALLORAN, TESTIMONY GIVEN AT THE WIDOW’S COMFORT INQUEST



Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+2	+2	+0	Pay Dirt, Powderman
2	+1	+3	+3	+0	Grubstake
3	+2	+3	+3	+1	Edge, Claim
4	+3	+4	+4	+1	Dowse, Field Inventions
5	+4	+4	+4	+1	Assayer's Eye
6	+5	+5	+5	+2	Demolitionist
7	+6	+5	+5	+2	Edge, Sapper
8	+7	+6	+6	+2	Overcharge
9	+8	+6	+6	+3	Edge
10	+9	+7	+7	+3	The Mother Lode, Claim Mastery

Pay Dirt

Luck is a muscle, and yours is overdeveloped. You have a pool of **Pay Dirt** equal to your WIT modifier + half your level (minimum 1), refreshed each dawn. Spend a point to add 1d6 to any check tied to searching, surviving, digging, or scrounging — or to declare a small fortunate find: a length of fuse, a sound timber for cover, a trickle of water, a glint of something useful in the dirt. The Keeper says how much it amounts to; you only ever guarantee that there is *something*.

Powderman

You handle blasting powder, dynamite, and raw nitro as easily as another handles a fork. Each dawn you prepare a number of **field charges** equal to your WIT modifier + half your level (minimum 2) — sticks, bottles, and the specialty devices you have learned to build. A

stick of dynamite deals **2d6 fire** in a 10-foot burst (basic Reflex, DC 10 + half your level + WIT), rising to 3d6 at 4th level, 4d6 at 7th, and 5d6 at 10th. You may shape or time any charge — shorten or stretch a fuse, narrow the burst to a line, or widen it by 5 feet at the cost of a die. Best of all, your explosives never mishap on your account: a natural 1 merely fizzles rather than going off in your hand. Most powdermen learn that last rule posthumously.

Grubstake

You are never quite empty-handed. You always carry working prospecting and mining tools, and once per session you may produce one mundane but useful item you "had all along" — a spare pick, a coil of wire, a candle-stub, a creased claim-map of the very ground you stand on. You also know the outfitters; in any town of size you may secure a fair price and a line of credit no questions asked, so long as your luck holds.

Dowse

With a forked rod, a pan, or a pendulum and a minute's concentration, make a Survival check to sense the nearest **water, ore, or worked metal** within a quarter-mile, and its rough direction and depth. The same gift, pushed, finds darker things — buried bodies, salted graves, and the *bad veins* where the Old Dark runs close to the surface. The rod always tells the truth. It simply does not always tell you what you hoped to hear.

Field Inventions

You are forever modifying your kit by lamplight. Choose **two Devices** from the list below at 4th level, and one more at 6th and at 8th; you may rebuild your loadout each dawn. Unless noted, readying a Device spends one prepared charge.

A Powderman's Devices

A Powderman's Devices (cont.)

- **Concussion Charge.** A muffled blast of nonlethal force that deafens; gentle on walls, hard on men.
- **Flash Powder.** A blinding crack in a 10-foot burst; Fortitude or be dazzled a round, blinded on a critical failure.
- **Grapnel & Line.** A launched hook and rope to scale a height, swing a gap, or drag an object — or a man — off his feet.
- **Repeating Fuse.** Throw or place a charge as a single Beat rather than two, and add +2 to land it where you mean to.
- **Scattergun Charge.** Packed shrapnel fires in a 20-foot cone instead of a burst, dealing piercing for fire.
- **Smoke Pot.** A 15-foot bank of concealing smoke that drifts and lingers a minute or more.
- **String of Cats.** A rattling chain of bangers that apes a firefight — fine for a distraction, or a Demoralize against the green.
- **Thunderboot Auger.** A shaped breaching charge that opens a barred door, a safe, or a mine-wall in seconds.

Assayer's Eye

You appraise the worth and the honesty of a thing at a glance: the value of goods and gems, the salted claim, the counterfeit coin, the true content of a vein. You instantly recognize **silver** and **cold iron** by their gleam and heft — knowledge worth more than money against the things that fear them.

Demolitionist

Your understanding of powder has passed from craft into art. Your bursts gain +5 feet of radius, and against structures, wagons, and the unliving your charges deal **double dice**. Once per scene you may daisy-chain several prepared charges into a single catastrophic blast, combining their dice and their burst — the kind of thing that reshapes a canyon wall, or the course of a battle.

Sapper

You dig, tunnel, and undermine at twice the speed of honest men. In a fight, spend two Beats and a point of Pay Dirt to throw up hard cover from the ground itself — a trench, a rubble-pile, a collapsed timber — or, with a charge set, to bring a wall, a bridge, or a mine-roof down on whatever stands beneath it.

Overcharge

Once per scene, as a single Beat, you overload a Device or your own iron: until the end of your next turn your charges and gunshots deal +2 **dice** and ignore the first step of a target's resistance, and one Device fires without spending a charge. Push your luck and overcharge a second time in the same scene, and you risk a backfire — a flat check, or the thing goes off early, and on you.

The Mother Lode

Once per session you strike it rich. Either refill your Pay Dirt pool entirely and take a genuine windfall the Keeper honors — a fat vein, a lost cache, a buried strongbox — or, in a tight place, declare that *everything goes your way* for one round: treat every check you make that round as one degree of success better. The deep digging has changed you, too: you feel it in your fillings when the Old Dark stirs underground, and the Keeper gives you a moment's warning before it surfaces. You have learned what sleeps in the deep. You keep digging anyway.



"Folks say I struck it lucky. I struck it deep, is what I did, and lucky was getting back up the shaft. There's a sound down there, past the silver — patient, like water that learned to wait. I do not dig at night now. I have all the money a man could want, and I sleep with the lamp lit."

— J. HALLORAN, LATE OF THE WIDOW'S COMFORT CLAIM, NOW OF NO FIXED ADDRESS



Claims of the Prospector

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Deep Claim.** You see in the dark underground and sense ore, water, and the Old Dark near at hand. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene the deep answers — unearth a useful relic, or turn the Old Dark's notice aside for a round.
- **The Lucky Claim.** Your Pay Dirt pool grows, and once per scene you may reroll a search, survival, or save for free. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, declare the dice fall your way — treat any one roll as a natural 20.
- **The Powder Claim.** Prepare extra charges, and your bursts gain +5 feet of radius. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, set off a single ruinous blast that can level a building, or a monster.

Sawbones

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Steady

Surgeon, alienist, horse-doctor, or barber with a bone-saw — the Sawbones is the one who digs the bullet out by lamplight and decides who is worth the laudanum. They know the body too well to romanticize it, and the mind too well to trust it. In a country this lethal, they are worth their weight in silver.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+2	+0	+2	Field Surgery, Anatomist
2	+1	+3	+0	+3	Tonics
3	+2	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Practice
4	+3	+4	+1	+4	Precise Strike 1d6
5	+4	+4	+1	+4	Alienist
6	+5	+5	+2	+5	—
7	+6	+5	+2	+5	Edge, Precise Strike 2d6
8	+7	+6	+2	+6	—
9	+8	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+9	+7	+3	+7	Precise Strike 3d6, Miracle Worker, Practice Mastery

Field Surgery

With a kit and a few minutes, you restore 1d8 + your level in Blood to a patient, once per wound. Without a kit you may still stop bleeding and stabilize the dying on a Medicine check.

Anatomist / Precise Strike

You know exactly where things come apart. Against any living foe whose anatomy you understand, you may add the listed extra damage with a precise attack — a scalpel, a derringer pressed to the ribs, a well-placed blade.

Tonics

You brew and carry remedies: stimulants, sedatives, laudanum, antitoxins. Each dawn you may prepare a number of doses equal to your WIT modifier + half your level. Their use, and abuse, is detailed in Chapter X.

Alienist

You can doctor the mind as well as the body. By talking a sufferer through their terror for ten quiet minutes, you restore Nerve equal to 1d6 + your WIT modifier — reason held up like a lamp against the dark. It does not work twice on the same fright.

Miracle Worker

At 10th level your hands have become something the country whispers about. Once per session you may attempt the impossible at the operating table: a Beyond (DC 30) Medicine check, taken over an hour of desperate work, can pull a character back from death itself so long as the body is whole and no more than a minute has passed — or can lift a single Lasting Injury or bodily Affliction entirely. Whether the patient is grateful for what you have done is between them and their god.

Practices of the Sawbones

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

Practices of the Sawbones (cont.)

- **The Chemist.** Prepare extra tonics each day and name any poison or drug at a glance. *Mastery (10th):* brew a signature serum that grants a mighty boon for a scene, or lays a foe insensible.
- **The Field Medic.** Tend wounds in the thick of a fight without provoking, and reach the downed faster. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, a barked field-treatment heals every ally who can hear you.
- **The Surgeon.** Your Treat Wounds restores an extra die, and you stabilize the dying as a single Beat. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, drag a freshly-fallen ally back to their feet and fighting.

VI. Callings of Faith

For those who answer the dark with a louder Word.

Not every power in this country is bought from the Old Dark beneath it. Some is asked for, on the knees, of a higher and quieter thing — and sometimes the asking is answered, though never plainly. The Callings of Faith draw their strength from conviction: the certainty, against all evidence, that the world has a maker and the maker has not entirely turned away. Whether that certainty is true matters less, mechanically, than that it is *held*. Faith made countable is the rarest currency in the Territories, and it spends.

This chapter holds five Callings of Faith, each answering the dark in a different tongue.

Padre meets it with sacrament, Latin rite, and the long authority of the Church. **Preacher** meets it with the open Word and sheer conviction. **Shaman** meets it by walking with the spirits of the living country itself. **Medicine Man** meets it with the oldest answer of all — by keeping the wounded alive in spite of it. And the **Witch Hunter** meets it with fire, silver, and a zealot's certainty, hunting the dark's servants back to their dens.

A Note on Faiths Not Your Own

The faith-keepers of the First Peoples are **not** a Calling in this book and should never be reduced to one. Their ceremonies are living religion, not game mechanics, and they are not the "Old Rites" of Chapter XIII. The **Shaman** presented here is a deliberately fictional, syncretic spirit-talker — drawn from the broad frontier well of animist and folk belief, and likewise *not* a stand-in for any real nation's sacred practice. If a table wishes to portray such a figure, do so as a person of faith — with the care urged in Chapter IV — and leave the sacred specifics of any living tradition off the character sheet entirely.

Medicine Man

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Steady

In a country that deals exclusively in wounds, the rarest soul of all is the one who closes them. The Medicine Man is that soul: healer, herb-doctor, prayer-mender, bonesetter — keeper of the only craft the frontier truly cannot do without. Where other Callings of Faith answer the dark with fire or rite, this one answers it with the simple, stubborn insistence that the people in its care are going to *live*. No Calling keeps a party breathing like this one.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+2	+0	+2	Healing Hands, Herb-Lore
2	+1	+3	+0	+3	Mend the Body
3	+2	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Way
4	+3	+4	+1	+4	Draw Out the Sickness
5	+4	+4	+1	+4	Call Back the Breath
6	+5	+5	+2	+5	—
7	+6	+5	+2	+5	Edge, Soothe the Spirit
8	+7	+6	+2	+6	—
9	+8	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+9	+7	+3	+7	Hands of Life, Way Mastery

Healing Hands

You possess the deepest healing well of any Calling: a pool of **Vital Breath** equal to your RES modifier + your full level (not half), refreshed each dawn. Every gift below draws on it. Where another healer counts pennies, you carry a purse.

Herb-Lore

You gather and prepare remedies from the living country — poultices, teas, tinctures, splints. Gain +2 on Medicine and Survival, and treat your prepared remedies as a Sawbones' Tonics. Between fights, your herb-work stabilizes the dying and tends the hurt *without* spending Vital Breath, so that your well is full when the shooting starts.

Mend the Body

By touch, spend 1 Vital Breath to heal **2d8 Blood** — more per point than any other Calling can manage — or to instantly stabilize a dying soul and bring them back to their senses. Pour in more points to mend more — each further point of Vital Breath heals another 2d8.

Draw Out the Sickness

Spend Vital Breath to grant an immediate save against a poison, disease, or Affliction at +4 — or, for 3 Vital Breath, end one outright. You may also ease the penalty of a Lasting Injury for a day, buying a wounded companion the time the country would otherwise deny them.

Call Back the Breath

Within a minute of a death, you may spend half your maximum Vital Breath (rounded up) and a long, exhausting effort to call a soul back into a body still whole enough to hold it. It is never certain and never cheap, and the country sometimes takes notice when you cheat it of a meal. But you can do the one thing nearly nothing else in this book can: undo a death.

Soothe the Spirit

Your gift mends more than meat. Restore Nerve as readily as Blood, lift fear from the frightened, and — uniquely — suppress the *symptoms* of the Mark for a scene, granting a Hexer, a Dark Cultist, or any haunted soul a few hours of true peace. You cannot lift the Mark itself. But you can give the Marked a night's sleep, which they will remember as a kindness long after they have forgotten your name.

Hands of Life

Once per session, a great mercy pours out of you to every soul you can reach: all your companions restored, afflictions lifted, the freshly dying raised, fear washed clean away. For one moment you are the thing this country refuses to be. The cost is borne in your own body — you take on a measure of what you healed, a share of the wounds and the dread — and you cannot do it again until you have rested and grieved what it cost you.

A Note on the Name

"Medicine Man" carries real and specific meaning in Native American traditions. This Calling is **not** a portrait of any nation's sacred healer or ceremony — those, as Chapters IV and VI insist, stay off the character sheet. It is a deliberately fictional, syncretic frontier healer, blending the herb-doctor, the granny-woman, the faith-healer, and the bonesetter of many trail traditions. Tables are warmly encouraged to rename it to taste — the Healer, the Granny, the Bonesetter, the Yarb-Doctor — and to play the mercy and the craft while leaving real ceremony alone.

Ways of the Medicine Man

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Dreaming Way.** You walk in visions and read omens for guidance. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, walk the dream to foresee a danger, or to find what is hidden or lost.
- **The Mending Way.** Your remedies are potent and may lift a lingering affliction. *Mastery (10th)*: once per scene, a healing rite mends every ally near you.

Ways of the Medicine Man (cont.)

— **The Warding Way.** Craft charms that turn aside the dark and its lesser servants.

Mastery (10th): once per scene, draw a circle of protection no uncanny thing may enter.

Padre

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 4 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Steady

Where the Preacher improvises, the Padre inherits. Behind one tired man at a crumbling mission stands eighteen centuries of liturgy, an unbroken chain of ordination, and a Church that has been writing down what it learned about the dark since long before the dark followed the settlers west. The Padre's power is the power of the Rite, performed exactly, whether or not the celebrant's own faith is steady. The words work. That is rather the point of them.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+2	+0	+2	Sacraments, Rite of Exorcism
2	+1	+3	+0	+3	Holy Water & Relic
3	+2	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Order
4	+3	+4	+1	+4	Sanctuary
5	+4	+4	+1	+4	Viaticum
6	+5	+5	+2	+5	—
7	+6	+5	+2	+5	Edge, The Greater Rite
8	+7	+6	+2	+6	—

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
9	+8	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+9	+7	+3	+7	The Church Militant, Order Mastery

Sacraments

You have a pool of **Grace** equal to your PRE modifier + half your level (minimum 1), refreshed at the dawn Mass (or its private equivalent). Grace fuels every rite below. A Padre who has missed his offices too long begins the day with the pool halved — the Church is exacting about its bookkeeping.

Rite of Exorcism

Your signature work. Against a possessing spirit, a controlling influence, or the Mark working in a living soul, spend Grace and intone the Rite — a contest of your **Sacrament DC** (10 + half level + PRE) against the thing's Will, repeated each round you persist. Win the contest and you suppress it for the scene; win it twice running and you cast it out entirely. It is slow, it is loud, and it makes you the only thing in the room the dark wants dead.

Holy Water & Relic

You may bless water by the vial; a thrown vial deals 1d6 holy damage (Scatter 5 ft) to the uncanny and burns the Marked. You also carry a true **relic** — a saint's bone, a splinter, a medal worn smooth — which grants one reroll each day on a save against the unnatural, and which the restless dead are loath to approach.

Sanctuary

Spend Grace and a minute to consecrate a space. Uncanny things must make a Will save against your Sacrament DC to enter or to strike those within; allies inside recover Nerve each round and gain +2 on

Will saves. The ground holds until dawn, until deconsecrated, or until you are carried out of it.

Viaticum

The last rites are also the kindest medicine. Spend Grace to heal 2d8 Blood and halt the dying by touch. Should the patient die regardless, you shrive them: their soul departs in peace, beyond the dark's reach — they cannot rise as restless dead — and the quiet of a good death restores you 1d6 Nerve.

The Greater Rite

You learn one major liturgical working: *Bell, Book, and Candle* (a ten-minute rite that banishes a lesser uncanny outright, or a greater one for a day and a night), or the *Consecration of a Haunt* (which lays a binding on the very stones of a haunted place). Choose at 7th; the Keeper may permit more in play.

The Church Militant

Once per session, draw on the whole weight of the Church behind you. As an action, name the unclean in Latin and command it: it makes a Will save against your Sacrament DC or is destroyed if a lesser thing, banished if a greater, and in any case driven Frightened and Slowed. Every ally who can hear the Rite is immune to fear until the scene ends. Two thousand years of the dead speak the words with you, and for one moment, the dark remembers that it has lost this argument before.



"The boy's father asked me did I believe, truly, that the words would hold the thing in his son. I told him belief was his department. The Rite was mine, and the Rite does not require my opinion. Then I opened the book, and we found out together which of us was right."

— FR. IGNACIO REYES, MISSION SAN CRISANTO



Orders of the Padre

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Exorcist.** Rebuke the uncanny and loosen its grip upon the possessed. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, cast out a possessing or lesser horror entirely.
- **The Martyr.** Take a wound meant for another, and endure where others fall. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, interpose against a killing blow, or fall and rise once more, unbroken.
- **The Shepherd.** Bless allies who can hear you and ward them against fear. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, raise a sanctuary that shields all nearby from harm for a round.

Preacher

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 4 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Steady

Whether ordained, defrocked, or self-anointed, the Preacher carries the Word into a country that has plainly been abandoned by whatever wrote it — and keeps preaching anyway. Their faith is a weapon and a wall. Whether any god hears them is a question the Preacher has stopped asking aloud.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+2	+0	+2	Conviction, Sermon
2	+1	+3	+0	+3	Ward
3	+2	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Testament
4	+3	+4	+1	+4	Brimstone 1d6
5	+4	+4	+1	+4	Lay On Hands
6	+5	+5	+2	+5	—
7	+6	+5	+2	+5	Edge, Brimstone 2d6
8	+7	+6	+2	+6	—
9	+8	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+9	+7	+3	+7	Brimstone 3d6, Revelation, Testament Mastery

Conviction

You have a pool of **Conviction** equal to your PRE modifier + half your level (minimum 1), refreshed each dawn. Conviction fuels your sermons and miracles. It is faith made countable — and it runs dry exactly when you need it most.

Sermon

Spend 1 Conviction and speak for a round. Allies who hear you regain Nerve equal to your PRE modifier and gain +1 on Will saves until the scene ends. The unfaithful may mock; they steady all the same.

Ward

Spend 1 Conviction to inscribe or invoke a ward against the uncanny. Marked and unnatural things must make a Will save to cross it or strike those within. A ward holds until dawn or until you fall.

Brimstone

Your invective becomes a smiting. As an attack, point and condemn a single creature within sight; spend 1 Conviction to deal the listed holy damage (doubled against the Marked and the uncanny), Will save for half. It is loud, and it draws notice.

Lay On Hands

By touch and prayer, spend Conviction to heal 1d8 Blood per point spent, or to halt bleeding and stabilize the dying. The same gift, turned on the unnatural, deals that much instead.

Revelation

At 10th level, faith burns through the veil. Once per session, as an action, you may spend 3 Conviction to lay the truth of a place or a creature bare before all who can hear you: the uncanny within sight is named aloud — its nature, its hunger, and the one thing it fears — and is struck Frightened 1 for the scene, while your companions ignore the next Dread Check they would face. The Word, spoken once with perfect certainty, still moves something. You simply never learn what, or whether it was listening, or merely could not bear to be seen.



"I have buried ninety souls and christened thirty, and I keep the arithmetic in the same book. If the Lord reads it of an evening, He has not yet seen fit to remark upon the difference."

— REV. AMOS TEAGUE, HIS OWN LEDGER, WATER-STAINED



Testaments of the Preacher

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Hellfire Testament.** Your Brimstone strikes an additional foe within reach of the first. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, call down a pillar of fire upon the unclean.
- **The Revival Testament.** Your sermons mend the faithful and steady their nerve. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, a great revival heals and emboldens every ally who can hear you, and lifts the freshly fallen.
- **The Wrathful Testament.** Gain a bonus against the uncanny and those who serve it. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, your smite banishes a lesser horror outright.

Shaman

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Steady

The Shaman of this book is a spirit-talker: one who has learned that the country is not empty but *crowded* — with the spirits of beasts and weather, river and rock, and the long-departed dead — and who keeps a working peace with them through respect, offering, and the long apprenticeship of listening. Theirs is not the borrowed power of the Hexer but a relationship,

maintained the way any relationship is: with patience, gifts, and a healthy fear of giving offense.

See the box opposite (Chapter VI's note, and Chapter IV): this Shaman is a fictional, syncretic frontier archetype, not a portrait of any living nation's sacred role. Play the relationship and the respect; leave real ceremony off the sheet.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+2	+0	+2	Spirit-Sight, The Helping Spirits
2	+1	+3	+0	+3	Mending Hands
3	+2	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Spirit-Pact
4	+3	+4	+1	+4	Spirit-Walk
5	+4	+4	+1	+4	Don the Aspect
6	+5	+5	+2	+5	—
7	+6	+5	+2	+5	Edge, Commune
8	+7	+6	+2	+6	—
9	+8	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+9	+7	+3	+7	Become the Mask, Spirit-Pact Mastery

Spirit-Sight

You perceive the spirits of the living world and the unquiet dead, the thin places, and the moods of the country itself. You may address a spirit of place and, with courtesy, be answered — though the spirits keep their own counsel and their own grudges.

The Helping Spirits

One or more spirits walk with you — choose an **Aspect**, such as the Wolf (the hunt and the pack), the Raven (cunning and the dead), the River (mending and endurance), or the Elder (memory and counsel). The Aspect grants a standing boon and a called-upon boon fueled by your pool of **Breath** (RES modifier + half level, refreshed each dawn). You may make peace with a second Aspect at 6th level.

Mending Hands

Spend Breath to heal 1d8 Blood per point by touch and song, or to ease a frightened soul — granting back Nerve or a fresh save against an Affliction. The spirits mend what they are asked to, in their own time and to their own ends.

Spirit-Walk

Send your spirit out from your body to scout unseen, or step a short way through the spirit-world to cross ground you could not otherwise reach. Your body lies senseless while you wander, and the longer you stay out, the harder the road back; tarry too long and you risk a Dread Check to find your way home.

Don the Aspect

For a scene, take on the gifts of a Helping Spirit: the Wolf's claws and speed, the Raven's wings and sight, the River's tirelessness, the Elder's uncanny insight. The change is partial and temporary, and it asks a little of you each time — the spirits lend, they do not give.

Commune

Sit with the land, the weather, or the recently dead and learn what they know: the way through, the coming storm, the game and the water, the name of what walks at night. With proper respect you may also lay a restless spirit to rest, which is the truest service a Shaman renders, and the one the dead remember.

Become the Mask

Once per session you may give yourself wholly over to a great spirit for a scene, embodying its full power — a storm, a beast-king, an ancestor of terrible weight. While the spirit rides, you wield gifts far beyond a mortal's. But when it departs, make a Will save (DC the Keeper sets) or a little of it stays, and a little of you does not return. Wear the mask too often and the question stops being whether it comes off, and starts being who is wearing whom.



"My grandmother told me the spirits are not servants and not enemies. They are neighbors, and a neighbor remembers everything — the borrowed cup, the kind word, the slight at the well. Treat them as you would the people whose land you cross. You are, after all, doing both at once."

— RECORDED FROM A SPIRIT-TALKER WHO ASKED TO BE NAMED ONLY AS A FRIEND OF THE RIVER

*Spirit-Pacts of the Shaman*

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Ancestor Pact.** The honored dead counsel you; gain rerolls on lore and warning of danger. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, call an ancestral host to stand and fight beside you a round.
- **The Beast Pact.** A spirit-beast walks with you, lending its senses and its aid. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, take on the great beast's shape, or call it forth in full.

Spirit-Pacts of the Shaman (cont.)

— **The Land Pact.** Command small workings of wind, water, ember, and stone.

Mastery (10th): once per scene, loose a great elemental working — a sudden storm, a swallowing earth.

Witch Hunter

Hit Die d10 · Trained Skills 4 + WIT · Strong Saves Fortitude, Will · Attack Practiced

Where the Marshal hunts men, the Witch Hunter hunts the things that wear them. Inquisitor, monster-killer, burned-out zealot — they are the grim specialists who ride toward the thing the town is fleeing, with silver in the cylinder and a litany of weaknesses by heart. In a country where the uncanny is plainly real, they are a mercy. The trouble is that a man who has spent twenty years finding the Mark on the guilty eventually begins to see it on the innocent, too.

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+1	+2	+0	+2	The Hunt, Sanctified Iron
2	+2	+3	+0	+3	Steeled Nerve
3	+3	+3	+1	+3	Edge, Creed
4	+4	+4	+1	+4	Recognize the Unclean
5	+5	+4	+1	+4	Judgment 1d8
6	+6	+5	+2	+5	—
7	+7	+5	+2	+5	Edge, Relentless
8	+8	+6	+2	+6	Judgment 2d8

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
9	+9	+6	+3	+6	Edge
10	+10	+7	+3	+7	The Pyre, Judgment 3d8, Creed Mastery

The Hunt

As a single Beat, name one creature you can see as your **quarry**. Against that quarry you gain +1 to hit and to all checks to find, track, and study it; you ignore any supernatural concealment it enjoys; and you may not be forced to flee it by fear. You may have one quarry at a time and may shift it with another Beat. The Hunt is the whole of the art: choose your prey, and never lose the trail.

Sanctified Iron

Each dawn, anoint your weapons with salt, silver-wash, oil, and a muttered rite. Until next dawn they count as **silver, cold iron, and blessed** for the purpose of overcoming the uncanny's resistances, and deal +1 damage to the Marked and the unnatural. At 6th level, all three at once; before that, choose one each morning and guess well.

Steeled Nerve

You have stared into too many open graves to flinch at one more. Gain +2 on all Dread Checks and saves against fear, and halve the Nerve you lose to your current quarry's kind. The horror is still there. You have simply made a profession of not looking away.

Recognize the Unclean

Study a creature or a person for a round and make a Lore: Occult check: learn whether they bear the Mark or are unnatural, what manner of thing they are, and one weakness the Keeper will honor — silver, fire, running water, true names, the dawn. The gift is exact, and it is the most dangerous thing you own, for it tempts you to trust it absolutely.

Judgment

Once per quarry, declare **Judgment** before a Strike. On a hit, deal the listed extra holy-and-silver damage; on a critical hit, the quarry must save (DC 10 + half level + WIT) or be Frightened and Slowed, losing a Beat. Judgment refreshes when you name a new quarry.

Relentless

When your quarry drops or flees, you do not relent: immediately Stride toward it for free, and your first Strike in pursuit ignores the Multiple Attack Penalty. A wounded thing that runs from a Witch Hunter is merely choosing where it dies.

The Pyre

At 10th level you are the bane of unclean things. Your Judgment recharges at the start of every scene, no longer only with each new quarry. And once per session, when you reduce an uncanny quarry to 0 Blood, you may perform the rites of ending — salt, fire, the severed name — and ensure it **stays dead**: it does not rise, reform, or return. Nothing the Keeper has prepared survives the Pyre. The cost is the man you have become to wield it.

On Hunting, and on Zealotry

In this country the monsters are real, and the Witch Hunter is sometimes the only thing between a town and the dark. But history's witch hunters mostly burned the frightened, the strange, and the inconvenient — and a long-serving Hunter in this game should feel that pull. Keepers may ask for a Will save or a touch of the Mark when a Hunter condemns on too little proof. The most frightening question this Calling can ask is not *what is that thing*. It is *how certain are you* — and whether certainty is the same as being right.

Creeds of the Witch Hunter

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and blooms into its greater ability — its **Mastery** — at 10th level, the height of a frontier life.

- **The Inquisitor.** You sense lies and the Mark upon a soul, and you resist the uncanny's influence. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, speak a binding word that holds a lesser uncanny thing helpless a round.
- **The Slayer.** Deal extra damage against your quarry's kind. *Mastery (10th):* your Judgment can fell even a great horror, and a killing blow against the uncanny cannot be shrugged off.
- **The Warden.** Scribe wards that bar the uncanny and shield others from the Old Dark. *Mastery (10th):* once per scene, sanctify the ground around you, which no uncanny thing may cross.

VII. Callings of the Old Dark

Four roads into the Old Dark — by pact, by craft, by deceit, and by devotion.



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You have come a fair way into this almanac, reader — through the honest chapters, the wages and the weather and the workaday iron. Notice, if you would, how naturally you turned this page. That is how it happens out there, too: one door at a time, each opening easily off the last, until a soul looks up from its reading and finds the light has changed. The pages from here forward concern the things the handbills do not mention. It is not too late to close the book. It has never yet been too late for anyone, at this particular page.

Not all power is preached from a pulpit. Beneath this country lies an older one — the **Old Dark**: the deep strata of buried gods, drowned hungers, and patient things that were ancient when the first peoples were young. It does not love you and it does not hate you; it lends, and is inherited, and is worshipped, and it always collects. Four Callings in this chapter reach down into the Old Dark, each by a different road, and it is an old and fatal error to mistake one road for another. The **Hexer** takes power on loan from the Old Dark, and the lender never forgets a debt. The **Witch** inherits an older, steadier craft, bound to a familiar and worked in curses and brews. The **False Prophet** neither borrows nor inherits, but runs a confidence game on the Old Dark's behalf — and arranges for a deceived flock to pay the bill. And the **Dark Cultist** has simply fallen in love with one of the things below, and serves it gladly, body and soul.

*All four work **Signs** and **Old Rites** from Chapter XIII, paying the Old Dark in Nerve (and sometimes Blood, or worse). Each chooses a **Bargain** at 3rd level that grants a boon now and a greater boon at 9th — the shape of the bargain, the craft, the lie, or the devotion. Hexer and Dark Cultist begin **Marked** and walk the track quickly — the Hexer dragged, the Dark Cultist glad of it; the Witch does not begin **Marked** at all; and the False Prophet, cleverest and worst, sees to it that someone else bears the Mark in their stead.*



“We put six torches and a deal of lead into the thing that used to be Abner Cole, and ran it clear to Diablo Canyon before it went down. What we buried was not a wolf, and it was not Abner. Salt the grave. Do not mark it.”

— MARSHAL T. COYLE, ON A MATTER HE WOULD NOT ENTER IN THE LEDGER



Dark Cultist

Where the Hexer *uses* the dark and the False Prophet *cheats* it, the Dark Cultist **loves** it. They have looked upon one of the old things beneath the country, understood exactly what it is, and chosen it — gladly, fully, with both hands. Their power is the gift of a true believer to a patron that answers, and they pay its price not in dread but in joy. The Hexer flinches at the Mark. The Dark Cultist counts each step of it as a sacrament, and asks the dark for one more.

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 4 + WIT · Strong Save Will · Attack Slight

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	Devotion, Dark Communion, The Glad Mark
2	+0	+0	+0	+3	Sign learned
3	+1	+1	+1	+3	Edge, Sacrifice, Devotion
4	+2	+1	+1	+4	Sign learned
5	+3	+1	+1	+4	Gifts of the Patron
6	+4	+2	+2	+5	Sign learned
7	+5	+2	+2	+5	Edge, Rapture

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
8	+6	+2	+2	+6	Sign learned
9	+7	+3	+3	+6	Edge, Devotion (Greater)
10	+8	+3	+3	+7	Vessel

Devotion

You have a pool of **Devotion** — your patron's favor — equal to your RES modifier + half your level, refreshed through observance: the kept fast, the night vigil, the rite performed at the proper hour. It fuels your Dark Communion. A Dark Cultist who lets devotion lapse finds the favor cold exactly when it is needed.

Dark Communion

You work **Signs** and **Old Rites** (Chapter XIII), paid in Devotion (or, when that runs dry, in Nerve and Blood), and you receive them as what they are to you: genuine gifts from the thing you serve. You begin knowing two Signs and learn another at each *Sign learned*.

The Glad Mark

You begin already touched (Mark 1), as a Hexer does — but where the Hexer is dragged along the track, you *walk* it, willingly, eyes open. Reckless workings advance your Mark as theirs do; the difference is that you do not mourn the steps. And unlike any other Calling, a rising Mark **repays** you (see Gifts of the Patron). You are becoming something else on purpose, and calling it grace.

Sacrifice

Devotion is best shown in blood. Spend your own Blood to empower a working at the Blood-Price rate, or offer a worthier sacrifice — a beast, a treasure, a life — to petition your patron for a boon beyond your level, which the Keeper adjudicates. Great gifts demand great

offerings, and the patron always knows the difference between a sacrifice that costs you and one that does not.

Gifts of the Patron

As the Mark claims you, the patron remakes you in its image. At Mark 2, 3, and 4, choose a **Gift**: unnatural resilience (DR), a malformed weapon-limb, sight that pierces any dark, a voice that staggers the faithful, the cold strength of the deep places. Each is a true power and a true disfigurement. The more monstrous you become, the more the dark can pour through you.

Rapture

Once per scene, give yourself over to ecstatic communion: become immune to fear and pain (ignore Frightened, gain DR) and let your workings surge in power. While raptured you cannot retreat, and you cannot act against your patron's interest — for in that moment you have no interest of your own.

Vessel

Once per session you may invite your patron to descend fully into you for a scene. You become its herald upon the earth, wielding power no mortal should hold — and the Keeper plays you while it lasts, for it is no longer entirely your body. When the scene ends, make a Will save against a DC the Keeper sets. Fail, and a little more of you stays behind the veil; fail at high Mark, and you do not come back at all, but step willingly into the dark a finished thing. The most devoted Dark Cultist's last prayer is always answered, exactly as it was asked.

On Playing a Dark Cultist

This is, more often than not, the Calling of the people the others ride out to stop — the membership of the cults the country breeds in its lonely places. It can be played, and

On Playing a Dark Cultist *(cont.)*

played well: as a fallen soul seeking redemption, a true believer the party does not yet suspect, a double agent, or a tragedy walking knowingly into the fire. But its arc bends toward the monstrous by design. Talk it through with your table first. Some doors are written to be walked through; this Calling is the hinge.

Dark Cultist's Devotions

At 3rd level, name the Patron you serve — one of the Patrons of the Old Dark on the following page. Your Devotion grants a boon at once and a greater boon at 9th level, as the thing below sinks its hooks the deeper.

- **The Cold Deep.** Spend Devotion to drain warmth (Slowed, Drained, cold damage) and steady yourself against your end (reroll a failed Fortitude save to stop your bleeding; ignore fear). *Greater (9th):* once per session, open a sphere of annihilating cold that withers all within and shows each witness the indifferent end.
- **The Devourer.** Slaying or sacrificing heals you and grants Devotion; your Gifts favor claws and toughness; you regenerate while fed. *Greater (9th):* once per scene, swell into a thing of teeth — large, swift, regenerating — devouring what you bring down.

Dark Cultist's Devotions (cont.)

- **The Long Trail.** Spend Devotion to lay a withering death-touch (necrotic cold) and to sense the dying — you know who in your sight is marked to die soon, and may bid a freshly-slain foe rise and serve you a round. Your Gifts favor a deathless calm, an unerring eye for a mortal wound, and a body slow to quit. *Greater (9th):* once per session, pronounce a death sentence on one you can name — short of a true miracle the Long Trail comes for them before the arc is out — or, when you yourself fall, rise once at the next dusk, a little further down the trail than you were.
- **The Red Sermon.** Spend Devotion to borrow a face and a honeyed voice — charm or compel those who hear you, pass for someone trusted, and feed on a crowd's devotion to refill your pool. You gather a small flock that believes, and their belief is meat. Your Gifts favor a stolen face, a compelling word, and a hunger worn as warmth. *Greater (9th):* once per session, hollow a gathering — every soul who can hear you is gripped by compulsion or terror, and a little of each is fed to the thing you serve, leaving you flush with power and them diminished and yours.
- **The Thing Beneath the Mountain.** Spend Devotion to call on the deep stone — a crushing grip, a hide of grinding rock (DR and resistance), and tremor-sense through earth and floorboard. You see in the lightless dark, never lose your way underground, and the buried answers when you knock. Your Gifts favor stone flesh, a crushing strength, and the secrets of ore and vein. *Greater (9th):* once per session, wake the mountain a little — bring down a ceiling, split the ground, or clad yourself in living rock, huge and all but unkillable, for a few rounds.
- **The Whisperer.** Spend Devotion to pluck a secret from a mind or the air, and to whisper madness — confusion, fear, or a Dread Check. *Greater (9th):* once per session, speak the Unspeakable Word — unmake a mind, or wring one true and terrible answer from your Patron.

False Prophet

A False Prophet did not sign for power as a Hexer does, nor inherit it as a Witch does. They stumbled instead on a meaner trick: the dark will pay, and pay handsomely, for **worship** — and it does not greatly care where the worship is aimed. So the False Prophet raises a congregation that believes it prays to Heaven, skims the devotion off the top, and lets something out past the firelight drink the rest. The miracles are real. The gospel is a lie. And the bill, when at last it falls due, is mailed to the flock.

Hit Die d8 · Trained Skills 6 + WIT · Strong Saves Reflex, Will · Attack Steady

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+0	+2	+2	False Gospel, The Conduit
2	+1	+0	+3	+3	Stolen Wonder
3	+2	+1	+3	+3	Edge, Gospel
4	+3	+1	+4	+4	Honeyed Word
5	+4	+1	+4	+4	Visit the Cost
6	+5	+2	+5	+5	Stolen Wonder
7	+6	+2	+5	+5	Edge, Feed the Dark
8	+7	+2	+6	+6	Stolen Wonder
9	+8	+3	+6	+6	Edge, Gospel (Greater)
10	+9	+3	+7	+7	The Hollow Crown

The Conduit

Your power is stolen worship, and your pool of it is called **Tribute**. It equals your PRE modifier + half your level, but its maximum *swells* with the size and fervor of the flock you have deceived — a packed revival tent raises the ceiling high; a doubting crowd or a night alone drops it to nothing. Tribute refills when you preach the false gospel to believers. Cut off from a congregation to fleece, you are merely a liar with empty hands and a dangerous patron.

False Gospel

You may work a small repertoire of **Signs** (Chapter XIII) — but in your hands they wear the mask of holy wonders: light where there should be shadow, a dove where there should be a worm. None but the witch-sighted perceive the dark beneath. You pay for these workings in **Tribute**, never your own Nerve. You begin knowing two such wonders and learn another with each *Stolen Wonder* feature.

Honeyed Word

Few resist a prophet. Gain +3 on Persuade and Deceive against crowds and the faithful, and once per scene issue a Command the devout obey as scripture (Will save to resist, at disadvantage for true believers).

Visit the Cost

This is the black heart of the Calling, and the thing that sets you apart from every other soul in this chapter. When a working would make *you* pay — a Backlash, a Blood price, an advance of the Mark — you may instead lay that cost upon a member of your flock: a believer takes the wound, the ruin, the creeping Mark, while you walk away clean and haloed. The dark does not care who bleeds, only that someone does. But each time you do it, the thing behind your gospel sinks its hooks a little deeper into the congregation — and into you.

Feed the Dark

Once per session, offer the massed devotion of a gathering up to your unseen patron. Refill your Tribute and gain a surge besides — and the dark grows fat, while your flock comes away hollowed, hungrier for you, and a little less themselves than they were. They will not know why. They will only know they need another sermon.

The Hollow Crown

Once per session, for a single scene, you throw the doors wide and let the dark wear your gospel openly through you: tremendous power flows — great smitings, healings, terrors, commands — and the crowd will die at your asking, and some may. But you are no longer entirely the one preaching; the Keeper may put a word in your mouth and turn your hand, as the thing behind the curtain stretches into the room it has rented all this time. When the scene ends the Mark advances, and you understand the shape of the trick at last: you did not gather a flock for yourself. You baited a hook. You were the worm.

Three Debts: Hexer, Witch, False Prophet

The **Hexer** borrows from the dark directly and is Marked from the first hour. The **Witch** inherits an older craft and pays in her own Nerve. The **False Prophet** does neither — they run a confidence game on the dark's behalf and arrange for the deceived to settle the account. The Hexer dreads the bill. The Witch budgets for it. The False Prophet mails it to a parishioner and passes the collection plate again.



"He laid hands on my boy and the fever broke, and I thanked God on my knees in the mud. My boy has not slept right since. Says a man with my preacher's face stands at the foot of the bed and takes something small out of him, each night, with great tenderness. I have stopped going to the tent. I find I am the only one in town who has."

— TESTIMONY OF A MOTHER, RECORDED AND SEALED AT CALVARY WELLS



False Prophet's Gospels

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and a greater boon at 9th level — the deepening of the gospel.

- **The Borrowed Saint.** Healing and blessing wonders cost 1 less Tribute and run deeper; you read as genuinely holy to Witch-Sight and any test of faith. *Greater (9th):* once per session, stage a public miracle that binds every witness to you as devoted and floods your Tribute.
- **The Doomsayer.** Fear and smiting wonders surge; once per scene pronounce a small judgment — a blight, a swarm, a sickness, a curse of ill luck. *Greater (9th):* once per session, prophesy and unleash a scene-wide calamity, its cost paid by the deceived flock.
- **The Golden Calf.** You and your faithful prosper — conjure good fortune and draw a sourceless income wherever you preach. *Greater (9th):* once per session, seal a covenant of plenty over a town for the arc, while the dark quietly mortgages the deceived.

Hexer

Some did not wait for the dark to come to them. The Hexer — conjure-doctor, hedge-sorcerer, pact-sworn — has reached into the old country beneath the country and pulled something back. Their power is real and it is borrowed, and the lender always collects. Every Hexer begins already touched (Mark 1), and every Hexer travels the Mark faster than the rest of the living. This is not a Calling for a soul that wishes to stay one.

Hit Die d6 · Trained Skills 4 + WIT · Strong Save Will · Attack Slight

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	Witch-Sight, Signs, Marked
2	+0	+0	+0	+3	Sign learned
3	+1	+1	+1	+3	Edge, Bargain
4	+2	+1	+1	+4	Sign learned
5	+3	+1	+1	+4	Blood Price
6	+4	+2	+2	+5	Sign learned
7	+5	+2	+2	+5	Edge
8	+6	+2	+2	+6	Sign learned
9	+7	+3	+3	+6	Edge, Bargain (Greater)
10	+8	+3	+3	+7	Sign learned, Adept

Signs

You know and may work **Signs** — the rites of the Old Dark (Chapter XIII). You begin knowing two and learn another at each even level. Working a Sign costs Nerve, and sometimes Blood, and always risks **Backlash**.

Witch-Sight

You see what is truly there: the residue of violence, the Mark upon a soul, the thin places where the world wears through. This sight cannot be unlearned, and some nights you wish it could.

Marked

You begin at Mark 1 and advance the Mark faster than others — reckless use of Signs, and the knowledge they bring, pushes you along the track toward the thing you are slowly becoming. Power and ruin are the same road.

Blood Price

From 5th level you may pay for a Sign in Blood (Hit Points) when your Nerve runs short, at a rate of 2 Blood per point of Nerve. The Old Dark does not care which red ledger you draw from.

Adept

At 10th level, choose one Sign you know. You may work it without spending Nerve once per scene — though never without consequence.

Working a Sign — the Short of It

Declare the Sign and pay its Nerve (or Blood). If it forces a save, the target rolls against your **Sign DC** = 10 + half your level + your RES modifier. Backlash strikes on the listed trigger — most often a natural 1 on any roll the working requires, or a failed working. The deep truths a Sign reveals may also demand a Dread Check of their own. Knowing is never free; for a Hexer, it is merely cheaper at first.

Hexer's Bargains

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and a greater boon at 9th level — the deepening of the bargain.

- **The Conjurer.** Bind a Sign or Rite into a charm anyone may trigger without Nerve (keep WIT-mod charms); +2 and half-time on Old Rites. *Greater (9th):* once per session, craft a great charm that wards a whole scene — allies gain a Ward, the uncanny recoil — paid for with something dear.
- **The Hollow-Born.** Feel pain and fear dimly — DR 2 vs nonmagical harm, ignore the first Nerve lost each scene — but advance the Mark faster. *Greater (9th):* at Mark 4+, once per scene work any Sign without Nerve, paying in Blood instead — each working a step nearer the sixth Mark.
- **The Pact-Sworn.** Once per scene, turn a failed Sign or Will save into a success by taking a Debt; on your third Debt the Patron calls it in — a demand, and +1 Mark. *Greater (9th):* once per session, when you would die, the Patron stays death's hand — stabilize at 1 Blood and rise, at the cost of +1 Mark.
- **The Spiritist.** See and briefly question the recently dead; set a willing spirit to watch and warn (+5 Notice). *Greater (9th):* once per session, invite a willing spirit to act through you for a round, borrowing a skill or memory; the unwilling risks possession.

Witch

Where the Hexer signs for borrowed power, the Witch was born to hers, or had it handed down a crooked family line, or learned it slow from an old woman at the edge of a town that no longer exists. The Craft is older than the dark the Hexer bargains with, and steadier; a

Witch does not begin Marked, and need not end that way. But the Craft keeps its own accounts — in curses that linger, in a familiar's small life bound to hers, and in the quiet certainty that the village will turn on her the day a child takes sick.

Hit Die d6 · Trained Skills 4 + WIT · Strong Save Will · Attack Slight

Lvl	Attack	Fort	Ref	Will	Class Features
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	The Craft, Familiar, The Evil Eye
2	+0	+0	+0	+3	Sign learned
3	+1	+1	+1	+3	Edge, Craft
4	+2	+1	+1	+4	Sign learned, Brew
5	+3	+1	+1	+4	Hex
6	+4	+2	+2	+5	Sign learned
7	+5	+2	+2	+5	Edge
8	+6	+2	+2	+6	Sign learned
9	+7	+3	+3	+6	Edge, Craft (Greater)
10	+8	+3	+3	+7	Sign learned, The Old Witch

The Craft

You know and work **Signs** (Chapter XIII), beginning with two and learning another at each even level, paid in Nerve and risking Backlash as the Hexer's are. But the Craft is inherited, not borrowed: you do **not** begin Marked, and you advance the Mark only through genuine recklessness, never automatically. The dark did not hand you this. Your line did.

Familiar

A small beast is bound to you — a cat, a crow, a hare, a toad, a black snake. It is cannier than any animal, scouts and spies at your bidding, can deliver a touch-range Sign for you, and grants a standing boon while near (a +2 to one sense or skill befitting its nature). You share its senses at will. Should it die, you are Sickened until you can bind another over a long night's rite — and you will feel the loss far longer than the penalty lasts.

The Evil Eye

With a look and a muttered word, lay a minor bane on a creature you can see (Will save vs your Sign DC): -1 to its rolls and a run of small misfortunes for a round per two levels. It costs no Nerve, but everyone who sees you do it remembers your face.

Brew

Given a kitchen, a fire, and time, you brew the work of the Goods chapter and more — healing poultices, sleeping draughts, truth-loosening teas, and poisons that no assayer can name. Treat your brews as a Sawbones' Tonics, with effects you and the Keeper devise; the dose is in the making, and the making is in your hands.

Hex

Your maledictions grow teeth. As an action and 1 Nerve, lay a true **Hex** on a foe (Will save vs Sign DC): Frightened, Clumsy, Sickened, or cursed with ruinous luck (foes' crits against allies, your crits against the cursed) for a scene. A Hexed soul knows it is Hexed, and knows who did it, which is sometimes the worst of it.

The Old Witch

At 10th level your curses set like winter ground: a target who fails a Hex carries it until it is lifted by rite, apology, or your death. Once per session you may speak a *true curse* of dire and lasting effect, the kind that follows a

bloodline. You have outlived everyone who feared you young. The ones who fear you now are right to.

Witch and Hexer — the Difference

Both work Signs and pay in Nerve, but the Hexer's power is a *loan* (begins Marked, races the Mark) while the Witch's is *inheritance* (no starting Mark, advances it only through abuse). A Hexer can become a Witch's cautionary tale; a Witch can become a Hexer the day she reaches for something her line never taught her. Keep the distinction at the table — it is the whole tragedy of the chapter.

Witch's Crafts

At 3rd level, choose one. It grants a boon at once and a greater boon at 9th level — the deepening of the craft.

- **The Cursewife.** Your Hexes and Evil Eye strike harder and cling tighter; Hex two targets at once; lifting your curse costs dearly. *Greater (9th):* once per session, lay a curse of escalating ruin on a wrongdoer until they amend, fall, or flee the country.
- **The Familiar-Bound.** Your familiar grows clever and hardy, delivers your Signs, and lets you see and hear through it at any distance. *Greater (9th):* swap places with it once per scene and share wounds or Blood; should you fall, it carries your spirit to a new dawn — once.
- **The Greenwitch.** Brews never spoil and take half the time; keep a free healing or warding brew; +2 Survival and Medicine; beasts will not harm you unbidden. *Greater (9th):* once per scene, call the wild — walling thorns, a healing green circle, or a trail the land hides until dawn.

Witch's Crafts (cont.)

- **The Moon-Daughter.** See in the dark; once a night take to the air until dawn; slip into a sleeper's dreams to glean or leave a secret. *Greater (9th)*: once per session, ride the night sky to any place you have been, carrying your coven, and walk the dreams of the distant sleeping.

The Patrons of the Old Dark

The Old Dark is not one thing, and it is not a god. It is a depth — and certain shapes move in that depth, old and vast and particular, each with its own hunger and its own coin. These are the **Patrons**: the powers a Hexer borrows from on his Bargain, a Dark Cultist serves in her Devotion, and a False Prophet feeds through his Gospel without ever quite naming. A Witch seldom deals with them directly; her Craft is older and quieter. None of them are kind. The kindest thing that can be said of any is that it keeps its bargains exactly.

What follow are the Patrons most often met in the Territories. A Keeper should feel free to invent others, or to leave every one of these a rumor — the Old Dark is largest when it is least explained.

The Devourer

A vast and patient hunger in the deep places, all teeth and growth. *It offers* strength, swiftness, and a body that knits its own wounds and never stops wanting. *It takes* an appetite that outgrows your power to feed it, until the day the hunger decides your body suits it and declines to give it back. *Its sign*: food spoils, livestock vanish, and the served grow lean no matter how they gorge.

The Whisperer

A thing made of secrets and the spaces between thoughts. *It offers* knowledge — true facts, hidden weaknesses, names, and a voice that staggers the mind. *It takes* by giving: understanding you cannot un-know, that does not fit inside a mortal skull and must make room. *Its sign*: a whisper at the edge of sleep, shared dreams, sudden unbearable certainties, and the same strange word surfacing in many mouths at once.

The Cold Deep

Not a hungry thing, nor a clever one — a vast, indifferent cold, older than warmth, that will outlast every fire. *It offers* numbness, a calm nothing can rattle, a grip like the grave, and a steadiness against your own end. *It takes* the warmth from a soul a degree at a time, until nothing is left that can be moved. *Its sign*: the temperature drops, lamps gutter, and the dying report that it is, at the last, terribly easy.

The Long Trail

Death itself, as this country knows it: a presence at the end of every road, a rider always one ridge behind. *It offers* passage *past* death — a stay of the reaper's hand, a return from the far side, an unerring eye for the dying and the doomed. *It takes* what it lends, with interest; those it carries back come back a little wrong, and it follows them home. *Its sign*: animals that will not pass a certain place, a horseman seen at dusk who is gone at a second look, and the Came-Back-Wrong, who remember the dark on the other side.

The Thing Beneath the Mountain

An old god of the deep stone, sealed long ago by peoples who knew better than to name it, and now dug toward by every shaft and adit in the Territories. *It offers* gold, rich veins, the secrets of rock and metal, and dominion in the dark below the world. *It takes* a little waking with every blast — and it has been waking a long time now. *Its sign*: the *bad veins* where the

Old Dark runs close, the madness that takes deep miners, and a patient sound past the silver, like water that learned to wait.

The Red Sermon

The hunger that wears faces and feeds on worship. *It offers* miracles that truly work, crowds that come, and devotion that fills the plate and the pews. *It takes* the flock, hollowing a congregation a soul at a time, and at the last it takes the preacher too, wearing his gospel openly through him. *Its sign*: a revival that leaves a town emptier than it found it, and a kind face that is almost — not quite — right.

The False Prophet and the Patrons

Of all who deal with the Old Dark, the False Prophet deals most blindly. A Hexer signs a Bargain and reads its terms; a Dark Cultist names the thing she serves and calls it grace. The False Prophet, more often than not, half-believes his own pulpit — or believes only in the collection plate — and never learns whose appetite his gospel truly feeds. The Patron is content to go unnamed. Worship is worship, and it eats just as well from a congregation that thinks it prays to Heaven.

A Prophet's *Conduit* and *Tribute* are, in plain terms, a Patron's hunger fed secondhand: every soul gathered, frightened, healed, or fleeced sends its portion down into the dark, and the dark sends a little power back up through the Prophet as wonders. The shape of those wonders betrays the Patron behind them, for a Prophet's **Gospel** is only the mask his Patron wears:

— The **Borrowed Saint** most often fronts the **Red Sermon** — the face-wearing hunger that loves a crowded revival tent — though a healer's gospel can as easily mask the **Long Trail**, trading true cures for a quiet claim on the cured.

- The **Doomsayer** serves a Patron of fear and ruin: the **Whisperer**, whose prophecies come true because it whispered them first, or the **Devourer**, whose promised judgments are only its appetite given a date.
- The **Golden Calf** answers to whatever pays — commonly the **Red Sermon** again, or the **Thing Beneath the Mountain**, whose veins of easy gold are never free for long.

The reckoning, when it comes, is the Patron stepping out from behind the mask. A Prophet who has fed his Patron well enough and long enough does not retire; he is *worn* — the *Hollow Crown* of his tenth level is the Patron wearing openly, at last, the man it made. A Prophet who tries to quit, or who fails to deliver the worship he promised, learns that the Patron collects in arrears — and that a congregation can be turned upon its shepherd in a single evening.

On Naming the Unnameable

Players seldom need the truth of a Patron, and are often better without it. A Hexer knows the terms of her Bargain, not the thing's true shape; a Dark Cultist's Devotion is faith, not knowledge. Keep the Patrons mostly off the page — a rumor, a sign, a price come due — and they stay frightening. Explain one fully and you have made it a monster with a stat line, which is a far smaller thing.

VIII. Skills

The hundred small competencies between you and the grave.

Skills are the things you have learned to do on purpose. Each is tied to an ability and to a **proficiency rank** — untrained, trained, expert, or master. Once you are trained, your check is a d20 + your proficiency (your level, plus +2 trained, +4 expert, or +6 master) + the keyed ability's modifier, against a Difficulty Class; while untrained, you roll ability alone. At creation you become trained in a number of skills set by your Calling and your Wits, and you raise one skill a rank with each **skill increase** at 3rd, 5th, 7th, and 9th level, as your level allows — for out here, a thing you cannot do is a way you can die.

Skill	Ability	What It Covers
Acrobatics	DEX	Balance, tumbling, slipping a grapple or a fall
Animal Handling	PRE	Calming, driving, training beasts; reading them
Athletics	STR	Climbing, swimming, jumping, raw feats of body
Deceive	PRE	Lies, disguise, the confidence and the con
Gamble	PRE	Cards, dice, odds, and the reading of opponents
Insight	RES	Reading truth, motive, and madness in a face
Intimidate	PRE	Threats, menace, the cold promise of violence
Lore: Frontier	WIT	Towns, trails, peoples, law, history, rumor
Lore: Occult	WIT	The Old Dark, its signs, its rites, its appetites
Medicine	WIT	First aid, surgery, disease, poison, the dying
Notice	RES	Spotting the ambush, the tell, the wrong shadow

Skill	Ability	What It Covers
Persuade	PRE	Reason, charm, negotiation, the honest plea
Repair	WIT	Mending guns, tack, wagons, machinery, traps; clearing a misfire
Ride	DEX	Horsemanship, mounted fighting, hard country at speed
Sleight	DEX	Palming, pickpocketing, marking cards, hidden draws
Stealth	DEX	Moving unseen and unheard; hiding self and goods
Survival	RES	Tracking, foraging, weather, wayfinding, shelter

Using a Skill

Most of the time, the Keeper sets a DC from the table in Chapter II and you roll. Some uses deserve a word:

- **Demoralize.** A combat use of Intimidate: spend a Beat and roll Intimidate against a foe's Will save (DC 10 + half their level + their PRE modifier). On a success the target is **Frightened 1**; on a critical success, Frightened 2. Several Callings sharpen this — letting you Demoralize a whole group at once, or strike harder at the cowed.
- **Helping (Aid).** Declare you are helping before the action; on your turn, make a DC 10 check of a relevant skill. Success grants your ally +2 (a critical success, +3); a critical failure may hinder them by -1. Many hands make light a heavy door.
- **Lore as a lifeline.** A successful Lore (Occult) check may tell you what a thing is, what it wants, and what it fears — but every such check on the deep dark risks a Dread Check (Chapter XII). A *critical* success tells you all three and spares the Dread Check; a *critical* failure plants a confident lie. Knowing is never free.
- **Opposed work.** Stealth opposes Notice; Deceive opposes Insight; Sleight opposes Notice. Read these as opposed rolls, not flat DCs, when a living mind stands against you.

- **Reading the country.** A Survival check forewarns of weather, finds water, and reads how long ago something passed; against the spoor of the uncanny, the DC rises and the answer chills.
- **Untrained.** You may attempt most skills while untrained, rolling ability alone — save for Medicine (surgery), Repair (machinery), and the two Lores, which need at least Trained proficiency to attempt the hard work. The untrained do not perform amputations by guesswork. Often they perform them anyway.

At the Green Table — Each Trade Its Own Tell

Anyone may sit down to cards, and most do. Beyond the **Gamble** skill itself, every worldly Calling — and every Calling of the Old Dark — brings a small standing edge to the table, in the manner of the Gift an Origin grants. (Men and women of faith are pointedly absent from this list; the Padre would rather you came to the rail than the rake.) Each edge below is a minor knack, not a class feature.

- **Bounty Hunter — Reading the Room.** Gain +1 on Notice and Gamble checks to take the measure of a table, and you know at a glance which player is carrying the most iron — and which face matches the paper in your pocket.
- **Drifter — Stranger's Seat.** No one here has played you before. Gain +1 on Gamble checks at any table where you are not known, and a foe gets no read on your tells the first hand.
- **Gambler — The Whole Craft.** The table is your trade and it shows. Treat your proficiency rank in Gamble as one rank higher, and you may spend **Favor** on Gamble checks as on any other roll. The others bring a knack; you brought your life's work.

At the Green Table — Each Trade Its Own Tell (cont.)

- **Gunhand — Nobody Calls a Loaded Hand.** Gain +1 on Gamble checks to bluff or hold a pot while you are openly armed. Few men call a shootist's raise on a thin hand.
- **Marshal — House Rules.** Gain +1 on Gamble checks at a table where your authority is known, and +2 to catch a cheat (Notice against their Sleight). Crooked dealers fold early when a badge sits down.
- **Mountain Man — Granite Face.** Your weathered stillness gives nothing away: foes take -1 to read your tells, and you ignore the first measure of drink or fatigue that would shake another's hand.
- **Prospector — Reads the Odds Like Ore.** Gain +1 on Gamble checks in games of pure chance — faro, dice, chuck-a-luck — which you reckon as coldly as an assay.
- **Sawbones — The Body Doesn't Lie.** Gain +1 on Gamble checks to read an opponent. You mark the racing pulse, the dry mouth, the sweat at the collar — the tells a man cannot will away.
- **Dark Cultist — The Patron Smiles.** Once per session, when you stake something real, your patron tilts a single card your way: roll one Gamble check twice and keep the better. A small grace, and never a free one.
- **False Prophet — The Long Con.** Gain +1 on Gamble checks to deceive at the table; you run a crooked game as smoothly as a crooked gospel, and the marks thank you for the fleecing.
- **Hexer — Borrowed Luck.** Once per session, whisper to the Old Dark and reroll one Gamble check. The unpaid luck comes due later — a point of Nerve, or worse, at the Keeper's choosing.

At the Green Table — Each Trade Its Own Tell (cont.)

- **Witch — A Charm in the Sleeve.** Keep a small luck-charm worked beforehand; once per session it turns one losing hand into a winning one — until someone notices the brew on your breath.



"There is no such thing as a useless skill out here. There is only the skill you did not have on the one night it would have mattered, and the small wooden marker they put up after."

— FROM A PRIMER FOR GREENHORNS, SOLD FOR A DOLLAR, WORTH MORE



IX. Edges

The hard-won knacks that set the quick apart from the dead.



“The greenhorn asks what a man’s good at. The old hand asks what he’s lived through. Same question, and only one of them knows it.”

— MARSHAL T. COYLE



Every character gains an Edge at 1st level and at each odd level after — 1st, 3rd, 5th, 7th, and 9th — and may also raise one ability score by a point at 5th and 10th. Edges are the deliberate choices that shape what your character is good at. Some have requirements, noted in parentheses. A selection follows, grouped by the part of you they sharpen; your Keeper may allow others.

Edges of the Gun

These knacks come alive under the Iron Code (Chapter XI). Where one speaks of Strikes, Beats, the Multiple Attack Penalty, or misfires, see that chapter.

- **Cylinder & Sky.** (Quick Draw) Once per round, when you reduce a foe to 0 Blood, you may immediately spend a Beat you have not yet used to reload — a habit that has outlived a great many faster men.
- **Dead Eye.** (DEX 15) Once per scene, before rolling a single Strike, declare it a hit short of the impossible; it cannot be a failure, and you roll its damage twice, keeping the higher. It cannot, however, become a critical on its own.

- **Fan the Hammer.** (Quick Draw) With a single-action revolver, spend two Beats to make up to three Strikes, applying the Multiple Attack Penalty as normal but at half the usual step (–2/–4 rather than –5/–10). Loud, wasteful, final.
- **Gunfighter's Calm.** Once per scene, ignore the Multiple Attack Penalty on a single Strike — the noise falls away and the world seems to slow to let you aim.
- **Practiced Reload.** Reduce the Beats to reload any one weapon you favor by 1 (minimum 0). You clear your own misfires as a single Interact rather than an action plus a check.
- **Quick Draw.** You may draw and Strike in one motion, and add +2 to the roll deciding who shoots first.
- **Steady Shot.** If you do not move on your turn, ignore the first range increment penalty and gain +1 to hit. With a Kickback weapon you also ignore the recoil penalty.
- **Throw the Stick.** If you carry powder, you may hurl a lit charge in place of a Strike, lobbing it a fair distance to burst where it lands.
- **Two-Gun.** Fight with a pistol in each hand. Your off-hand Strike does not increase your Multiple Attack Penalty for that round, though it is still made at the current penalty.

Edges of the Body

- **Fleet.** Your Speed afoot increases by 10 feet.
- **Hard to Kill.** Once per session, when you would drop to 0 Blood, drop to 1 instead and stay on your feet. The frontier is not done with you yet.
- **Iron Gut.** +2 on Fortitude saves against poison, disease, drink, and spoiled provisions — and you can hold your liquor past any reasonable man.
- **Saddle-Born.** You and your horse act as one; never fall from the saddle by mishap, and fight mounted without penalty.
- **Tough as Rawhide.** Gain +1 Blood per level, now and as you advance.

Edges of Mind and Nerve

- **Born Lucky.** Once per session, reroll any single roll you have just made — yours, and no one else's — and keep the kinder result.
- **Cold Read.** +3 on Insight, and you may spend a moment to learn one true thing a person is trying to hide.
- **Gallows Humor.** Once per scene, crack wise in the face of the awful and recover 1d6 Nerve — yours, or a companion's who laughs.
- **Iron Will.** Once per scene, reroll a failed save against fear, charm, or compulsion and keep the better result.
- **Stone Nerve.** Gain +2 maximum Nerve per level, and +1 on Dread Checks. The horrors find you harder ground.
- **Unshakable.** (RES 13) The first time each scene you would lose Nerve, lose none instead. You have seen worse, or tell yourself so.

Edges of the Frontier

- **Dead Shot Provider.** You never want for food or fresh horses where game or ranches exist, and your camp is always well-sited.
- **Frontier Medicine.** (Trained in Medicine) Your field care heals an extra 1d6, and you can improvise a remedy from what the land offers.
- **Pathfinder.** You are never truly lost; gain +2 on overland travel and always find water, forage, and safe ground where others find none.
- **Powder Sense.** +2 to set, spot, or disarm charges and traps, and your own blasts never catch a friend you can plainly see.
- **Tracker.** +3 on Survival to track, and you may track across stone, shallow water, and the spoor of unnatural things.

Edges of the Old Dark

- **Hedge Magic.** You learn a single Sign (Chapter XIII) and gain a small Nerve pool to fuel it, though you are not a Hexer. Knowledge has a way in.
- **Salt-Wise.** +2 on Lore (Occult), and the Old Rites (Chapter XIII) take you half the usual time and materials.
- **Touched.** (RES 13) You have brushed the uncanny and lived. Gain Witch-Sight, +1 Mark, and an unsettling certainty about where the dark is thickest.
- **Warded.** (Salt-Wise) Scribe a ward at a threshold that the uncanny cannot cross uninvited for a night; the crossing costs such a thing dearly.

Edges of the Callings

The edges that follow belong to a single Calling. You may choose one only if it names a Calling you hold and you meet what it asks. These are the signatures of the trade — the moves that make a Gunhand a Gunhand, and more than a soul with a pistol and bad luck.

Worldly Callings

- **Bounty Hunter — Run It Down.** (Getaway) After a Bushwhack lands, immediately Step and Stride for free; your quarry must spend an action to break away, or you stay on him through the dust.
- **Drifter — Long Gone.** Once per scene, when no enemy is looking your way, you may slip from sight even while observed and take a free Stride into cover.
- **Gambler — Double or Nothing.** Once per scene, before you roll, name the stake: on a success the result is one degree better; on a failure, one degree worse. The house is always watching.

- **Gunhand — Pistolero's Tally.** When you drop a foe with a Strike, your next Strike this round ignores the Multiple Attack Penalty.
- **Marshal — The Long Arm.** When you Demoralize a foe or invoke the law against it, allies who can hear you gain +1 on their next Strike against that foe.
- **Mountain Man — One Shot, One Kill.** (Dead Aim) Once per scene, a steadied shot against a foe unaware of you deals **maximum** Dead Aim dice and ignores any Damage Reduction from hide or armor — the shot you spend an hour in the cold to earn.
- **Prospector — Hang Fire.** (Powderman) Set a charge to blow on a trigger you name — a tripwire, a gunshot, a spoken word — and it waits, patient as the deep, until that moment comes.
- **Prospector — Highball Charge.** (Powderman) Once per scene, overpack a single charge: it deals **maximum dice** and doubles its burst radius. Stand well back, and count your friends first.
- **Prospector — Laid By.** Once per session, declare that you laid by a useful mundane item, a cached supply, or a contact in this place — within reason, you did.
- **Sawbones — Battlefield Surgeon.** Your field care in the thick of a fight provokes no reaction and restores an extra die of Blood.

Callings of Faith

- **Medicine Man — Mending Hands.** Your remedies lift one lingering affliction — Sickened, Drained, the first grip of a curse — along with the Blood they restore.
- **Padre — Shepherd's Word.** Spend a Beat to grant an ally who can hear you an immediate save, with your bonus, against a fear already gripping them.
- **Preacher — Hellfire Sermon.** Your invocations against the unclean reach every foe who can hear your voice, not one alone.

- **Shaman — Spirit-Spoken.** Once per scene, put one yes-or-no question to the spirits about this land, its dead, or what passed here, and be answered true.
- **Witch Hunter — Bane-Sharpened.** When you exploit your quarry's known weakness, deal an extra die of damage; you also name the kind of any uncanny thing on sight.

Callings of the Old Dark

- **Dark Cultist — Devoted Unto Death.** You are immune to fear of the power you serve, and once per scene may shrug off a wound's effect for a round — the Mark keeps the tally.
- **False Prophet — Golden Tongue.** You may work a single Deceive against an entire crowd at once, as readily as against one trusting soul.
- **Hexer — Hard Bargain.** Once per scene, work a Sign for one less Nerve than it asks; the unpaid cost comes due later, at a time of the Keeper's choosing.
- **Witch — Bitter Brew.** Keep one extra charm or poison prepared, and your brews hold their potency a full day longer than another's would.

X. Goods & Provisions

Iron, leather, powder, and the price of everything.

Coin in the Territories is reckoned in dollars and bits — a bit being one eighth of a dollar, twelve and a half cents, the width of a hard day's wage. What follows are fair prices in a fair town; a remote post or a desperate hour will charge what it likes. Your starting wealth depends on your Calling, rolled below and spent before play.

Calling	Starting Coin
Bounty Hunter	3d6 × \$10 (in collected bounties)
Dark Cultist	2d6 × \$5, plus the favor of the patron
Drifter	2d6 × \$10
False Prophet	3d6 × \$10 (collected, never earned)
Gambler	3d6 × \$10 (as the cards fell)
Gunhand	3d6 × \$10
Hexer	2d6 × \$5
Marshal	3d6 × \$10, plus a badge or its like
Medicine Man	2d6 × \$10, plus a healer's kit & herbs
Mountain Man	2d6 × \$10 in pelts, plus a rifle, traps, and a good knife
Padre	2d6 × \$10, plus vestments & a relic
Preacher	2d6 × \$10, plus a holy book
Prospector	3d6 × \$10, plus prospecting tools

Calling	Starting Coin
Sawbones	3d6 × \$10, plus a surgeon's kit
Shaman	2d6 × \$5, plus the regard of the spirits
Witch	2d6 × \$5, plus a familiar
Witch Hunter	3d6 × \$10, plus silver for a few rounds



“Everything’s for sale and nothing’s cheap. A man comes down out of the high country once a season, trades his pelts, and rides out with half what he meant to carry and twice what he’ll need to bury him. That’s commerce.”

— EB TUTTLE, OUTFITTER, CALVARY WELLS MERCANTILE



Of Rarity — Common, Uncommon & Rare

Goods in this country come in three grades. **Common** items fill any general store and carry the listed price; unless a thing is marked otherwise, treat everything in the tables of this chapter as Common. **Uncommon** items are scarce, specialized, or controlled — found only in a city, a fort, or by special order, and dearer for the trouble (the Keeper may add a surcharge of half again or more, and a roll to locate one at all). **Rare** items are another matter entirely. They are seldom for sale at any honest price, and the truest of them are not mundane goods but **relics and artifacts** — objects with a real and uncanny power, the haunted frontier's answer to the enchanted swords and holy relics of older tales. A Rare item is found, won, inherited, or stolen; it is the Keeper's to place, never the player's to purchase;

Of Rarity — Common, Uncommon & Rare (cont.)

and it nearly always carries a history, a hunger, or a price folded inside the gift.

Firearms

Damage is rolled on a hit. **Range** is the increment in feet; each full increment beyond the first is a cumulative –2 to hit. **Cap.** is how many shots before reloading. **Reload** is the Beats (actions) it takes to make the weapon ready again, per the Iron Code (Chapter XI). **Traits** are explained below. Black powder fouls, misfires in the wet, and gives away your position with smoke — the Keeper may make much of this.

Weapon	Damage	Range	Cap.	Reload	Traits	Cost
Buffalo Rifle	1d12	250	1	1	Kickback, Volley 30 ft, Fatal d12	\$55
Cap-and-Ball Revolver	1d8	40	6	slow	Fatal d10, Misfire 2	\$12
Derringer	1d6	20	2	1	Concealable, Fatal d8, Misfire 1	\$8
Double-Barrel Shotgun	2d8	30	2	1	Scatter 10 ft, Kickback, Fatal d12	\$25
Lever-Action Repeater	1d10	120	12	1/shot	Repeating, Fatal d12	\$40
Single-Action Revolver	1d8	50	6	1/shot	Fatal d10, Misfire 1	\$20

Weapon Traits

- **Concealable.** +2 to hide it on your person, and it may be drawn as part of the Strike rather than a separate Beat.
- **Fatal dX.** On a critical hit, this weapon's damage dice all become dX, and you add one extra die of that size. A gun is at its most honest in the half-second it kills you.
- **Kickback.** The recoil is brutal. Take -2 to the Strike unless your STR is 12 or higher, or you spend a Beat to brace (Aim). Firing a Kickback weapon without bracing leaves you Off-Guard until your next turn.
- **Misfire X.** On a critical failure to hit (or any natural 1), the weapon jams. Clearing it costs an Interact action and a Repair check (DC 10 + X). In wet weather, increase X by 1 for black-powder arms.
- **Reach.** The weapon strikes at a step's distance — a lance, spear, pike, or fixed bayonet. It can hit a foe (or a rider) one rank back, and lets a footman set against a charge (see *Fighting from the Saddle*).
- **Repeating.** Holds many rounds. Loading a single round is one Interact; a full reload follows the rule below.
- **Scatter X.** On a hit, deal 1d6 splash damage to every creature within X feet of the target. On a miss within the first range increment, the target still takes the splash.
- **Two-Handed.** The weapon needs both hands to wield. You cannot also manage a shield, the reins, or a second gun, and using it from a moving horse is doubly awkward.
- **Volley X.** This long iron is made for distance; Strikes against targets within X feet take -2.

Reloading

"Reload 1/shot" means each shot can be chambered with one Beat, firing and feeding in rhythm. "Reload 1" single-shot arms spend one Beat to load the next round. A **slow** reload (the cap-and-ball revolver) means fully recharging the cylinder takes three rounds of

dedicated work — which is why a wise gunhand carries a second loaded cylinder, or a second gun. Topping a capacity or repeating weapon back to full takes Beats equal to half its capacity, rounded up.

Blades & Bludgeons

Weapon	Damage	Notes
Club / Rifle-Butt	1d6	Common; nonlethal by choice
Fists / Boots	1d3	Nonlethal unless you mean it; Agile
Hatchet	1d6	Throwable to 20 ft
Knife / Bowie	1d4	Concealable; Agile; +1 on a Sudden Strike
Saber / Cavalry Sword	1d8	Reach and heft; favored mounted

***Agile** weapons reduce the Multiple Attack Penalty (–4 / –8 instead of –5 / –10). A blade with the Fatal trait is rare and dear; most simply cut.*

On Armor

There is precious little armor in this country, and less that helps. A heavy duster or buffalo coat turns a knife and the cold; boiler-plate and scavenged iron will stop a pistol ball at the cost of speed and sweat. Note the hard truth plainly: **most firearms ignore most armor**. Worn armor grants Damage Reduction against blades and small shot only; cover and not being shot remain your best defense.

Protection	Effect	Cost
Boiled Leather	DR 2 vs blades; –1 Defense	\$15

Protection	Effect	Cost
Heavy Duster / Coat	DR 1 vs blades; warmth	\$6
Scavenged Iron Plate	DR 3, stops pistol ball; –2 Speed, loud	\$60

Provisions, Gear & Sundries

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
50 ft hemp rope	75¢	Bandages, per use	10¢
Bedroll & tarp	\$2	Bottle of whiskey	50¢
Box of cartridges (50)	\$1	Graveyard salt, lb.	\$1
Holy book	\$3	Lantern & oil	\$1
Laudanum, per dose	25¢	Shovel / tools	\$2
Silver ball, each	\$5	Spyglass	\$8
Stick of dynamite	\$2	Surgeon's kit	\$10
Talisman or charm	\$2–\$20	Week's rations	\$3

Tonics & the Sawbones' Trade

Prepared doses (a Sawbones' Tonics, or bought dear) take a Beat to administer. Their use, and their abuse, ride together:

- **Antitoxin.** +5 on the next save against a poison or disease, or a fresh save against one already taking hold.

- **Laudanum.** Restores 1d6 Nerve and quiets pain (ignore the penalty of one Lasting Injury for an hour). Lean on it and court the vice — repeated use demands rising Fortitude saves against Drained.
- **Sedative.** Calms a panicking patient: ends one fright and grants a new save against an Affliction, but renders them Clumsy and slow for ten minutes.
- **Stimulant.** Removes Fatigued and suppresses Frightened for one scene; afterward, a DC 13 Fortitude save or take Fatigued.

Special Ammunition

The uncanny does not always heed lead. The wise carry alternatives, dear as they are: **silver** balls bite the lycanthrope and the restless dead; **rock-salt** loads scatter the spectral and drive off the merely living without killing (treat as nonlethal, Scatter 5 ft); **blessed or cold-iron** rounds wound things that shrug off ordinary fire. Against a thing that should not be, the right ammunition is the difference between a fight and a funeral — yours.

Mounts & Tack

A horse is not a luxury here; it is the line between a journey and a death. The mount you ride decides how far you go in a day, what you can carry, and whether you outrun trouble or are run down by it.

Mount	Speed	Blood	Def	Carry	Cost
Burro / Donkey	40 ft	16	11	130 lb	\$12
Cow Pony / Mustang	55 ft	20	12	200 lb	\$25
Draft Horse	45 ft	30	11	400 lb	\$60
Fine Saddle Horse	65 ft	24	13	230 lb	\$90+

Mount	Speed	Blood	Def	Carry	Cost
Mule	50 ft	26	11	260 lb	\$30
Ox (per yoke)	30 ft	34	10	pulls	\$35
Riding Horse	60 ft	22	12	230 lb	\$40
Trained Warhorse	60 ft	28	13	250 lb	\$150+

A horse kicks for 1d6 and bites for 1d4; a warhorse is trained to do both in a fight and to hold its ground against the uncanny. A mule is slower and stubborn but tougher of gut, surer on bad ground, and far harder to spook — which in this country is often worth more than speed. Saddle, bridle, and blanket run about \$15 the set.

Tack & Trappings

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Bedroll & tarp	\$2	Feedbag & a week's grain	\$2
Hobbles / picket line	50¢	Lariat / lasso (60 ft)	\$1
Packsaddle (mule)	\$6	Saddle scabbard (long gun)	\$4
Saddle, bridle & blanket (set)	\$15	Saddlebags	\$3
Shoeing (set of four)	\$1	Spurs	\$2

On the Trail

At a steady **walk** a mount covers about **30 miles a day** over good ground — half that in mountains, mud, or snow. A **trot** doubles the distance but wears on animal and rider alike; a **gallop** is for emergencies only, good for a mile or two before the horse must be walked or be ruined. Push a mount past its wind and the rider makes a Ride check each hour; on a failure the animal falters, founders,

or — driven long enough — dies under you. Grain, water, and rest are not optional out here.

A Horse's Nerve

Animals know the dark before their riders do. The first time a mount faces a monster, an explosion, or a soul gone deep into the Mark, the rider rolls **Ride** against the thing's Dread DC; on a failure the animal bolts, bucks, rears, or flatly refuses, and may throw its rider (see *Fighting from the Saddle*, Chapter XI). A mule rolls this with a bonus; a trained warhorse ignores ordinary frights altogether.

More Arms & Powder

The five irons of the foregoing table are the common run; a person with coin and a particular need has further choices. Traits are explained on the previous pages and apply as written.

Weapon	Damage	Range	Cap.	Reload	Traits	Cost
Bolt / Trapdoor Rifle	1d12	200	1	1	Volley 30 ft, Fatal d12	\$30
Bow / Crossbow	1d8	60	1	1	Silent; Volley 20 ft (bow)	\$6
Carbine (lever)	1d10	90	8	1/shot	Repeating, Fatal d12	\$34
Coach Gun (sawed-off)	2d8	15	2	1	Scatter 15 ft, Concealable, Kickback	\$22
Coal-Oil Bomb	1d6 fire	15*	—	—	Thrown; Scatter 5 ft, persists 1 round	50¢
Heavy "Walker" Revolver	1d10	50	6	slow	Kickback, Fatal d12, Misfire 1	\$22
Pepperbox Pistol	1d6	25	5	slow	Concealable, Misfire 2	\$10

Weapon	Damage	Range	Cap.	Reload	Traits	Cost
Pocket Revolver	1d6	30	5	1/shot	Concealable, Fatal d8, Misfire 1	\$14
Stick of Dynamite	2d6	10*	—	—	Thrown; 10-ft burst, Reflex DC 15 half	\$2
Throwing Knife / Tomahawk	1d4 / 1d6	20	—	—	Thrown, Agile (knife)	\$1
Wall / Punt Gun	3d10	80	1	slow	Scatter 20 ft, Kickback, Volley 20 ft	\$70

**Thrown explosives use the range as a throwing increment, not a shooting one. A Prospector ignores the scatter against themselves and may shape the burst (Chapter V).*

Ammunition & Specialty Rounds

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Blessed round, each	\$4	Cold-iron round, each	\$3
Incendiary / phosphor round	\$2	Metallic cartridges, box of 50	\$1.25
Paper cartridges, per 50	\$1	Percussion caps, tin of 100	50¢
Powder & ball, per 50	75¢	Powder horn / flask	75¢
Rock-salt load, each	25¢	Shotgun shells, box of 25	\$1
Silver ball / round, each	\$5	Soft-lead (hollow) round	15¢

***Soft-lead** rounds add +1 damage against the unarmored living but lose a die against anything with Damage Reduction. **Incendiary** rounds set the dry and the oily alight; the Keeper adjudicates the blaze.*

Weapon Furniture

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Bandolier / cartridge belt	\$2	Bayonet / knife mount	\$2
Cleaning kit & gun oil	\$1.50	Holster, plain	\$1
Quick-draw / cross-draw rig	\$4	Saddle scabbard	\$4
Shoulder rig (concealed)	\$3	Spare loaded cylinder	\$6
Speed-loader (rare)	\$8	Telescopic sight	\$25

A *spare loaded cylinder* turns a slow cap-and-ball reload into a single Interact — the difference, often, between a story told and a stone carved.

Clothing & the Cold

The country kills more travelers with weather than with lead. Dress for the one and you may live to worry about the other.

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Bandana / kerchief	15¢	Buffalo / fur coat	\$14
Fine Stetson	\$10	Hat (felt or straw)	\$2
Leather gloves / gauntlets	\$1	Oilskin slicker	\$3
Snowshoes	\$3	Spectacles	\$4
Spurs & chaps	\$4	Sunday best	\$12
Tinted "glare" glasses	\$2	Working clothes & boots	\$5

Tools of Many Trades

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Apothecary / brewing kit	\$8	Blacksmith's tools	\$12
Branding iron	\$2	Carpenter's / general tools	\$4
Climbing kit & pitons	\$5	Field camera & plates	\$30
Lockpicks / skeleton keys	\$8	Manacles & key	\$3
Prospecting kit (pan, pick, rod)	\$6	Sewing / tailoring kit	\$1
Surgeon's kit (refill)	\$10	Telegraph key (portable)	\$15

The Camp & the Trail

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Bullseye / dark lantern	\$3	Candles, dozen	20¢
Canteen / water-skin	75¢	Canvas tent (two-soul)	\$5
Compass	\$2	Cook pot, pan & tin	\$1.50
Fishing line & hooks	25¢	Matches, tin of 100	10¢
Panniers (pair)	\$4	Sextant	\$20
Steel traps, each	\$1	Territory map (fair)	\$3
Tinderbox & flint	25¢	Wool blanket	\$2

Vittles & Comforts

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Airtights (canned goods), each	25¢	Bottle of fine brandy	\$3
Bottle of whiskey	50¢	Cigars, each	10¢
Coffee, lb.	35¢	Flour / beans, lb.	5¢
Hardtack & jerky, lb.	20¢	Hot meal, saloon	25¢
Patent "cure-all" tonic	50¢	Sugar, lb.	12¢
Tobacco & papers	25¢	Week's trail rations	\$3

Provisions Against the Dark

A wise soul lays in more than powder. These are dear, often hard to find, and worth every cent the night you need them. Several are the working stock of the Callings of Faith and of the Old Dark — a Padre's vial, a Witch's herb, a Hexer's chalk.

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Beeswax candles & incense	\$1	Blessed oil, vial	\$1.50
Church bell, hand	\$4	Cornmeal & chalk (sigils)	20¢
Divining rod / pendulum	\$1	Graveyard salt, lb.	\$1
Hand mirror	\$1	Holy water, vial	\$1
Horseshoe / iron nails	25¢	Iron filings, lb.	75¢
Mojo bag / charm	\$2–\$20	Sage, wolfsbane, herbs, bundle	75¢

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Saint's relic (true)	rare	Silver crucifix / medal	\$6
Spirit-board	\$2	Warding chalk & tallow	50¢

Most of these do nothing in untrained hands but reassure. In trained hands — a Padre's, a Witch's, a Hexer's — they are the difference between a rite that holds and one that lets the dark in behind it.

Services & Lodging

Service	Cost	Service	Cost
Bath & shave	25¢	Coffin & burial	\$15
Doctor's visit	\$2	Laundry, the load	20¢
Lawyer, per matter	\$10+	Letter & postage	3¢
Posting a bounty	\$5+	Rail ticket, per mile	3¢
Room, per night	25–75¢	Stabling a horse, night	25¢
Stagecoach, per mile	10¢	Telegram, per word	2¢

Livestock & Conveyances

Animal / Vehicle	Cost	Notes
Buckboard wagon	\$45	Light haul; needs a team
Buggy / surrey	\$60	Town conveyance for those with airs
Canoe / flatboat	\$8 / \$25	For the rivers, where the roads give out

Animal / Vehicle	Cost	Notes
Cattle dog	\$3	Loyal, loud, and the first to smell the dark
Conestoga / freight wagon	\$120	The home you drag west
Draft horse / ox	\$60 / \$35	For plow and wagon; oxen tireless, slow
Fine saddle horse	\$90+	Faster, braver, far more spirited
Mule	\$30	Slow, stubborn, sure on bad ground; hard to spook
Mustang (green-broke)	\$18	Cheap, hardy, may yet throw you
Pack mule / burro	\$15	Carries the camp so you needn't
Riding horse (sound)	\$40	Blood 22, Def 12, Speed 60 ft, kick 1d6



"I have buried men who skimmed on the horse and men who skimmed on the salt, and I will tell you the salt funerals were the worse to look upon. Spend on both. You can always sell a good horse. You cannot un-see what comes for the one who saved a dollar on the salt."

— EB TUTTLE, OUTFITTER, CALVARY WELLS MERCANTILE



Uncommon Goods

The following are **Uncommon**: scarce, specialized, or controlled. A general store will not stock them. Expect to find them only in a city, a fort, a railhead, or by special order — and to pay a surcharge of half again or more for the privilege, after a roll to turn one up at all.

Item	Cost	Item	Cost
Astronomer's telescope	\$30	Book of true occult lore	\$25
Carrier pigeons, trained pair	\$8	Chemist's / forensic kit	\$20
Crude diving apparatus	\$40	Disguise & theatrical kit	\$12
Dynamite, case of ten	\$18	Ether, anesthetic bottle	\$4
Forged papers, the set	\$10+	Good strongbox / safe	\$30
Hand printing press	\$60	Iron vest (turns pistol ball)	\$50
Jointed prosthetic limb	\$25–\$60	Lever-action shotgun	\$45
Master lockbreaker's tools	\$20	Matched scope & target rifle	\$80
Morphine & syringe kit	\$12	Mountaineering rig	\$12
Nitroglycerin, vial (volatile)	\$10	Repeating crossbow	\$20
Superior doctor's bag	\$30	Trained bloodhound	\$15
Camera & wet-plate kit	\$35	Blasting machine & wire	\$25
Coffin, lead-lined	\$30	Galvanic battery, medical	\$15
Pinkerton file on a name	\$15+	Surveyor's transit & chains	\$25

Superior doctor's bag. Grants +2 to Medicine and lets a Sawbones or Medicine Man treat one extra patient between rests. **Iron vest.** DR 3 against pistol balls and small shot, but –2 Speed and loud; most long irons still punch clean through. **Book of true occult lore.** A month's careful study grants +2 to Lore: Occult, or — at the Keeper's discretion, and at the usual risk — the working of a single Sign. **Camera & wet-plate kit.** A long exposure and a steady hand make a portrait — and now and again the plate holds what the eye refused: a figure at the window, a face in the smoke. The camera does not lie, which is exactly the trouble with it. **Coffin, lead-lined.** A body sealed in lead and buried proper does not rise. Usually. **Pinkerton file on a name.** Bought quiet from an agency man: aliases, known associates, last verified whereabouts. The Keeper answers three plain questions about the name; the fourth costs more than money.

Rare — Charms & Lesser Relics

Here the goods stop being merely goods. Each of the following is **Rare** and carries a small but true uncanny power. None is reliably for sale; each is found, won, or inherited, and placed by the Keeper. The lesser relics below are potent without being world-shaking — a good first taste of the magic of the haunted frontier.

Hangman's Coin (Rare · cursed)

A coin taken from a hanged man's eyes. Once, spend it to turn a failed save against death into a success — but the dead man wants it back, and from that night he walks a step behind you in dreams, holding out his hand.

Dead Man's Compass (Rare)

Its needle points not north, but toward the nearest restless dead within a mile — or, when there are none, toward the thing you most fear. It is never wrong about either, which is the trouble with it.

Witch-Bottle (Rare · one use)

A stoppered bottle of pins, nails, and worse, buried at a threshold. It catches the next curse or Hex laid upon the household and turns it back, entire, upon the one who cast it. Then it shatters, its work done.

Saint's Finger-Bone (Rare · true relic)

A genuine relic in a silver reliquary. Once per day, add a die to one healing or warding you perform, and the lesser uncanny will not lay hands on the bearer without first making a Will save. Faith, made into an object you can lose.

Gambler's Marked Deck (Rare · cursed)

Once per session, force a single roll to be rerolled — yours or another's — as the cards decide. But the deck always collects in the end: the Keeper holds one reroll in reserve to use against you, at the worst possible hour, and you will know it is the deck by the cold that comes with it.

Ghost-Iron Spurs (Rare)

Forged from a graveyard's fence. Your mount cannot be panicked by the uncanny, and once per scene may outrun anything dead that pursues it, however fast that dead thing flies.

Salt of the Forty Martyrs (Rare · consumable, a few uses)

Blessed graveyard salt of terrible potency. A pinch makes any single ward you lay so strong that the uncanny save against it at a steep penalty. A small tin holds perhaps three pinches, and there is no more being made.

Coyote's Tooth (Rare · cursed)

A yellowed canine on a leather cord, taken — so the story goes — from the Trickster's own jaw while he slept. Once per session, slip free of any one thing that holds you: a knot, a manacle, a grapple, a cell. But the tooth loves a liar, and while you wear it small falsehoods come easier than truths, until the people who know you best begin to hear it.

Widow's Locket (Rare)

A mourning locket holding a faded portrait of someone else's beloved dead. The dead one keeps watch: once per session the locket grows cold a moment before an ambush, a betrayal, or a bullet with your name on it. But grief clings to the bearer like woodsmoke, and the locket's price is that the dead beloved must be mourned as your own — skip the graveside visit too long and the warnings stop.

Church-Door Nail (Rare · one use)

A hand-forged nail drawn from the door of a church that stood a hundred years and never burned. Driven into a threshold, a gatepost, or a wagon-board at dusk, no uncanny thing may cross that doorway until sunrise. In the morning the nail is only iron, its century spent in a single night.

Rare — Artifacts & Relics of Power

And here are the great ones: **Rare** artifacts of real power, each unique, each the heart of a story. Treat these as you would the legendary relics of older tales — won at cost, never bought, and never without a history folded inside. Most carry a price, a curse, or a hunger. A campaign need hold only one or two.

The Peacemaker's Last Round (Rare · artifact, one use)

A single cartridge of blessed silver, its casing scribed with a dying prayer. Fired at any Marked or uncanny thing, it cannot miss and strikes as a critical hit, Fatal die and all. Then it is spent forever — and the gun that fired it never shoots quite true again, having known perfection once.

Vial from the Weeping Spring (Rare · artifact)

Water from a spring that should not weep. A single swallow cures any affliction, mends grievous wounds, and within a minute of death will call a willing soul back into its body. There is only ever a little — three sips, perhaps — and it refills for no one, save at the spring itself, wherever in the world that has wandered to now.

Saint Dymphna's Bell (Rare · artifact · true relic)

A small hand-bell of cracked bronze. Rung, it ends a possession or calms every maddened and Frightened mind within earshot, and bars the uncanny from crossing its sound. The bell cracks a little further with each ringing; no one knows how many peals remain in it, and the bearer dares not waste one finding out.

The Cartographer's Eye (Rare · artifact · cursed)

A glass eye that sees what the living one cannot: through illusion and disguise, into the thin places, and across the true and dreadful shape of haunted ground. It showed its first owner the hour and manner of his own death, exactly once, and it will show you yours the day you first put it in. It has never yet been wrong.

The Hanged Man's Rope (Rare · artifact · cursed)

A noose that never frays and never breaks, and binds even the uncanny fast where chain and iron fail. But it is heavy with the despair of all it has held; carry it long, and that weight settles into the bearer, draining hope and Nerve until the rope begins to seem less a tool than a suggestion.

The Conquistador's Cuirass (Rare · artifact · cursed)

A blackened Spanish breastplate three centuries old. It turns even rifle balls (DR against firearms), an unheard-of protection — but it remembers the will of the man who died in it, and whispers in old Castilian, and covets the wearer. Wear it through enough battles and the cuirass begins, quietly, to decide which of you is in command.

The Iron Star (Rare · artifact · true relic)

The badge of a sheriff who never once broke his word or abandoned the helpless. Shown to a liar, it compels the truth; worn, it steadies the bearer's Nerve against any terror. But it holds its wearer to the old lawman's code as surely as a geas: turn your back on the innocent while

you wear the Star, and it will burn cold against your chest until you cannot bear it — or until you become someone who can, which is the worse outcome by far.

The Padre's Lantern (Rare · artifact · true relic)

A dented tin lantern carried on the mission trails by a padre who walked the worst of this country and was never once touched. Lit, its circle of light is honest ground: nothing within it may wear a false face, hold an illusion, or hide its true shape — and the uncanny must save even to step into the glow. But the light is honest about the bearer too. Within the circle you cannot lie, cannot conceal, cannot be hidden from what hunts you; the lantern makes its carrier the brightest thing on the plain, and it has outlived every soul who carried it.

The Bone Fiddle (Rare · artifact · cursed)

Strung with gut and pegged in yellowed bone, its maker unknown and better left so. Played, it commands the dead: every restless thing in earshot — the Risen, the walkers, the things half-through the door — stops to listen for as long as the tune holds, and a masterful player can walk them a slow measure back toward their graves. But the tunes it plays are not learned from the living, and each performance is a conversation: the dead hear where the fiddle is, they remember the fiddler kindly, and one night, when the playing is done, they will want a tune of their own choosing.

The Meridian Chain (Rare · artifact)

A surveyor's chain of sixty-six iron feet, struck — the story runs — from the first true meridian stake driven in the Territories. Ground enclosed by the chain between dusk and dawn is *surveyed*: it belongs, for that night, to the living, and the uncanny must save at a steep penalty to cross the line. One acre, no more, and the chain must be taken up and laid fresh each evening by the same hands. Homesteads have stood forty years behind it. Every one of them fell the year its keeper grew too old to walk the line, and forgot a single corner.

The Ferryman's Dollar (Rare · artifact · cursed)

A worn silver dollar, minted no year a living man can find in a ledger. Held under the tongue, it lets the bearer walk unseen among the dead for a scene — the restless take you for one of their own, and let you pass, and answer what you ask them in their fashion. But the coin is fare, not disguise: each crossing, make a Will save or leave a little of yourself on the far bank. Those who use it often are known by their gray eyes and their quiet, and by how the dogs no longer bark at them.

A Note on What Is Not Here

You will find no nation's nor any living faith's sacred objects laid out as loot in these pages — no medicine bundles, no stolen ceremonial regalia, no holy thing of a people still praying with it. Such items are not treasure, and a table reaching for that well should reach instead for the care urged in Chapter IV. There is no shortage of invented relics in a haunted country. Make your own; the dark is generous with them.



"Every one of these cursed marvels was somebody's salvation once, and every one of them is for sale now, which tells you exactly how that salvation went. Buy the rope if you must. Just don't be surprised when you start to feel how many necks it has known, and how patient it is, and how well it fits."

— EB TUTTLE, OUTFITTER, DECLINING TO SET A PRICE



XI. Conflict & the Iron Code

How violence is reckoned, and how quickly it ends a life.

Violence in *Blood and Grit* is fast, ugly, and rarely fair. A gunfight is not a duel of attrition; it is a handful of seconds in which someone dies. Fight only when you must, from cover when you can, and never in the belief that your numbers make you safe. They do not. The rules of the gun are called the **Iron Code** — not a law any marshal enforces, but the plain arithmetic of powder and flesh that the country enforces for itself.

Rounds, Turns, and the Three Beats

When blood is in the offing, time breaks into **rounds** of roughly six seconds. Everyone rolls **initiative** — a Notice check (or another skill the Keeper calls for, after the manner of Pathfinder 2E) — and acts from highest to lowest. On your turn you have three **Beats** — the small, equal measures of what a person can do in those six seconds. Spend them in any order, and on any mix of the actions below. A second Strike in a turn is harder than the first; a third, harder still. That is the whole of the Code, and the whole of why patient people outlive quick ones.

Action	Beats	What It Does
Aim / Brace	1	+2 on your next Strike before your turn ends; braces a Kickback weapon.
Interact	1	Draw or stow a weapon, clear a jam, work a lever, open a door, fetch a tonic.
Reload	varies	Make a spent weapon ready; see Reloading below.

Action	Beats	What It Does
Steady a Soul	1	A shout, a hand, a Command — many Calling features cost a Beat. The feature says so.
Stride	1	Move up to your Speed. Mounted, move your horse's Speed.
Strike	1	One attack with a readied weapon. Subject to the Multiple Attack Penalty.
Take Cover	1	Press to available cover, improving its bonus by one step until you leave it.

***Free of charge.** A single short phrase, dropping prone, and letting go of what you hold cost no Beat. **Reactions.** Once between your turns you may take one reaction. The common one is Dive for Cover: when you can see the shot coming — a leveled gun, a lit fuse — drop prone and gain the benefit of cover against that one attack, at the cost of being Prone when you rise.*

The Strike, and the Multiple Attack Penalty

To make a Strike, roll d20 + your attack (your level, adjusted by your Calling's rank — Chapter XIV) + the keyed ability — DEX for guns and thrown, STR for blades and fists — against the target's **Defense**. Your first Strike in a turn is clean. Your second takes a **Multiple Attack Penalty (MAP)** of –5; your third, –10. An **Agile** weapon (a knife, a light blade) softens this to –4 and –8. The penalty resets at the start of each of your turns. The Code rewards the one good shot over the three wild ones — as the dead could tell you, if the dead said much.

The Four Degrees of Success

Every Strike, and many a desperate skill check besides, has not two outcomes but four. Compare your total to the Defense (or DC):

Result	How It Lands
Critical Success	Beat the number by 10 or more, <i>or</i> roll a natural 20 that also hits. Deal double damage and apply the weapon's Fatal die. A wound to be buried with.
Success	Meet or beat the number. Roll damage and subtract it from their Blood.
Failure	Fall short. No harm done — this time.
Critical Failure	Miss by 10 or more, <i>or</i> roll a natural 1. The shot is wasted, and a weapon with the Misfire trait jams (see Chapter X).

This is the spine of the Iron Code: the same roll that decides whether you hit also decides whether you hit *well*, and whether your own iron betrays you. A natural 20 always at least hits; a natural 1 always at least misses. The country humbles the sure.

Circumstance

Few shots are taken on a fair field. The Keeper applies what the moment warrants:

Circumstance	Effect on the Strike
Beyond first range increment	–2 per full increment past the first
Firing into melee	–4, or a miss may strike a friend at the Keeper's call
Point-blank (adjacent)	No range penalty; a long gun is unwieldy this close (–2 unless braced)
Target behind cover (light / heavy)	–2 / –4 to hit; <i>Take Cover</i> improves the target's by one step
Target fully concealed	Cannot be targeted directly; fire blind at –8 and guess the square
Target Off-Guard	+2 to hit; a Drifter adds Sudden Strike damage

Circumstance	Effect on the Strike
You Aimed and did not move	+2 on the Strike (does not stack with itself)

Off-Guard is the Code's word for a target who cannot properly defend — unaware of you, flanked between two foes, caught unready at the first instant of a fight, or knocked sprawling. An Off-Guard creature is easier to hit and easier to hit well.

Aiming and Bracing

Patience is a weapon. Spend a Beat to **Aim** and your next Strike before your turn ends gains +2. A Kickback weapon — a shotgun, a buffalo rifle — punishes the hasty: fire it without bracing and you take -2 and stand Off-Guard until your next turn, unless your STR is 12 or better. Spending a Beat to **brace** (the same action as Aim) plants your feet and lifts both penalties. A long gun fired from a galloping horse is a prayer, not a plan.

Reloading

An empty gun is an expensive club. How long it takes to feed it depends on the iron:

- **1 / shot.** A single-action revolver or lever repeater takes one Interact to chamber or thumb in one round between Strikes — or a full reload to top off (below).
- **Full reload.** Topping a capacity or repeating weapon all the way back to full takes Beats equal to half its capacity, rounded up — a six-gun, three Beats; a twelve-shot repeater, six. The *Practiced Reload* Edge shaves one Beat from a weapon you favor.
- **Single (1).** A break-action — derringer, double shotgun, single-shot rifle — is one Interact to reload fully.
- **Slow (cap-and-ball).** Powder, ball, and cap by hand: a cap-and-ball revolver takes **three rounds** of dedicated work to make ready, and cannot be partially loaded in a hurry. This is the price of the cheapest gun in the book.

A wet day fouls black powder: increase a black-powder weapon's Misfire value by 1 (Chapter X), and clearing the jam is the more anxious for the rain running down your collar.

Wounds, Bleeding, and Death

Your **Blood** is your hit points; it is also, plainly, your blood. At **0 Blood** you fall, **Dying** and bleeding — losing 1 Blood each round — until someone stabilizes you or you reach **–CON**, at which point you are dead, and out here dead is dead. A Fortitude save (DC 15) or a Medicine check (DC 15) can stop the bleeding; a point of Grit can keep you upright and acting one round more (Chapter II).

Damage Reduction (DR) and **resistance**. Some armor, hides, and unnatural toughness grant **Damage Reduction**: subtract that number from the Blood lost to each qualifying hit, so *DR 2 vs blades* turns a six-Blood knife wound into four. DR never lowers a hit below zero, and a noted limit (*vs blades*, *vs nonmagical*) means it helps only against that source. A creature with **resistance** to a kind of harm — fire, lead, the merely mortal — treats it as steep DR against that source and may shrug such blows off almost wholly; overcoming a resistance, with silver or fire or a blessed weapon, is often the whole of the problem.

Fighting from the Saddle

A horse turns a gunfight into a moving thing. The rules below cover a rider and mount in a fight; the mount's own statistics and temperament are in Chapter X (*Mounts & Tack*).

The Mount's Movement

You and your mount act on your turn, sharing your three Beats. Spend a Beat to have a trained horse Stride its full Speed; you may move before and after a Strike as your Beats allow. Controlling a calm, trained mount is free. Controlling a green, wounded, or frightened one costs a Beat and a **Ride** check — fail, and the animal does as it pleases. A galloping

mount that Strides at least 30 feet in a straight line lets you ride a foe down or break clean past a line.

Shooting from Horseback

From a **standing or walking** horse you fire as normal. From a **trotting or galloping** horse, every ranged attack takes **–2** for the moving platform, you cannot *Aim* or *Brace*, and a two-handed long gun (rifle, carbine, shotgun) takes a further **–2** and cannot be reloaded until you slow to a walk. The pistol is the horseman's weapon for good reason: fired one-handed, it leaves a hand for the reins.

Striking from Horseback

Mounted, you strike **down** at a foe on foot: gain **+1** to melee Strikes against the unmounted, and a footman needs reach — a spear, a polearm, a bayonet — or an Acrobatics check to strike back at you rather than at the horse. A two-handed melee weapon swung from the saddle is awkward (**–2**); the cavalry carries a saber and a lance for a reason.

The Charge

If your mount Strides at least **20 feet** in a straight line into a foe and you Strike with a **lance, spear, or saber**, the blow deals **+1 die** of damage — a couched lance deals **double dice** on a hit. You are committed and off-balance after: **–2** Defense until your next turn. A foe who sets a braced polearm or bayonet against your charge lands their blow on your mount first.

Keeping the Saddle

You may be thrown when the horse takes a critical hit, when it bolts or rears, or when you yourself take a critical melee blow. Make a **Ride** save (DC 15, or the attacker's result); on a failure you are unhorsed — fall prone, take **1d6** damage, and land a few feet from the animal. Mounting or vaulting up on purpose costs a Beat (a Drifter or a Veteran may do it free). A rider who has lost his horse is, all at once, just a person standing in the open.

From the Saddle, by Weapon

- **Carbine / rifle / shotgun.** –2 at a gallop and again for being two-handed (–4 in all); no reload above a walk. A saddle scabbard keeps it to hand.
- **Knife, hatchet, fists.** Usable but graceless from the saddle, and they earn no charge bonus.
- **Pistol / revolver.** No penalty at a walk; –2 at a gallop. The ideal horseback arm — one-handed and quick to holster.
- **Saber / lance / spear.** The charge weapons: +1 die on a charge, double dice for a couched lance. A saber also serves at a stand, the mounted –2 waived.
- **Thrown (dynamite, knife, bottle).** –2 from a moving horse — and pray the fuse and the gallop agree.

Grievous Wounds

Guns are made to maim. When a single blow deals damage equal to half your maximum Blood or more, or on any **critical hit**, you must make a Fortitude save (DC 15, or higher for terrible weapons) or suffer a **Lasting Injury** — roll on the table below. These do not heal with rest alone; they require a Sawbones, time, and sometimes a graveyard.

d6	Lasting Injury
1	Bloody Gash — bleed 1 extra until doctored; a scar to remember it by
2	Cracked Ribs — –2 on STR and DEX actions until healed
3	Maimed Hand — drop what you hold; –4 on tasks needing two good hands
4	Lamed Leg — Speed halved until set and rested a week

d6 Lasting Injury

- | | |
|---|--|
| 5 | Ruined Eye or Ear — -4 on Notice and ranged Strikes; permanent |
| 6 | Gut-Shot — Dying at once; survival buys a lifelong frailty |

Two Kinds of Fighting

Not every quarrel ends in a grave. A barroom scuffle, a wrestling-down, a pistol-whipping meant to subdue — declare before you roll that you strike **nonlethally**. Fists and a club do so by default; most other arms take -2 to pull the blow. A foe brought to 0 Blood this way is knocked senseless, not killed. The same mercy is rarely offered to the things that hunt at night, and is never offered to a Hexer who has gone Lost.

The Mercy of Lethality

A game where bullets are deadly is a game where players think before they draw. That is the point. Telegraph danger, let foes be talked down or fled, and make the rare gunfight matter. When a character does die, give the death its weight — a last word, a turn of silence — and let the table feel it before the next scene rides in.



"I have seen a man empty all six and hit nothing but the night, and I have seen a woman fire once and end a war. The difference was never the gun. It was the half-second she took that he did not."

— MARSHAL T. COYLE, ON THE ONLY LESSON WORTH TEACHING



XII. Nerve & the Uncanny

The mind's slow accounting, and the long road of the Mark.



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Set down, for a moment, what you were told in the first chapter, and hear the rest of it. Something kept these plains before the buffalo, before the first peoples, before the word for hunger had a mouth to say it. The settlers call the silence peace. It is not peace. It is patience — and this chapter is the accounting of what that patience does to the souls who finally hear it.

This is the heart of the game. A body can be doctored; a mind, once it has seen too far past the edge of the ordinary world, does not mend so cleanly. **Nerve** measures how much horror your character can carry before something in them gives way. The **Mark** measures how much of them the dark has already claimed. Watch both. They are the truest hit points you have.



“It stood over her the way weather stands over a valley — without face, without name, without any need of either. Elara screamed until she had no voice, and then she smiled, and that was worse. I have not slept a whole night since.”

— FROM THE SEALED TESTIMONY CONCERNING MRS. ELARA, CALVARY WELLS



The Nerve Pool

Your maximum Nerve equals your **RES score + your level** (Edges and Callings may raise it). You begin each session at your maximum. When you witness or endure the uncanny, the Keeper calls a **Dread Check**: a Will save against the Dread DC of what you face. Fail, and you lose Nerve; succeed, and you steel yourself, losing none or only a little.

The Sight	Dread DC	Nerve Lost on a Failed Save
A fresh corpse, plainly murdered	10	1
A mutilation, a thing half-eaten	13	1d4
The walking dead; a true haunting	16	1d6
A thing from outside; the deep dark	20	1d10
A truth that unmakes your world	25	1d10 + a lasting Affliction

A **critical success** on a Dread Check (beating the DC by 10, or a natural 20) costs no Nerve and steadies you against the same horror for the rest of the scene. A **critical failure** (missing by 10, or a natural 1) loses the listed Nerve and imposes *Frightened 1* at once.

Breaking

Lose Nerve and you fray. At low Nerve the Keeper may impose the **Frightened** condition — a status penalty to all your rolls equal to its value — until you steady. Reach **0 Nerve** and you **break**: roll at once on the table below for a short, uncontrolled response, and take a lasting Affliction that rides you until it is treated. A broken character is not removed from play; they are made dangerous to themselves and to those beside them.

d6	In the Moment of Breaking
1	You freeze — lose your next turn, then act Frightened

d6	In the Moment of Breaking
2	You flee, heedless, toward the nearest dark or door
3	You fire wild at the threat — and at whatever is near it
4	You go to your knees, useless, until shaken hard or slapped
5	Hysterical laughter or weeping; others nearby test Nerve too
6	A moment of terrible clarity — you understand, and gain +1 Mark

Lasting Afflictions are the scars of the mind: a phobia of the dark or the open plain, a compulsion to count or to pray, a palsy of the hands, or the *Thousand-Yard Stare* — a flatness that costs –2 on Presence and Insight until lifted. They are treated by an Alienist, a Confession, or long safe rest among people who love you, which in this country is the rarest medicine of all. (The Keeper's Book carries a full table of them.)

The Mark

Some knowledge cannot be unlearned, and some contact cannot be washed off. The **Mark** is a track of six steps. You advance it when you break utterly, when you reach for power the world was not meant to hold, or when you touch the deep dark and survive changed. The Mark does not heal on its own. It only ever waits.

Mark	What It Means
1	A chill others feel near you; dogs will not meet your eye
2	Dreams that are not yours; you wake knowing things
3	A visible sign — pale eyes, a cold touch, a wound that won't close
4	The uncanny treats you as kin; Dread DCs against you ease

Mark	What It Means
5	You hunger for something you cannot name; Will saves to resist it
6	You are Lost — the dark finishes its work; the character becomes the Keeper's

Recovering Nerve

Nerve is dear, and the ways to restore it are few:

- **Confession.** Speaking the horror plainly to someone who listens — a Preacher, a friend, a downtime scene — restores 1d6 and may ease an Affliction.
- **Safe rest.** A full night unmolested in genuine safety restores 1d6 Nerve; a week of true peace, all of it.
- **The gifts of others.** A Preacher's sermon, a Sawbones' reason, a comrade's grim joke, or a point of Grit can each buy back a measure of steadiness.
- **Whiskey and worse.** A stiff drink steadies the hand now — recover 1d4 Nerve — but lean on it and court a vice, and the Fortitude saves that come with it.

A Second Word on Safety

The horror in this game lives most in the mind — in dread, helplessness, and the dark turns a frightened character may take. Keep checking in with your table, honor every line and veil, and remember that no one's real unease is the price of a good scare. The Mark is a story tool, not a trap; a player should always know roughly where their character stands on it, and have a fighting chance to step back.



"Folk ask me what the dark wants. It don't want. Wanting is a thing the living do. The dark only keeps — patient as a ledger, and twice as honest about what you owe."

— ATTRIBUTED TO THE CONJURE-WOMAN OF CALVARY WELLS



The Taint of the Land

Some country has drunk too deep. Where a Patron of the Old Dark has been fed — a massacre left unburied, a cult's ground worked for a generation, a mine that broke into the deep dark, a thin place where the veil has worn through — the land itself takes a stain. Crops come up the wrong color. Water runs cold and tastes of iron. The dark does not haunt such places so much as *own* them, and it asks a toll of every living soul that lingers, whether they ever lay eyes on a ghost or not.

A character of any calling **save those of the Old Dark** who remains on tainted ground gathers its **Taint** — a stain measured in four steps that deepens the longer they stay. The Old Dark callings (Chapter VII) feel no such toll; the blight is kin to them, and a few grow stronger in it. For everyone else the land is patient, and the ledger runs one way only, until the ground is cleansed or the soul is claimed.

The Reckoning

For every **three days** a soul spends on tainted ground — waking or sleeping, it makes no difference — the Keeper calls a **Taint save** against the ground's DC. The save is **Fortitude** while the stain is still in the body and **Will** once it has reached the mind; the Keeper names which. Hold your save and you are no worse than you were. Fail, and your Taint deepens by one

step. A **critical failure** deepens it by two; a **critical success** sheds a step you had already taken.

The Ground	Taint DC
Soured — a hanging-tree, a salted field, blood spilled in the dark's name	13
Blighted — a cult's seat, a haunted claim, a true thin place	16
Unhallowed — a Patron's own ground, the deep dark risen into the land	20

*A ward, a charm, or the right Provision Against the Dark (Chapter X) eases the DC by 2. Ground that is blessed, salted, and watched may be held off for a while; ground that is properly **sanctified** sheds its taint for good — though the doing of it is its own long night's work.*

The Four Steps of the Stain

Taint	What the Land Does to You
1 — The Sickening	The body sours first. You are Sickened 1 and Fatigued ; food will not sit and wounds knit slow. The illness lifts a day after you quit the ground.
2 — The Whisper	It finds a voice. Whenever you would plainly cross the dark — break its work, leave its ground, warn another soul — the Keeper calls a Will save ; fail, and you hesitate, “forget,” or talk yourself onto its errand instead.
3 — The Stain	It is in you now. The penalties harden, the place reads your wants, and your dreams turn to its purpose; while you remain, Dread DCs ease for the dark and worsen for you.
4 — The Claiming	Exposed this long, you are all but owned. At each further Reckoning you make a Will save or take +1 Mark (Chapter XII) — and the Mark, once taken, does not wash off when you ride away.

Shedding the Taint

- **Distance.** Leave the ground and the stain eases one step for every three days clear of it — but a Taint that reached the Claiming leaves its Marks behind regardless.
- **Sanctuary and rite.** A Padre's blessing, a Confession, true holy ground, or the Old Rites (Chapter XIII) can each lift a step, and full sanctification on the Compass (Chapter III) clears the whole of it.
- **The Marked ride easier.** A soul already bearing the Mark eases its own Taint DC by 2 — the dark is slow to spoil what it half-owns — yet pays for that kinship in every other quarter.

For the Keeper

Taint is a clock, not a coin-toss. Name the ground, set the DC, and let the players feel the days pressing on them. Tell them plainly when a place is tainted and roughly how deep their stain has run; the dread lives in the choice to stay, never in a hidden number. Use it to give cursed country real weight — and always leave a road back out: a church, a rite, a reason to ride for clean air before the land collects what it is owed.

XIII. Signs & Old Rites

The borrowed words of the dark, and the folk-craft that holds it off.

There is power in the old country beneath the country, and it can be reached — by the Hexer freely, by the Touched a little, by the desperate at ruinous cost. **Signs** are worked acts of will and word; each lists its casting time, its price in Nerve (and sometimes Blood), the save it forces or grants, its effect, and its **Backlash** — what the dark exacts when the working slips.

*Where a Sign forces a save, the DC is the worker's **Sign DC** = 10 + half their level + RES modifier. A casting time given in Beats follows the Iron Code (Chapter XI); a Sign that takes an Action costs one Beat.*

The Stilling

1 Beat · 1 Nerve · Will save. A word and a gesture, and one living creature within sight must save or be held fast, unable to act, for 1 round per two levels. **Backlash:** on a failed working, you are stilled instead.

Witch-Sight

Free · 1 Nerve. For a scene, you see the unnatural plainly — the Marked, the haunted, the thin places. **Backlash:** what you see may also see that you see it.

The Crimson Word

1 Beat · 2 Nerve or 4 Blood · no save. You speak a syllable not meant for tongues, and a creature you can see takes 3d6 harm as its own blood turns against it. **Backlash:** on a critical failure to overcome its resistance (or a natural 1), you take the damage instead.

Hollow Step

1 Beat · 1 Nerve. You step into a shadow and out of another within sight, as far as a stone's throw. **Backlash:** a part of you arrives late — Frightened 1 until your next turn.

The Tally

Ten minutes · 2 Nerve · no save. You ask the dark a single question and receive a true, partial, and unwelcome answer. **Backlash:** the answer costs a Dread Check; deep truths gain Mark.

Salt & Iron

1 Beat · 1 Nerve. You throw a handful of blessed salt or cold-iron filings; uncanny things within ten feet must save or recoil, and the Marked feel its sting. **Backlash:** none — this is the kindest Sign, and the weakest.

Borrowed Breath

1 Beat · 3 Nerve · no save. You lend a dying companion a measure of your own life: heal them 2d8, taking half that in Blood yourself. **Backlash:** if they die anyway, you gain +1 Mark.

The Calling

One minute · 4 Nerve and 1 Mark · no save. You call something from the dark to bargain or to serve. It comes. What it is, what it wants, and whether it leaves are the Keeper's to decide. **Backlash:** the most dangerous Sign in the book; use it last, or never.

The Old Rites

Rites are folk-craft, not sorcery — anyone may attempt them with the right materials, time, and a skill check (usually Lore: Occult or Survival). They cost no Nerve, but they are slow, and failure has its own price. A **critical success** on the check doubles the protection or

duration; a **critical failure** spoils the materials and may draw the very thing you meant to ward against.

- **Calling the Rain.** An old song and a day's patience may, or may not, bring weather. The country keeps its own counsel. (DC 20, and the sky owes you nothing.)
- **Laying the Dead.** A proper burial, a true name spoken, an unfinished thing set right — and a restless spirit may rest at last. (DC by the Keeper; some dead bargain hard.)
- **Reading the Bones.** Cast and read them to glimpse one likely danger of the day ahead — vague, and never wrong in the way you hoped. (DC 15.)
- **The Sain.** A blessing over a threshold, a grave, or a frightened soul; eases the next Dread Check by 2. (DC 12.)
- **Warding Salt.** An hour and a pound of graveyard salt lay a line the uncanny is loath to cross until dawn. (Lore: Occult or Survival, DC 15.)

Who May Work the Dark

The four Callings of the **Old Dark** — Hexer, Witch, False Prophet, and Dark Cultist — work Signs by their nature, each paying in Nerve, Blood, and the slow accrual of the Mark. A character of any Calling who takes the *Hedge Magic* or *Touched Edge* (Chapter IX) knows a Sign or two and a small pool to fuel them — a worldly soul who has already paid a little. Anyone at all may attempt the **Old Rites**, for they are tradition and patience rather than borrowed power. The First Peoples' own ceremonies are *not* represented by these invented Signs and Rites; see the boxes in Chapters IV and VI.

The Callings of Faith may never work a Sign. A Preacher, Padre, Shaman, Medicine Man, or Witch Hunter draws on faith, rite, and the spirits — never on the Old Dark's borrowed words, which stand opposed to their power at the root. A faithful

Who May Work the Dark *(cont.)*

soul may *recognize* a Sign, *resist* it, *break* it, or *cleanse* what it has wrought — much of the Witch Hunter's and the Padre's trade — but they cannot speak one. Should one ever truly do so, they have set down their faith entirely, and become something else by the Keeper's hand.

The Unmarked at the Threshold

Now and again a Gunhand finds a dead Hexer's notebook, or a Drifter is taught one word by a thing that should not have spoken. A character of a **worldly** Calling — and only a worldly one — may attempt a Sign they have somehow learned, but the dark lends nothing to strangers on easy terms:

- **Backlash comes easy.** Backlash strikes on *any* result that is not a clean success — not only on the Sign's listed trigger — and the Keeper may step its severity up.
- **It costs double.** Working the Sign costs **twice its Nerve**; with no Nerve to spend, the shortfall is paid in **Blood**.
- **No proficiency.** Lacking the Signs feature, their **Sign DC** (when a Sign forces a save) is only 10 + their RES modifier — no level added.
- **The dark remembers.** On the flat check's failure, or on any Backlash, the character takes **Mark 1** (Chapter XII). A soul who makes a habit of this is no longer, in any way that matters, worldly — they have started down the Hexer's road, and the Mark will say so.
- **The mind must hold the shape.** Before the Sign manifests, make a **flat check (DC 11)**. On a failure the Nerve or Blood is spent for nothing and the working rebounds anyway.

The Unmarked at the Threshold *(cont.)*

This is meant to be rare, costly, and frightening. A Keeper is right to make a player want it badly before the dark will so much as listen.



"Every word I know that the dark answers to, I bought. Not with coin — coin it laughs at — but with a piece of the morning I used to be able to stand in. Ask yourself what you have to spend before you ask the dark anything at all."

— FROM A LETTER FOUND UNSENT, SIGNED ONLY "YOUR SISTER, WHAT'S LEFT OF HER"



XIV. Advancement

What surviving earns you, and what it does not.

You advance by living through things that should have killed you. The Keeper awards experience for danger faced, mysteries unraveled, and scenes played true — or simply marks the passing of each hard chapter with a level. Either way, growth is slow, and tenth level is a long, unlikely old age for a soul in this country.

After the manner of Pathfinder Second Edition, advancement runs on a flat tally: **every level costs 1,000 experience**. The Keeper awards experience for the dangers you survive and the mysteries you close; when your tally reaches 1,000 you gain a level and subtract 1,000, carrying the remainder toward the next.

You earn experience for...	Award
A trivial brush with danger	10
A low, manageable threat	15
A moderate, fair-matched danger	20
A severe, outmatched fight or horror	30
An extreme, should-not-have-survived ordeal	40
A story accomplishment or hard scene played true	10–30

A whole level is 1,000 experience however earned — a band climbs one level over many such awards, not many thousands. Keepers who prefer may set the tally aside entirely; see below.

What a Level Brings

- One **ability score** raised by a point at 5th and at 10th level.
- Better **attack and saves**, as your Calling's table shows — and as *Attack Rank and the Saves*, below, lets you reckon without the book.
- More **Blood**: roll your Calling's Hit Die (or take its average) and add your CON modifier.
- New **Calling features**; an Old Dark path (Bargain, Craft, Gospel, or Devotion) deepens at 3rd and 9th; the gifted learn new **Signs** at the listed levels.
- An **Edge** at 1st, 3rd, 5th, 7th, and 9th level.
- A **skill increase** at 3rd, 5th, 7th, and 9th level, raising one skill's proficiency a step (toward Expert, then Master, as your level allows).

Attack Rank and the Saves

Two of the figures on your Calling's table follow a plain rule, so you may reckon either in your head when the book is not to hand.

Attack. Every Calling holds one of three ranks, named on its statline. All three climb by one at every level. What the rank fixes is how far behind the gun Callings you stand — and that distance never grows.

Rank	Your attack	Callings
Practiced	Equal to your level	Bounty Hunter, Gunhand, Marshal, Mountain Man, Witch Hunter
Steady	Your level, less 1	Drifter, Gambler, Prospector, Sawbones, Medicine Man, Padre, Preacher, Shaman, False Prophet
Slight	Your level, less 2 (never below +0)	Hexer, Witch, Dark Cultist

Saves. Your statline names which of your three saves are strong. A **strong save is 2 plus half your level**; a **weak save is a third of your level**; both round down. Add the keyed ability on top — Fortitude (CON), Reflex (DEX), Will (RES).

A Hexer will never outshoot a Gunhand, and is not meant to. But the country's teeth grow sharper as you climb, and no soul should arrive at a tenth-level reckoning unable to hit a barn door for the sole crime of having learned to read the dark.

Milestones over Tallies

Many Keepers dispense with counting experience and simply raise the whole party a level when the story turns a corner — a survived winter, a mystery closed, a town saved or lost. This keeps the table together and the bookkeeping light. Use whichever way keeps your people leaning forward.



"They call it getting older. Out here it is only getting kept — by luck, by friends, by the dark deciding it is not done with you. Do not mistake survival for a reward. It is a stay of execution, and the court does not adjourn."

— REV. AMOS TEAGUE, A SERMON PREACHED TO FOUR GRAVES AND ONE MOURNER



A. Appendix: An Example of Play

How it sounds at the table on a bad night.



"You want to know how the game goes? It goes fine, right up until it doesn't, and then it goes very fast. Listen close to this next part."

— OVERHEARD AT A LEADWATER TABLE



*Three players sit with their Keeper. **Cassidy** plays Reverend Amos Teague, a Preacher; **Lee** plays the Drifter called Magpie; **Sam** plays Dr. Esther Vane, a Sawbones. They have followed a child's screaming to a sod house on the flats at dusk.*

Keeper: The door hangs open. Inside it's black, and the screaming stopped the moment you dismounted. There's a smell — copper and wet wool. Magpie, you're first to the threshold. Give me a Notice check.

Lee: Twelve plus five — seventeen.

Keeper: Seventeen. The dirt floor is dark and shining all the way to the back wall, and it's running *uphill*, toward a shape in the corner that's too tall to be a child. Roll me a Dread Check — Will save, DC sixteen.

Lee: ...Nine. That's a fail.

Keeper: You lose 1d6 Nerve — four. You're down to three, and you're Frightened. The shape turns its head without turning its body. What do you do?

Cassidy: I push past Magpie — gently — and hold up the book. I spend a Conviction and start the Sermon. Loud. "You are not welcome at this hearth."

Keeper: Good. Everyone who can hear you, take back Nerve equal to Amos's Presence — that's three. Magpie, you're back to six and the shake leaves your hands. The thing in the corner... flinches from the words. Esther, it's between you and the crying you can now hear again, under the floor.

Sam: Under the floor. Of course it is. I draw the derringer — that's one Beat — and I use my second to Aim. I tell Amos to keep talking.

Keeper: The derringer's a Concealable iron, so the draw and the Strike could come together if you'd rather — but Aiming first is the wiser play. Hold that +2. Amos, the Sermon's still going; the thing has not crossed the salt of the doorsill. Roll me your next round of Nerve, all of you. The floorboards are starting to lift.

Note how the dice escalate dread, how the Preacher spends a resource to buy the party's Nerve back, how the Iron Code's Beats let Esther trade speed for a steadier shot, and how the Keeper narrates mechanics as sensation — never "you take four psychic damage," always the head that turns the wrong way.

B. Appendix: Conditions

A glossary of the ways a body and mind can fail.



“There’s a hundred ways to come apart out here, and the country will show you every one if you give it the season. Best you learn their names before they learn yours.”

— DOC A. MERCER



Condition	Effect
Bleeding	Lose 1 Blood each round until stabilized
Blinded	–4 Defense, –4 most actions, lose DEX to Defense, half Speed
Clumsy	–2 on DEX-based Strikes, checks, and Defense
Drained	–2 on Fortitude and CON checks, and lose Blood equal to your level, until recovered
Dying	At 0 Blood; unconscious and Bleeding toward –CON and death
Fatigued	–2 on checks and saves; cannot Aim or run; rest to shed it
Frightened	–1 (or worse) on everything; lessens by one step each turn as you master the fear
Grabbed	Held fast; Off-Guard; –4 DEX; a check to break free
Lost	Mark 6; the character passes into the Keeper’s hands
Marked	Stepped along the Mark track; see Chapter XII

Condition	Effect
Off-Guard	–2 to your Defense; you cannot properly defend (unaware, flanked, sprawled, or caught unready)
Prone	–4 to melee; +4 to others' ranged against you; rising costs a Beat
Sickened	–2 on Strikes, damage, checks, and saves; nausea
Slowed 1	Lose one Beat each turn while it lasts; may still defend
Stunned	Drop what you hold; lose all Beats this round; –2 Defense

C. Appendix: Quick Reference

The whole machine on a single page.

The Core Roll

$d20 + \text{ability mod} + \text{proficiency} \geq \text{DC}$. Beat by 10 or a natural 20 is a critical; miss by 10 or a natural 1 is a critical failure.

Difficulty. Trivial 10 · Easy 13 · Average 15 · Hard 18 · Very Hard 20 · Punishing 25 · Beyond 30.

Abilities. STR, DEX, CON, Wits, Resolve, Presence. Modifier = $(\text{score} - 10) \div 2$, rounded down.

Saves. Fortitude (CON), Reflex (DEX), Will (RES). Base from Calling + ability.

In a Fight (the Iron Code). Initiative: a Notice check. Each turn has **three Beats**: Strike, Stride, Aim/Brace, Interact, Reload, Take Cover. Strike = $d20 + \text{attack proficiency} + \text{DEX/STR}$ vs Defense. Multiple Attack Penalty $-5/-10$ (Agile $-4/-8$). Four degrees of success; a crit applies the weapon's Fatal die.

Blood. 0 = Dying and Bleeding. Death at $-\text{CON}$. Half-max in one hit, or any crit, risks a Lasting Injury.

Grit (3 / session). Add 1d6 · reroll · shrug off a fright · stay up at 0 Blood · soften a critical failure.

Nerve. Max = RES + level. Failed Dread Check loses Nerve; 0 Nerve breaks you. The Mark has six steps; the sixth is Lost.



*"Keep your powder dry, your salt close, and your accounts with the dark paid up.
The country settles every debt in the end."*

— THE LAST LINE OF THE FIELD MANUAL, IN EVERY EDITION



D. Appendix: A Posse, Ready-Made

Six souls built and waiting, for the table that wants to ride tonight.

Character-making is a pleasure, but it is an hour's pleasure, and some nights the dark won't wait. Here are six finished souls — one from most walks of this book — built with the Honest Array and their Origin gifts, outfitted, and carrying their Four Questions already answered. Take one as written, rename it, or use it as a pattern. Any four of them make a sound posse; all six make a crowded and interesting one.

Ruth “Six-Finger” Calloway — Gunhand · the Outlaw

There is paper on her in two territories and a sixth finger of scar down her draw hand. She is faster than her reputation, which is saying something.

STR 13 (+1) · **DEX** 16 (+3) · **CON** 14 (+2) · **WIT** 10 (+0) · **RES** 12 (+1) · **PRE** 9 (−1)

Blood 12 · **Defense** 13 · **Saves** Fort +4, Ref +5, Will +1 · **Nerve** 13 · **Grit** 3

Attack +1 (guns +4 with DEX) · single-action revolver 1d8 (Fatal d10), knife 1d4

Trained: Notice, Intimidate. **Features:** Deadly Aim (−2 attack / +4 damage), Gunhand's Edge. **Edges:** Quick Draw, Steady Shot.

Gear: revolver, 40 cartridges, knife, duster, a horse she didn't pay for, \$9.

Lost: her gang, to a job gone wrong she didn't plan. **Seen:** the man she shot at Careless Creek stand back up. **Vice:** the cards. **Moving:** the paper on her, and whoever's carrying it this month.

Doc Aurelia Mercer — Sawbones · the Fallen Gentry

A surgeon's hands, a ruined family name, and a habit of talking to patients who have stopped listening. Politer than anyone this far west has a right to be.

Doc Aurelia Mercer — Sawbones · the Fallen Gentry (cont.)**STR** 8 (−1) · **DEX** 12 (+1) · **CON** 13 (+1) · **WIT** 16 (+3) · **RES** 14 (+2) · **PRE** 11 (+0)**Blood** 9 · **Defense** 11 · **Saves** Fort +3, Ref +1, Will +4 · **Nerve** 15 · **Grit** 3**Attack** +0 · knife 1d4, cap-and-ball revolver 1d8 (slow reload)**Trained:** Medicine, Lore (Occult), Notice, Deceive, Survival, Sleight, Insight, Lore (Frontier), Persuade. **Features:** Field Surgery, Anatomist. **Edge:** Frontier Medicine.**Gear:** surgeon's kit, laudanum, good coat, worn revolver, \$14 and a letter of unpaid debt.***Lost:** the name, the house, the inheritance — a scandal she will not discuss. **Seen:** a body on her table open its eyes, four hours dead. **Vice:** laudanum. **Moving:** the debt, and the man back east who holds it.**Brother Elias Crow — Preacher · the Freed**Took his freedom, took the Word, and walked west preaching to whoever the country hadn't killed yet. His voice can fill a canyon, and has.***STR** 10 (+0) · **DEX** 8 (−1) · **CON** 13 (+1) · **WIT** 12 (+1) · **RES** 15 (+2) · **PRE** 16 (+3)**Blood** 9 · **Defense** 9 · **Saves** Fort +3, Ref −1, Will +4 · **Nerve** 16 · **Grit** 3**Attack** +0 · walking staff 1d4, double-barrel shotgun 2d8 (Scatter, kept wrapped in oilcloth and prayer)**Trained:** Persuade, Intimidate, Lore (Occult), Notice, Insight. **Features:** Conviction, Sermon. **Edge:** Iron Will.**Gear:** Bible, salt, camp kit, the shotgun, \$11 and a congregation's last collection.***Lost:** his congregation, to a fire that did not behave like fire. **Seen:** what set it — and it saw him. **Vice:** pride in the Word. **Moving:** the thing that burned his church went west, and so, therefore, did he.*

Anni Halvorsen — Mountain Man · the Scout

Thirty winters in the high country and a Hawken older than most towns. Speaks four languages and prefers none of them.

STR 15 (+2) · **DEX** 11 (+0) · **CON** 14 (+2) · **WIT** 12 (+1) · **RES** 14 (+2) · **PRE** 8 (−1)

Blood 12 · **Defense** 10 · **Saves** Fort +4, Ref +0, Will +4 · **Nerve** 15 · **Grit** 3

Attack +1 · Hawken rifle 1d12 (Dead Aim +1d6), bowie knife 1d4

Trained: Survival, Notice, Athletics, Stealth, Animal Handling, Lore (Frontier), Medicine. **Features:** Hawken Rifle, Dead Aim 1d6, Hard Country. **Edge:** Tracker.

Gear: the Hawken, traps, pelts worth 2d6 × \$10, a good knife, a better dog.

***Lost:** her trapping partner, to a winter that was not a winter. **Seen:** its tracks — man-shaped, and forty feet apart.*

***Vice:** solitude, and the flask that makes it bearable. **Moving:** she is hunting it. She does not say so.*

Addison Quill — Bounty Hunter · the Veteran

Rode with the cavalry, kept the carbine, and found that hunting men paid better than soldiering and asked fewer questions he couldn't answer.

STR 13 (+1) · **DEX** 15 (+2) · **CON** 11 (+0) · **WIT** 14 (+2) · **RES** 13 (+1) · **PRE** 8 (−1)

Blood 8 · **Defense** 12 · **Saves** Fort +0, Ref +4, Will +3 · **Nerve** 14 · **Grit** 3

Attack +1 (guns +3 with DEX) · service carbine 1d10, revolver 1d8, rope and irons

Trained: Notice, Stealth, Survival, Intimidate, Insight, Lore (Frontier), Athletics, Deceive. **Features:** Bushwhack 1d6, Quick Hands. **Edge:** Cold Read.

Gear: carbine, irons, wanted papers, field glasses, \$22 of the last bounty.

***Lost:** the certainty the war promised him. **Seen:** a man he'd buried collect his own bounty in the next county. **Vice:** violence, arrived at too easily. **Moving:** one name left on a private list, and it keeps moving west.*

Opal Vance — Hexer · the Homesteader

Buried a husband and three children under sod she broke herself, and one night the country offered her a different arrangement. She took it. She is still deciding what it took back.

STR 8 (−1) · **DEX** 10 (+0) · **CON** 13 (+1) · **WIT** 14 (+2) · **RES** 16 (+3) · **PRE** 13 (+1)

Blood 7 · **Defense** 10 · **Saves** Fort +1, Ref +0, Will +5 · **Nerve** 17 · **Grit** 3

Attack +0 · kitchen knife 1d4, and the Signs she paid for

Trained: Lore (Occult), Medicine, Survival, Notice, Animal Handling, Deceive.

Features: Witch-Sight, Signs, Marked. **Signs known:** Borrowed Breath, Salt & Iron.

Sign DC 13. **Edge:** Salt-Wise.

Gear: herb satchel, salt, iron nails, charm-makings, a crow named Deuteronomy, \$6.

Lost: everything the sod could take, and then the man too. **Seen:** what answered the night she asked — she carries **Mark 1**, and knows it. **Vice:** the bargains; they keep working. **Moving:** paying it back before it comes to collect.



*“Six strangers on one stage, and every one of them lying about why. Out here
that is what we call a fair start.”*

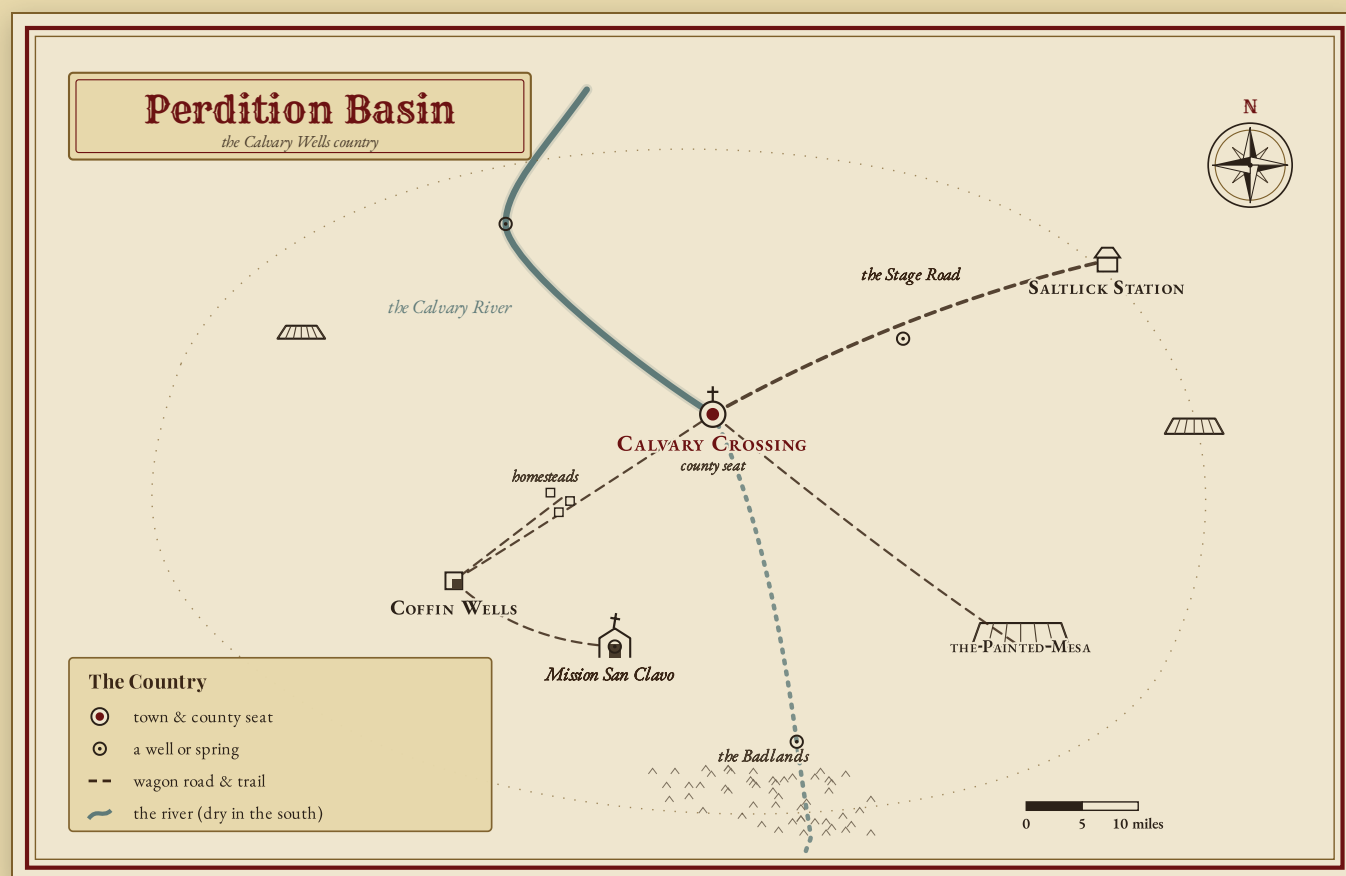
— OVERHEARD AT THE WELLS FARGO OFFICE, DRY SEASON, 1885



E. Appendix: The Country

Perdition Basin — a stretch of frontier to start your riding, drawn as a rider knows it.

Your Keeper may set you down anywhere; the country is wide. But if you want a place to begin — a map to point at and say *there, that is where we met* — here is one, ready-made. **Perdition Basin** is a hard, dry county in the territory: a bowl of grass and dust ringed by mesa and badland, its life strung along the failing Calvary River and the scattered wells that are the only sure water for a day's ride in any direction. This is the honest map — the country as any soul who has ridden it could scratch it in the dirt. What waits under it is the Keeper's business, and no concern of yours until it is.



Perdition Basin — the honest country, as any soul who has ridden it could draw it in the dirt.

What a Rider Knows

A few days' ride takes you across the whole of it. The places you will hear named:

- **Calvary Crossing** — the county seat, where the Stage Road fords the river. A marshal, a bank, a doctor, a second street, and the closest thing to safe: its well still runs sweet. Where you resupply, and where you hear the county's talk.
- **Coffin Wells** — a shrinking cattle town south and west, named for its boot-hill and its wells both. Hard luck lately; folks speak low of a fever out at the homesteads.
- **Saltlick Station** — a lonely stage relay a hard day north and east, the last roof for twenty miles when the weather turns. A meal, a bed, and a bar across the door.
- **Mission San Clavo** — a broken adobe church east of Coffin Wells, a ruin fifty years, and the oldest thing the settlers built here. The old folks still cross themselves when they pass it.
- **the Painted Mesa** — red rock in the south-east, the ground of the people who were in this country long before the mission, and who know it better than any deed-holder. Ride there with your hat in your hand or not at all.
- **the Badlands** — broken, waterless country to the south, where the river dies in the sand. People go in for shortcuts and to not be found. Some manage both.

And everywhere between, the **wells**: hand-dug, ringed with stone, the whole reason a town or a homestead sits where it does. Water is the wealth of this country, and lately — the old-timers will tell you, if you stand them a drink — some of the wells have *gone sour*. The drought, they say. Most likely it is the drought.

What Folks Say

Ride the basin a while and you will hear all of this, some of it more than once:

- “Don't water your stock at the Coffin Wells trough. Don't matter why. Just don't.”
- “The Vane bank's buying up every homestead whose well's gone bad. Paying, too. You have to wonder what a man wants with dry land.”
- “Old Padre out at San Clavo never left when the mission closed. Still out there. Folks that carry him supplies say he's digging.”
- “Railroad's coming through. That's what the powder-noise is, up in the north country. Progress, the man from the survey office calls it.”
- “My granddad rode for the Mesa people one winter. Said they've got a spring that never once went dry nor sour, and a reason they don't share the water. He wouldn't say the reason.”

A place to start, and no more than that. Everything here is true as far as a rider knows it — which in this country is never quite far enough.

~

And that concludes the matter of the country. You came to these pages, most likely, for a game about the West — and you have one: the cattle and the coin are real, the winters are honest, and the dice fall fair. But you have read this far, and so you know now what the first chapter only whispered. The almanac is therefore offered — as the survey men say — for your consideration. Keep your fire lit. Keep your accounts square. And if some evening on the long grass you find that the silence has a texture to it, you will not need this book to tell you what you have found. You will only need to decide, as every soul in these pages once decided, how much of yourself you are willing to trade to be believed.

The Ledger

A Reckoning of One Soul — Blood and Grit



NAME		CALLING		LEVEL		ORIGIN	
STRENGTH		DEXTERITY		CONSTITUTION		WITS	
Score Mod		Score Mod		Score Mod		Score Mod	
RESOLVE		PRESENCE					
Score Mod		Score Mod					
BLOOD / MAX		DEFENSE		SPEED		INIT.	
GRIT							
FORTITUDE SAVE		REFLEX SAVE		WILL SAVE			
NERVE / MAX							

THE MARK 1 2 3 4 5 6

THE FOUR QUESTIONS

What did you lose? · What keeps you moving? · What is your vice? · What have you seen?

SKILLS (MARK PROFICIENCY)☐ Acrobatics (DEX)☐ Animal Handling (PRE)☐ Athletics (STR)☐ Deceive (PRE)☐ Gamble (PRE)☐ Insight (RES)☐ Intimidate (PRE)☐ Lore: Frontier (WIT)☐ Lore: Occult (WIT)☐ Medicine (WIT)☐ Notice (RES)☐ Persuade (PRE)☐ Repair (WIT)☐ Ride (DEX)☐ Sleight (DEX)☐ Stealth (DEX)☐ Survival (RES)*EDGES, CALLING FEATURES & PATH**ARMS, GEAR & COIN*

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Every rule in its place, and the page where it waits.

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